
Romance in the Land of the Setting Sun
Book One

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Chapter 1
Rain in the Hallway

The hallway smelled faintly of rain and disinfectant, the kind of clean that clings to apartment buildings in Tokyo after a long day. Niklas turned the corner with a grocery bag and nearly walked into the white cane lying at an awkward angle across the carpet. A small figure leaned against the doorframe, breathing in thin, shivering threads.

"Rebecka?" he said, stopping so he wouldn't crowd her. "It's Niklas. From next door."

Her head tilted toward the bass of his voice. "Niklas… sorry. I— I couldn't get the key to line up." Even the apology sounded fever-bruised, fraying on the edges.

He crouched, big hands careful as he gathered the fallen cane and pressed it to her palm. "Ingen fara," he said softly. No worries. "May I help? You sound pretty sick."

A tiny nod. He slid his key ring onto his sleeve to keep it quiet, then guided her knuckles to the thumbprint pad on her lock, describing each motion before he made it. "Two steps to your left… good. Handle's vertical, now it's going horizontal—there. Door's open."

Warmth rolled out from the apartment, bringing the softer smells of laundry soap and paperbacks. Rebecka swayed. Niklas shifted his stance and offered his forearm like a railing.

"Can I hold your elbow?" he asked. "Just to steady you."

"Yes, please."

Her skin was hot where he touched it, fever heat humming through the cotton of her sleeve. He felt her trying to stand on dignity, feet careful and counting, and matched her pace in half-steps: threshold, mat, the squeak of indoor slippers. He didn't try to take the lead; he narrated quietly, turning the apartment into audio: "Shoe rack on your right. Low table ahead, sixty centimeters. Couch to your left. I'll clear the table." He set the grocery bag down without clatter.

"Water first," he added. "And I'll text Alice."

At the name, Rebecka's mouth softened with relief. "She's finishing a late shift. I didn't want to bother her."

"That's what friends are for," he said, fishing out his phone. "And neighbors. Hej, Alice—Niklas here. I found Rebecka in the hall. Fever, weak. I'll keep an eye on her till you're back. Apartment's open."

He pulled a spare mask from his jacket pocket and looped it on. Then he filled a glass and knelt so she could find it by sound; when her fingers brushed the rim, he steadied the base. She drank in slow, exhausted swallows.

"Do you think you can manage a shower?" he asked. "Steam might help. I can set everything up and wait just outside. No peeking, scout's honor."

A breath that might have been a laugh scraped her throat. "Yes. I'm chilled to the bones."

"Okay. Bathroom is straight past the couch, three meters, then the tile lip." He stood, massive in the small room, careful not to bump hanging plants or the wind chime that would give her a false landmark. "My hand's here," he said, knuckles brushing the air near her forearm. She found him, and they moved together.

Inside the bathroom he turned the tap until the pipes sang and steam edged the mirror. He explained each dial like a flight captain: "Left is temperature, right is pressure. I'm setting it warm. Shelf at shoulder height has fresh towels—I'll put one on the hook within easy reach. Shampoo is the square bottle; body wash is the pump."

He stepped back to the door and kept his voice low. “I’ll be right outside if you need anything. Take your time.”

The shower hissed to life. He used the minutes to strip the bed to crisp sheets and shake out a heavier duvet from the closet. He found a clean, oversized sweatshirt in a folded stack—soft cotton with some idol group’s logo—and laid it on the bed. On the stove, he put water on for ginger tea and set a small pot of rice to simmer; his mother’s nurse’s habits echoed in his head—fluids, warmth, simple food, clear instructions. When someone’s ill, make the environment kind.

When Rebecka called—“Niklas?”—he was already at the door. “Here,” he said. “I’ll open just a crack and pass the towel in.”

Her hand came through the steam, small and damp, and he wrapped the towel into it. “Floor mat is directly under you. Do you want me to set the sweatshirt on the stool?”

“Yes. Thank you.”

He stepped back again, listening for the soft rhythms of fabric and breath. When she emerged, hair damp and combed back, cheeks flushed with more than fever, she looked steadier. She couldn’t see the way his dark blue eyes softened, but she could hear it in the way he let his voice smile.

“Bed’s ready,” he said. “Four steps to the left, then straight ahead. I tucked the duvet open so you can slide right in.”

She found the edge by touch and folded into it with a sigh that seemed to melt the room. He placed the glass of water on the nightstand, moved it two fingers to the right when she reached for it, then tucked a small pack of tissues beside it.

“Tea coming up,” he said, and returned with the steaming mug. “Small sips. It’s just ginger and honey.”

“Smells like a hug,” she murmured, fingers wrapping the ceramic.

He checked her forehead with the back of his hand—cooler than before, but still too warm. “Do you have any meds you prefer? Paracetamol?”

“Top drawer,” she said, tapping the bedside table. He found the blister pack, read the label aloud to confirm, and handed her the correct dose with a fresh sip of water.

His phone buzzed. He angled it away so the light wouldn’t bother her. Alice: Thank you thank you! I’m on my way—twenty minutes. Can you stay till then?

He typed back: Of course.

“Do you want the room darker?” he asked.

“A little.”

He drew the curtains to a twilight hush and clicked on the small salt lamp, leaving the room warm and amber. The rain had started again outside, a soft percussion on the balcony rail.

Niklas dragged a floor cushion to the doorway so he could keep her in earshot without hovering. He set the rice to rest, poured some into a bowl, and let the steam rise like a quiet blanket in the kitchen. Every few minutes he narrated the time in a gentle way—“Ten minutes till Alice”—as if he were marking not minutes but milestones: you’re safe, you’re not alone, help is close.

“Why are you so kind?” Rebecka asked into the dim, voice already thick with drowsy edges.

He took a breath, choosing something honest and light. “I learned from home,” he said. “My dad’s probably the kindest man alive—he treats everyone like they matter. And my mom’s a nurse. From her, I learned to keep people warm, keep them hydrated, and tell them where the steps are. It sticks.”

She smiled where he could hear it. “It does.”

The lock clicked. Alice's soft hurry moved through the hallway like a breeze, shoes skidding off, bag thumping. "Rebecka?" she called, then saw him and bowed on instinct even as she moved past. "Niklas—thank you."

He rose, suddenly feeling too tall for the room. "She's had a shower, tea, paracetamol. Fever's still up but lower than before. Rice is on the stove if she wants a few bites later. I changed the bedding."

Alice's eyes shone in the lamplight. "You're a lifesaver."

"Just a neighbor," he said, embarrassed, rubbing the back of his neck. His red-brown hair darkened a little where the mist had caught it on the way in. "Text if you need anything tonight. I'm next door."

He hesitated at the door, then leaned close enough to be heard without making Rebecka stir. "I left a spare mask and some ginger on the counter," he added. "And… I'll check in tomorrow."

Alice squeezed his forearm once, gratitude warm and wordless. Rebecka shifted under the duvet, catching the tail of their whispering.

"Niklas?" she said, sleep dragging at the syllables.

"Mm?"

"Thank you for telling me where all the steps were."

He smiled where she could hear it. "All the way to bed," he said, and let himself out into the quiet hallway, the door clicking shut behind him like a promise kept.

Chapter 2
Ramen as Thank You

The packages were what did it.

All week, Alice had watched the elevator doors open and spit out brown cardboard boxes with fat, red stamps in kana. They thumped to a stop outside Niklas's door like obedient dogs: one from a specialty grocer in Sapporo, another with a smiling pig logo and "Hakata" written across the tape, thin chilled packs wrapped in silver bubble wrap that still hissed cold when you touched them.

"Ramen," Alice said now, kneeling beside the latest box and peeking at the shipping label while Rebecka held the door open. "He's been getting ramen stuff. Like, serious ramen stuff."

Rebecka's chin tipped toward the smell rising from the seam in the lid—miso, bony and sweet; sesame; something faintly woody like seaweed left to sun-dry. "It smells… cozy," she said, the soft word as tentative as a fingertip on glass. "Like the place my papá used to take me for caldo."

Hikari's phone spoke from Alice's pocket, the robotic alto smoothing each syllable like it was ironing a shirt. "[I vote we bribe the Swedish giant with soup.]"

Alice laughed and passed the phone over. "First, it's not a bribe, it's an orei. Thank-you culture. Second, I thought we were brainstorming? We had flowers, a cute letter, a mug that says WORLD'S KINDEST NEIGHBOR…"

"Flowers feel… cold," Rebecka said. "He was warm."

Hikari's thumbs moved, fast as the flicker of a moth. The phone chirped again. "[Then: warmth in a bowl. He likes ramen. We make ramen.]"

Alice looked at the boxes. At the memory of Niklas's arms guiding Rebecka gently inside on that fever-blown night, of him turning on the shower and finding towels like it was nothing, like care could be as simple as switching on a light. She inhaled, blew her bangs out of her eyes, and squared her shoulders.

"Okay," she said. "We make ramen."

In their tiny kitchen, the three of them moved like a machine that had been built out of love and improvisation.

Rebecka sat at the table with an array of spices and tare in front of her, sorted by elastic bands into little families. Her fingers learned the bottles the way her ears learned voices. The miso was heavy and cool through the plastic, the soy had a slick neck, the sesame oil sloshed with a sleepy weight. Under her touch, the kombu was sea-leathery, the katsuobushi flakes were papery and light—if she blew on them they would flutter like moth wings.

"We're not doing a sixteen-hour pork bone boil," Alice announced, tucking a strand of pink wig hair into her hoodie like it was a loose wire. "I have a shift at the café at nine tomorrow and also my landlord would murder me."

Hikari tapped. "[Shortcut is not a sin.] [We build flavor.] [Stock base, miso tare, aroma oil.]" The phone voice remained perfectly calm, but Alice could feel the excitement in the speed of Hikari's thumbs. "[I'll do the tare and aroma. You do toppings.] [Becka, taste referee.]"

Rebecka smiled. "Taste referee," she repeated, as if the title might pin like a medal to her sweater.

Alice set eggs to simmer, timing them on her watch, and sliced chicken thighs for a quick shio-chicken chashu—less traditional, maybe, but silky when braised and easy to chew. She marinated the thighs in soy, ginger, garlic, and mirin, the kitchen filling with a perfume so good Rebecka sat straighter, fists tucked under her chin like a cat catching sunlight.

Hikari worked like a chemist: kombu sliding into a pot of low-simmering chicken stock, then fished out before bitterness could gossip its way into the flavor; a handful of katsuobushi flurries tossed in and steeped; miso whisked with a bit of stock until it loosened to a glossy paste. The phone spoke the ingredients as she held each one up for Alice's camera, like a livestream that only two people were watching.

"Say ah," Alice told Rebecka, touching a spoon to her lips.

Rebecka tasted, tilted her head. "More… something like," she hesitated, searching, "the way warmth smells when it's starting to snow."

Hikari's thumbs startled into motion. "[White pepper.] [And toasted sesame.]" She measured with the confidence of someone who couldn't speak but could communicate with a kitchen.

They made aroma oil with a small mountain of minced garlic and scallion whites, coaxing them slowly in neutral oil until they were the color of weak tea and the whole room smelled like rainy days under a ramen shop awning. Alice used a spoon to drizzle the hot, fragrant oil over the miso paste, watching it bloom into a deeper gold.

Rebecka handled the menma: Alice rinsed and drained them, then guided Rebecka's hands to the pan where they'd sauté briefly with soy and a breath of sugar. The blind woman's face shifted, listening to the menma squeak and then soften, her hand steady on the handle.

"You're good at this," Alice murmured.

"I like when food talks," Rebecka said, shy and pleased. "It tells me more than the labels."

By the time the timer chimed for the eggs, the broth had body and depth without weight, and the chicken thighs were lacquered and tender. Alice plunged the eggs into ice water, cracked the shells all over like thin porcelain, and slid the shells away from whites that felt like cool skin under her thumbs. When she split them, the yolks grinned back: jammy suns.

"Scallions?" she asked.

Hikari held them up like a bouquet. The phone said, "[Green confetti.]"

Alice grinned. "You're cute."

The phone deadpanned back, "[I contain multitudes.]" Then: "[Focus. Noodles.]"

They couldn't make fresh noodles, not tonight; but among Niklas's deliveries Alice had found a brand that made the good, springy kind, the kind that snapped between chopsticks and drank broth like it was gossip. She boiled them in batches so each portion was bouncy and alive, not tragic and bloated.

Bowls warmed. Miso tare in first, then ladles of hot stock whisked until the surface gleamed. Noodles coiled like tame serpents. Sliced chicken chashu fanned like cards. Menma nested in a corner, sweet-caramel and brown. A jammy egg half seated like a sunrise. Scallions scattered. A nori sheet tucked in, a little flag.

They stepped back. The ramen was ready, steam lifting like a blessing.

It took Rebecka three slow breaths outside his door to trust the map of the hallway under her hands—the rug seam, the cool brass of the number plate, the faint draft that meant the elevator had just sighed closed. She shifted the warm ramen container against her hip and knocked.

Footsteps. The soft hush of socks on wood. The door opened on cedar-warm air and a voice she remembered even through fever haze.

"Rebecka?"

She smiled toward the sound. "Hi, Niklas. I… brought you dinner. Well—thank-you dinner. Orei." She lifted the container like an offering. Steam kissed her face.

There was a beat of surprised pleasure and then his weight moved aside from the doorway. "You walked it over yourself?"

"I wanted to," she said. "I wanted you to hear me say thank you."

He took the container from her, big careful hands mindful of heat, mindful of her fingers. "Thank you," he answered, and somehow made it sound like a promise. "Come in? So we don't make the hallway jealous."

She laughed, stepped across the threshold, and cataloged the room as it introduced itself: clean coffee on the air, a neat stack of books, a kettle somewhere that liked to murmur, the even heartbeat of a tidy place. He set the ramen down; cabinets opened, bowls found each other with a ceramic kiss. When she reached for the counter to steady herself, his palm hovered near her wrist—offering, not steering. She liked that.

"I guessed you liked ramen," she said, cheeks warm. "Your deliveries are very chatty."

"Traitors," he said, amused. "But accurate."

They ate at his small table, steam curling up to lay soft hands on their faces. He narrated the layout gently—"bowl at twelve, spoon at three, napkin by your left"—and then asked what she liked to eat in winter, and what books smelled like to her, and how music felt in her chest. The kettle sang once and was shushed with tea; the city beyond the window softened into a quiet hum. His laugh happened low and honest; her replies tripped out shy and then steadier, and somewhere between "jammy eggs are the best kind of sun" and "my dad warmed cups in the sink before soup," something unclenched in both of them.

He told her about leaving Sweden—the way the first months in Tokyo felt like being inside a song you didn't know the words to yet—and about calling his mother, the nurse, for recipes when he was homesick. She told him how paper tells her different secrets than screens, and how Hikari's phone voice can be funnier than most people on purpose.

They washed dishes shoulder to shoulder, hands bumping in the warm water. He dried and stacked as if the bowls were part of a careful puzzle. When he passed her the towel to feel the last plate—bone-smooth, perfectly dry—her fingers brushed his. He didn't pull away.

"Thank you for letting me say it in person," she murmured.

"You said it," he replied, voice even softer. "And you brought November in a bowl."

A small silence opened, not empty but expectant. She turned toward where his breath was, lifted her chin half an inch. "May I… check where your smile is?"

His chuckle was a quiet, delighted fall. "You may."

Her fingertips found the corner of his mouth, curved warm beneath them; he was taller, broader, but unexpectedly gentle under touch. She leaned in until her forehead met his chest, and he made that surprised sound again—the one that felt like a door unlocking.

They did not rush. He asked with a careful, "Okay?" when his hand rose to her shoulder; she answered with a yes that felt like stepping into light. Much later there was a kiss—unhurried, tasting faintly of miso and tea—more discovery than declaration. One thing folded into the next: the couch claimed them for another hour of talking, stories pooling and eddying; a yawn ambushed her; the clock forgot to scold.

"It's late," Niklas said at last, apology in it. "Do you want me to call Alice? Or—"

She shook her head, listening to the way the apartment breathed. "I don't want to go out into the cold again," she admitted. "Would it be terribly rude if I asked to stay? Just—sleep. I like how your place sounds."

"Not rude," he said, immediate and warm. "You can have the bed. I'll take the couch."

She laughed into his shirt. "It's your bed. Share, if you like? We can face opposite directions and be very proper and scandalize no one."

There was a smile in his answer she could hear. "Deal. Very proper."

He found her a soft t-shirt that smelled faintly of cedar and sunlight; she changed in the bathroom, fingertips reading the fabric like Braille. In the bedroom he narrated the map again—edge of the bed here, nightstand there, blanket heavier than it looks—and lay down a careful arm's length away. They talked a little more in the dark, voices pitched to the hush, then the distance shrank by mutual gravity: her hand found his, their fingers laced; his thumb made a small, absent circle on her knuckle that felt like safety.

"Thank you," she whispered once more, not for the shower or the soup anymore, but for the way he held space around her.

"Thank you for coming," he breathed back.

The apartment settled. The kettle slept. Their shared warmth leveled into one rhythm, and somewhere between a last laugh and the slow tide of breath, Rebecka drifted, with his hand still in hers and November tucked under the blankets.

Morning would arrive bright and ordinary. For now, the night held them, simple and certain.

The interrogation lamp was a ring light.

Alice dragged it to the kitchen table anyway, flicked it on to "dramatic," and squinted across at Rebecka like a detective who also owned too many wigs.

"State your name for the record," she said, pen poised over a notebook that read VERY SERIOUS INVESTIGATION in bubble letters.

Rebecka hid a smile behind her mug. "Rebecka." She paused, then added, "Very warm. Very sleepy."

Hikari sat at the end of the table with her phone in a stand, thumbs hovering. The phone's calm voice filled the room: "[And where were you between the hours of 'we brought ramen' and 'oh no it's morning']?"

Alice leaned in. "We saw your message at 07:12. 'Home soon. Everything is fine. Do not explode the apartment.' That implies that something happened which could cause an explosion."

Rebecka laughed, color rising to her cheeks. "No explosions. Just… you know when a blanket is heavy in a good way? It was like that. But a person."

Hikari typed. "[Proceed. Details. The cuddle report.]"

Alice slapped down a sticky note labeled CUDDLE REPORT. "Start with entry, proceed to couch phase, transition to bed phase. Becca, give us the squealables."

Rebecka let her fingers trace the rim of her mug, assembling the night like beads on a string. "He opened the door and sounded… glad. Not surprised in a scared way. More in a 'oh' way. His apartment smells like coffee and cedar. He told me where everything was, and when we ate, he described the bowl like a clock so I wouldn't go swimming for the egg."

Hikari's phone: "[Kitchen competence. Noted.]"

"We talked a lot," Rebecka went on. "He told me about calling his mom for soup recipes when he missed home. He laughed like—" she searched for it— "like the very first note in a song."

Alice softened, smile tugging. "That's disgustingly cute. Continue."

"After dishes, I asked if I could 'check where his smile was,'" Rebecka admitted, a little shy. "He said yes. He always asked, too. Every time he touched me he asked. 'Okay?' 'This alright?' Like he was putting bookmarks in me so I'd never lose the page."

Hikari typed without looking up. "[Consent checks: frequent.] [Green flags: many.]"

"And at some point," Rebecka said, quieter, "I was tired, and it was cold outside, and he offered the bed, and I asked to share. We were very proper." She smiled to herself. "For about five minutes."

Alice leaned forward so hard her chair squeaked. "What happened at minute six."

Rebecka's hands opened, describing the shape of a feeling. "He lay an arm's length away so I could decide. I scooted closer. He met me halfway. We laced fingers. He has… the gentlest hands for someone so big. When he held my hand, he didn't trap it. He made space around it."

Hikari: "[Describe the gentle.]"

Rebecka's voice turned fond and precise. "He kept narrating in little ways—'I'm going to shift my knee,' 'my hand is on the blanket near your shoulder'—so nothing was a surprise. He didn't rush. When I tucked under his chin, he paused like he was making sure the world had caught up. His heartbeat is steady. Like a metronome on a slow practice day."

Alice made a noise into her sleeve. "I'm going to combust. Go on."

"He stroked my hair the way you pet a cat you respect," Rebecka said. "Not pushing, just… letting me know he was there. When he kissed me, he waited for me to find him first. He tastes like miso and tea." She ducked her head. "And when I fell asleep, he kept our hands together. I know because every time I shifted, he squeezed once, like 'I'm here.'"

Hikari typed. "[Protective softness: confirmed.] [10/10 would allow him to guard the last dumpling.]"

Alice scribbled furiously, then flipped the notebook around. It read: HE ASKED. HE LISTENED. HE WAS WARM. "This is my thesis," she declared. "Your Swedish giant is a certified Gentle Creature."

Rebecka exhaled a small, happy sound. "In the morning he apologized for snoring, which I did not hear, made me tea, and offered to walk me to the elevator. He… didn't try to keep me longer. He let me decide when goodbye was."

Hikari: "[We approve.] [Also: I told you his voice was safe.]"

Alice's eyes narrowed playfully. "Follow-ups. Did he say he wants to see you again?"

Rebecka smiled, a slow sunrise. "He said, 'If you ever need anything, I am next door.' And I said, 'So am I.' And then he said he'd start ordering extra noodles."

Hikari's phone emitted a triumphant little chirp. "[Ship launched.] [Sturdy hull.]"

Alice reached across the table and squeezed Rebecka's fingers. "We're happy for you, bebé. And also, as your chaotic older sister figure, I reserve the right to interrogate him gently about intentions while wearing a maid outfit, because that is my only formalwear."

Rebecka laughed. "Please don't scare him."

"I will be so normal," Alice lied, then waggled the pen. "Action items! One: you text him later—something low-pressure, maybe a photo of a very self-satisfied egg captioned 'thinking about soup.' Two: we assemble a Care Kit for when he gets homesick—cloudberry jam, a silly little Dala horse keychain, and a handwritten Braille note so he has to learn to read your secret code."

Hikari: "[Three: movie night soon. At his place. We bring soft blankets. He brings extra noodles.]"

Rebecka tucked her chin, cheeks warm again. "I'd like that."

Alice clicked off the ring light and leaned back, satisfied. "Interrogation complete. Verdict: gentle, caring, and entirely keepable."

The phone added, "[Case closed.]" Then, after a beat: "[Open for sequels.]"

Rebecka lifted her mug like a toast. "To sequels," she said, and let herself imagine the next chapter: the kettle singing, the second blanket, the steady metronome heartbeat, and the kind voice making space around her in the dark.

Chapter 3
A Different Kind of Date

The apartment smelled faintly of ginger and detergent—the signature of Rebecka's careful cleaning. She sat cross-legged on the couch, white cane folded beside her, listening to the kettle click off. Niklas set three cups on the table and took the spot next to her. Hikari curled into the beanbag by the window, hoodie sleeves pooled past her fingertips. Her phone rested in her lap, the text-to-speech app open like a waiting mouth.

Rebecka found Niklas's hand and laced their fingers. "I've been thinking," she said, steady but soft. "About us. About Hikari."

Hikari's thumbs moved. A warm, contralto voice from her phone: "Uh-oh. Family meeting."

Rebecka smiled. "Kind of." She turned toward the soft rustle that told her where Hikari was. "You're my oldest friend. I've always tried to protect you. Sometimes… I overdo it."

The phone spoke after a few quick taps. "You mean… you baby me."

"I do." Rebecka breathed out. "You're a grown woman. I want people to treat you like it. I want him to treat you like it." She lifted their joined hands. "Niklas is… good. You know that."

Niklas swallowed. He could feel the weight of it in his shoulders—the trust being placed there. "I hear you," he said. "And I care about both of you. But I won't do anything unless you want it, Hikari. And we set clear boundaries together."

Hikari's mouth tilted into a half-smile. Her thumbs danced. The phone's voice emerged slow, deliberate: "I want a real date. Doors held because you think I'm dazzling, not fragile. I want you to ask me what I want—and believe me when I tell you."

Rebecka's grip tightened, then relaxed. "Then… I'd like you to go out with him, Hikari. Tonight, if you want. And if it feels right, you can stay the night." Her voice trembled on 'right,' but she held steady. "Only if you both feel safe."

Hikari tapped. "Compersion looks good on you," the phone teased. Then, a second message, gentler: "Thank you, Becca."

Niklas met Rebecka's sightless gaze anyway, letting the silence say everything before he said anything. "We'll message you when we head back," he promised. "And if either of us says stop, we stop. No questions, no pressure."

"Good," Rebecka said, and reached across to squeeze Hikari's sleeve.

✦

They chose a quiet kissaten two streets over, all wood paneling and the clink of porcelain. Niklas held the door—not because it was heavy, but because he wanted to. Hikari stepped through without ducking her head, chin lifted, the faintest hint of lipstick darkening her mouth.

He didn't order for her. He asked. "What sounds good?"

Hikari typed, then turned the phone so he could watch the words become a voice: "The anmitsu. And coffee. Black. Don't look at me like that; I contain multitudes."

"Black coffee and anmitsu is a power move," he said, grinning.

They spent an hour playing a game she ran on her phone—silent multi-choice chaos where he had to guess her answers before the narrator revealed them. Favorite season? "Autumn," he said. The phone:

“Autumn.” Favorite kind of storm? “Dry thunder.” The phone: “Dry thunder.” Thing she wishes people stopped assuming? He hesitated. “That you need permission to want things.”

The phone’s voice was quieter this time. “Yes.”

Outside, evening slipped in like ink wicking through paper. They walked the alley that smelled of rain even when it hadn’t, past a shuttered record shop and a ramen place closing early. At a crosswalk, the world went red. Hikari typed: “I’d like your hand.”

He offered it without comment, palm open. Her fingers slid into his.

✦

Back at his place, he set a glass of water on the low table and left the hallway light on, a soft amber. He didn’t touch her first. He sat, knees apart, hands on his thighs, and waited the two seconds it took for her to see that the waiting was intentional.

Hikari lifted the phone. “House rules?” the speaker asked.

“Talk honestly,” he said. “Ask for what you want. Change your mind anytime. We check in often. We laugh if something’s awkward. We’re careful. And we keep this ours—no one else’s business—unless you want to share.”

Hikari typed. The phone spoke each line with a slow dignity that felt like a vow:

“I want to be kissed like you’ve been meaning to all night.

I prefer lights dimmed, not dark.

I choose how we pace it.

If I put the phone down, you wait until I pick it up or sign.

My safeword is ‘white noise.’

I want you to call me beautiful, not cute.”

Niklas nodded after each. “Deal,” he said.

She placed the phone on the table, screen up, and then touched his jaw—a featherlight press of knuckles. He waited for the sound. The phone: “Now.”

They kissed—slow, careful, present.

The kiss was a conversation they had been having all night. It started with his quiet permission at her door, continued through his careful narration of the kissaten, and deepened over ramen and shared secrets. Now, the conversation shifted.

The kissing changed. It was no longer a question of “can I?” but a statement of “I am.” It became deeper, more deliberate. His hands, which had been respectfully on her waist and back, began to explore with a new intent, tracing the curve of her spine, the line of her shoulder. Her own hands, which had rested on his chest, slid up to tangle in his hair, pulling him closer, a silent, urgent plea for more.

Clothes became a question to be answered.

He paused, just for a heartbeat, pulling back enough to create a sliver of space between them. His dark blue eyes, usually so gentle, were now intense, searching. He didn't ask with words. He just held her gaze, giving her the power to stop this, to slow it, to change its course entirely.

Hikari answered.

She lifted her phone. Her thumbs flew across the screen, and then she turned it to him. The word was simple, stark, and absolute.

Yes.

He let out a breath he hadn't realized he was holding and closed the distance again, his lips finding hers with a renewed hunger. But the pause had done its work. It had reset the dynamic. He was not taking; he was receiving. And she was not giving; she was bestowing.

He asked often. She answered often.

"Is this okay?" he murmured against her neck, his fingers toying with the clasp of her choker.

TTS (from the phone on the nightstand): "Yes."

He unhooked it, his knuckles brushing her throat, and set it carefully on the nightstand like a piece of sacred jewelry.

His hands went to the hem of her shirt. "May I?"

TTS: "Please."

He lifted it over her head, his gaze reverent as her skin was revealed to the dim, moody light of the room. He didn't stare; he appreciated. He learned her with his eyes the way she learned the world with her hands.

He undressed her slowly, piece by piece, asking for permission for each new layer of skin revealed. She answered with her phone, with a nod, with the arch of her back, with the soft sigh that escaped her lips. The night moved like a conversation neither of them had rushed to have but both had wanted to finish.

When they were both bare, he laid her down on the bed, the velvet comforter a soft cloud beneath them. He covered her body with his, not with his weight, but with his presence. He entered her slowly, his eyes locked on hers, watching for any flicker of hesitation. He found none. He only found a deep, unwavering trust that humbled him.

He began to move, and she met him, thrust for thrust. It wasn't frantic or wild. It was a slow, deep, rhythmic dance. It was the physical manifestation of the quiet understanding they had built all night. His restraint was a gift to her, and her openness was a gift to him.

The room was filled with the sounds of their passion—the soft slap of skin, the ragged sound of their breathing, the low, guttural groans that escaped his lips, and the soft, breathy cries that escaped hers. But above it all was the sound of the phone's TTS, a steady, rhythmic presence that guided them, grounded them, and made their union uniquely theirs.

TTS: "Faster."

He obliged, his hips snapping forward with a little more force.

TTS: "Slower."

He slowed his pace, his strokes becoming long and deep, drawing out the pleasure.

TTS: "Touch me."

He reached between them, his fingers finding her clit, stroking it in time with his thrusts.

TTS: "Don't stop."

He didn't. He drove them both toward the edge, his movements becoming more erratic, his control finally fraying as her inner muscles clenched around him, her body convulsing in a powerful orgasm. He followed her over the edge with a hoarse cry, his own release ripping through him, his hot cum filling her.

They collapsed together in a tangle of limbs, their bodies slick with sweat, their breathing ragged. He held her close, his face buried in her hair, his heart hammering against his ribs. For a long moment, the only sound was their shared breathing, slowly returning to a normal rhythm.

He propped himself up on an elbow, being careful not to put his full weight on her. In the dim light, he could see the soft, contented look on her face. Still, he had to ask. He had to know.

He brushed a damp strand of hair from her forehead, his touch impossibly gentle. "Was that okay for you?" he whispered. The question wasn't about performance; it was a quiet, vital check-in, a final confirmation that the conversation they had started with their bodies had ended well for both of them.

A small, tired smile touched her lips. She reached for her phone on the nightstand. Her thumbs moved, and the phone's voice filled the quiet room, soft and certain.

TTS: “More than okay. It was perfect.”

Relief washed over him, so potent it felt like a second wave of pleasure. He leaned down and kissed her, a slow, deep kiss that was full of everything he felt but couldn't put into words.

TTS: “Stay.”

He didn't answer. He just held her tighter, a silent promise that he wasn't going anywhere. He had come to her room as a guest, but he was leaving as a devoted partner, a man who had found a new way to love, and a new world to cherish.

✦

Morning came with the soft hiss of the kettle and the faint ache of smiling too much. Hikari sat at the edge of the bed in one of his shirts, knees drawn up, phone in her palm. He came in with two mugs.

“Milk?” he asked.

She typed. “A little. And… good morning, handsome.”

He laughed, startled and happy. “Good morning, beautiful.”

They drank in companionable quiet. Then Hikari’s thumbs moved. “I felt seen,” the phone said. “Not managed.”

“Good.” He reached out, then stopped halfway, the old habit of caution. “May I?”

She nodded and he tucked a stray strand of hair behind her ear.

A message buzzed on her phone—Rebecka. Hikari held it out so he could read the screen reader’s haptic pattern. Then she typed back with a small smile; the app said, “We’re okay. Coffee level: ideal. I’ll be home by lunch.”

“Tell her I’ll bring soup later,” Niklas said.

Hikari typed, then added her own line. The phone spoke in that warm voice: “Also tell her… thank you, for trusting me. For trusting us.”

Niklas looked at the sunlight edging the curtain and felt the shape of the night settle into something like a promise. “We’ll keep earning it,” he said.

Hikari set the phone down and reached for his hand again. No translation needed.

The living room had been staged with theatrical menace: a single lamp angled like an interrogation spotlight, a notebook labeled CASE FILE: NIKLAS, and a plate of melonpan placed just out of reach. Alice had even put on a frilly black maid headband like a judge’s wig.

“Sit,” she said, pointing at the cushion opposite the coffee table.

Niklas sat. He raised a hand. “May I at least have a melonpan?”

“Not until we establish your alibi,” Alice replied, deadpan. She clicked a pen. “State your name, occupation, and intent with the women of this apartment.”

“Uh—Niklas Andersson. Systems developer. Intent: clear, honest, long-term, and very fond.”

From the couch, Rebecka hid a smile behind her knuckles. Her white cane rested by her knee. Hikari had taken the beanbag throne with her phone in her lap; the text-to-speech app waited like a co-counsel.

Alice leaned forward. “First question. Did you make Hikari feel small?”

Hikari’s thumbs moved first. The phone spoke in a calm, velvety alto: “No. He made me feel tall.”

Alice’s shoulders softened a single centimeter. “Noted.” She looked back at Niklas. “Follow-up: How many check-ins did you do?”

“Plenty,” he said. “Before, during, and after. We set rules. We stuck to them.”

Rebecka turned toward the sound of his voice, picking up the micro-pauses she now recognized as his care. “Did you ever push past a ‘maybe’?”

“Never,” he said. “We only moved on yeses.”

Hikari typed. “He asked often. I liked that.”

Alice chewed the inside of her cheek, scribbling in the notebook. “Okay. New line of inquiry: What do you love about Rebecka?”

Niklas blinked, blindsided—and then it was easy. “Her steadiness. The way she listens like silence is a gift, not a gap. Her stubborn kind heart. The way her laugh lands in the room and stays.”

Rebecka’s lips parted with a little inhale. Alice coughed suspiciously, like something had gotten in her eye. “Tch. Fine answer,” she muttered, writing, writing.

Hikari tapped. The phone spoke: “Question from the bench: What did you learn about me?”

“That you like black coffee and anmitsu because contradictions are fun,” Niklas said, smiling. “That you enjoy being asked instead of guessed. That ‘cute’ is not what you want to be called unless you decide it is. And that you’re very good at games where I have to guess you.”

The phone: “Sustained.”

Alice flipped the page. “Final exhibits.” She slid a small basket across the table. Inside: three woven bracelets—red, blue, and black—tied off with neat little knots. “Evidence of intention,” she said. “Red for Becca. Blue for Hikari. Black for me. Before you ask: I made them. No symbolism beyond ‘we’re talking openly now.’”

Niklas eyed the black one, then Alice. “And where does ‘me’ fit in this case file?”

Alice set the pen down. The playful edge softened into sincerity. “I fell for Hikari first,” she said, voice low. “I still fall every day. I’m protective because the world is careless with her. But last night I watched you not be careless. And… I’ve also gotten to know you. You’re a good man, Niklas. Annoyingly so.”

Rebecka reached across and found Alice’s wrist, grounding her. “I trust him,” she said simply.

Hikari typed. The phone’s warmth filled the space. “So do I. And Alice,” it added after a beat, “you get to want things for yourself.”

Alice laughed once, shaky. “I do,” she said, looking from Hikari to Rebecka, then to Niklas. “So here’s me wanting something. If everyone’s comfortable, I’d like a date. With you.” She tugged at the headband, sudden sheepishness. “Not because I need to test you. Because I want to see who you are with me.”

Niklas exhaled a breath he didn’t realize he was holding. “I’d like that,” he said. “Very much.”

Rebecka straightened, courtroom-serious. “Let’s make it official. Roles, boundaries, and a dinner plan.” She ticked them off on her fingers. “One: Niklas is my partner. Two: After last night and today’s… audit,” she smiled, “Hikari is also your partner—if she wants that word.”

Hikari typed without looking down. The phone purred: “I want that word.”

“Three,” Rebecka continued, “Alice and Niklas will go on a first date. Four: We keep talking. No secrets about big feelings. Five: We check in weekly.” She tilted her head toward Hikari. “Hika?”

Hikari typed. “Add: All dates visible on the shared calendar. Green dot for solo, gold for polycule. Consent can be revoked anytime, no explanations required. And… honorifics are optional, but I enjoy ‘beautiful’.”

Alice saluted with the pen. “Calendar it is.”

Niklas nodded, a hand over his heart. “Agreed to all of it.”

Alice slid the black bracelet across to him. “Then accept Exhibit C and ask me out properly, Swede.”

He took the bracelet, the thread warm from her hand, and tied it on. “Alice,” he said, a little formal, a little amused, “would you like to go out with me this Saturday? There’s a late ramen pop-up near the river and a tiny gallery with an exhibit on retro game pixel art.”

Alice’s grin was sunlight. “Yes,” she said, then wagged a finger. “But you’re not allowed to call my outfit ‘cute.’”

“Stunning?” he offered.

“Better.”

Rebecka reached for the blue bracelet and tied it around Hikari’s wrist with deft fingers, then offered her own to Niklas. He looped the red onto her with a careful knot. In the quiet that followed, the room felt larger, as if walls had moved to make space for the new shape of them.

Hikari’s thumbs moved one last time. “Group hug?” the phone asked, teasing.

Alice set the notebook aside. “Overruled,” she said, standing. “It’s mandatory.”

They folded into each other—Rebecka’s steady center, Hikari’s soft shoulder against Niklas’s chest, Alice’s headband poking someone’s cheek until they laughed and shifted. When they parted, the lamp no longer looked like a spotlight; it looked like a warm moon in a small, brave sky.

Alice picked up the notebook and, with a flourish, wrote the conclusion across the page, reading aloud as she penned it: “Case closed. Verdict: We proceed with joy.” She dotted the final ‘i’ like a tiny star.

“Also,” she added, tapping her phone to set a reminder, “Saturday, nineteen-hundred hours. Ramen, river, pixels. Dress code: ‘stunning.’”

Niklas squeezed Rebecka’s hand, then Hikari’s, then held out a pinky to Alice. She hooked it with a smirk.

“Welcome to the docket, counselor,” she said.

“Happy to serve,” he answered—and meant it.

Alice opened the apartment door and forgot, briefly, how to breathe.

Niklas filled the hallway like a well-kept secret: black suit cut sharp at the shoulders, midnight waistcoat, a soft charcoal shirt with the top button open to show a line of pale throat. His hair was brushed back, a clean strike of raven; the crescent moon glinted from his left ear, the Celtic loop from his right. On his right hand, a silver claw hugged his index finger, jointed and wicked; on his left, a scatter of gold and silver bands caught the light when he lifted a single dark rose.

“For the lady,” he said, a little amused, a little reverent.

Alice glanced down at herself—lace choker, black silk blouse tucked into a pleated skirt with subtle embroidery, sheer tights, boots that made perfect promises—and decided breathing could wait. “Okay,” she said, accepting the rose, “that’s… illegal.”

He smiled; the scar of humor touched his mouth. “Do I pass ‘stunning’?”

“You demolish it.” She took half a step closer, eyes flicking to the claw. “Hands where I can see them—wow.”

“Fashion,” he said lightly. “And a reminder to be gentle.” He flexed the silver joint; it clicked with delicate menace.

She locked the apartment, slipped her hand into the crook of his arm, and let herself be walked into the night like a secret was being escorted.

✦

The ramen pop-up was exactly where Rebecka had said it would be: under a low bridge near the river, paper lanterns swaying, steam making halos in the autumn air. They stood at a high table and slurped noodles with serious devotion.

"Spice level?" Niklas asked.

"Five," Alice said, eyes gleaming.

He raised a brow. "Bold."

She pointed her chopsticks at his earrings. "Not the only one making choices tonight."

They traded bites, then traded truths. He talked about code the way artists talk about light. She confessed that the maid café was a steady paycheck and a stage, but the sewing room was church. He asked about the first time she recognized Hikari in a crowd; she told him it was the tilt of a laugh and the stillness between words. He told her he'd never understood the beauty of quiet until Rebecka taught him how to listen.

"Ground rule check?" Niklas asked, setting down the spoon. "I'd like to hold your hand again."

Alice held it out. The silver claw rested cool and careful against her knuckles, the other rings warm as skin. "Approved."

They tossed the bowls and stepped into the river breeze, walking without hurry. The city purred around them: tires, water, a bicycle bell, the far-off yip of a dog. Alice hooked her finger through one of his rings and tugged him toward the footbridge.

"Photo?" she asked, holding up her phone.

He angled so the lanterns framed them. "Send it to the group?"

"Of course." She snapped one smiling, one mock-severe, one where she stood on tiptoe and he dipped until their foreheads touched, the moon earring a small scythe in the shot. She sent the collage to Hikari and Rebecka with the caption: Counsel meets Goth Council. Hikari heart-reacted immediately. Rebecka sent a single star.

✦

The retro pixel-art gallery was a third-floor walk-up with creaking boards and the sort of curator who looked like a friendly crow. They wandered through sprites and skylines, pausing at a backlit piece that rendered a city in four colors and a thousand tiny promises.

"It's like longing learned to hold still," Alice said.

Niklas tilted his head, studying her more than the piece. "You see so much."

"Mostly I choose what to see," she corrected gently. "Which is the same thing, if you do it on purpose."

They played a tiny cabinet game in the corner: two buttons each, a pair of wire-tethered joysticks. Alice beat him twice on reflexes; he beat her once on patience. When they left, the curator pressed a pixel-heart sticker into their palms and said, "For luck."

On the stairs, Niklas paused. "Can I kiss you?"

She took a heartbeat to savor the want in the question. "Yes. Here, against the echo."

He set a hand at her waist, the claw angled away, the other cupping her jaw with unshowy care. The kiss landed warm, precise, a slow hello that didn't presume to be a yes to anything else. When they parted, she thumbed the chain of the crescent moon and smiled. "You kiss like you respect gravity."

"I try to keep us both upright," he said.

"Keep doing that," she murmured.

✦

The night found its second wind at a late arcade lit like an aquarium. They took turns wrecking each other in rhythm games, laughing breathless when she trounced him at a song she'd choreographed for a con five years ago. He reclaimed honor at a claw machine—fittingly—coaxing a plush bat into the chute with surgeon's patience.

"For your familiar," he said, presenting it. "Name him?"

She thought for a beat. "Objection," she said, then snorted at herself. "No, wait—Night Court."

"Night Court it is."

From there: a tiny coffee bar that still ground beans after midnight; a rooftop nobody fully owned anymore where the city spilled itself at their feet; a convenience store picnic on a bench (onigiri, melon soda, Pocky, the universal language). At each stop, he checked in without making it into a test. At each stop, she found new ways to say yes without making it a promise of forever.

"Temperature okay?" he asked on the rooftop, offering his suit jacket.

She let him drape it over her shoulders. It smelled like cedar and something colder. "You're absurd," she said softly.

"I've been accused," he said.

They sat, knees touching, talking the kind of talk that eats time without remorse: the first album that broke you open, the teacher who saw you early, the one thing you'd teach your sixteen-year-old self if you could send a postcard through time. When silence came, it wasn't empty; it was a soft animal that climbed into their laps and purred.

Her phone buzzed. A message from Hikari: a photo of Rebecka asleep on the couch, white cane propped like a banner, Hikari's caption voice replying through the speaker when Alice tapped it: "She says, 'Have fun. Tell him I'm stealing his soup tomorrow.'"

Alice typed back a heart and a bat, then tucked the phone away. "We have a family," she said, surprised at how steady it came out.

"We do," he agreed, simple as a sunrise.

✦

At four in the morning, they ended up back at his place for tea and warm socks—because rookies forget how autumn bites at the ankle at dawn. He set a tray down: two mugs, honey, cut apple, a tiny dish of salt for the apple because he swore by it.

"House rules?" she asked, echoing Hikari on purpose.

"Talk honestly," he said, smiling, "ask for what you want, change your mind anytime. And we laugh if something's awkward."

She sipped and weighed the moment. The night had been a long yes to being known. She wanted the rest of the yes—but she also wanted to remember every inch of this, not blur it with sleep-starved haste.

"I want to keep kissing," she said. "I want to keep you. I don't want to rush the first time we sleep together."

He looked relieved in a way that made her proud of both of them. "I'd like all of that," he said. "And to walk you home at dawn."

They did both. Kissing unraveled into laughter when the silver claw tapped her collar by accident and she mock-scolded it like a misbehaving pet. He took it off and set it gently on the table—"Time-out," he told it—then kissed her forehead like a vow.

They left just as the sky began to dilute, the city rinsed in that shy blue that belongs to early risers and late returners. He kept pace half a step slow so she set it. At her building, he touched the bell by the door with his left hand, rings catching the newborn light.

"Saturday again?" he asked. "Or sooner, if we trip over a weekday."

She toyed with the crescent moon, just once. "Sooner. Let's accidentally find Wednesday."

"Done." He tipped his head. "May I text the photo to my parents' group chat and say, 'Met someone wonderful'?"

"You absolutely may," she said, surprised by the sudden sweet heat in her chest. "Tell them I make an excellent soup-stealer accomplice."

He laughed, and she decided she wanted to keep earning that sound.

"Walk me up?" she asked.

"Gladly."

At her door, she turned, rose on her toes, and kissed him like a period at the end of a very good sentence. "Thank you for the night," she said.

"Thank you for the yes," he returned.

She slipped inside and leaned against the door, listening to the hallway quiet. On the other side, she heard his footsteps retreat, steady, unhurried, like someone who trusted the next time was already on the calendar.

Alice texted the group a single line before bed: Verdict upheld. Night Court adjourned at sunrise.

He arrived with takeout and contrition—well, croissants—which Alice declared admissible as evidence. The apartment smelled like coffee and laundry; morning sun sliced the room into neat gold rectangles.

Hikari had arranged the "court" again: lamp angled like a spotlight, CASE FILE: WEDNESDAY taped over yesterday's NIKLAS, and three chairs in a row like a tribunal. Rebecka sat centered, cane across her knees; Hikari occupied the beanbag throne with her phone ready; Alice wore pajama shorts, an oversized tee, and the expression of a cat who knows the verdict already.

"Proceedings begin," Alice intoned, banging a wooden spoon against a mug.

Niklas set the box down and raised his palms. "I'd like to enter croissants into the record."

"Motion to accept," Rebecka said, amused.

Hikari's thumbs flickered. Her phone's warm alto: "Sustained. Buttering during testimony is allowed."

They ate first—because civilization—and then the questions began.

"Report," Rebecka said gently, turning her face toward the rustle of Alice's sleeve. "How did you feel when you got home?"

Alice swallowed a flaky bite and, for once, let the joke go unmade. "Soft," she said. "Seen. Like we let the night be big without making it heavy."

Hikari typed: "Any moments you didn't like?"

"Only when the silver claw tried to mount a rebellion." Alice pointed the wooden spoon at Niklas, mock stern. "It tapped my collarbone like a tiny villain."

"Claw is in time-out," he said solemnly. "We discussed its conduct."

Rebecka hid a smile. "Check-ins?"

"Constant," Alice said. "Easy. He asked to hold my hand. He asked to kiss me. He asked if he could send the photo to his parents' chat with the caption 'Met someone wonderful.'" She glanced down, suddenly shy. "He did."

Hikari's thumbs danced. The phone: "And boundaries?"

"We kept the night on 'sweet' and saved 'spicy' for another time," Alice said. "On purpose."

Rebecka nodded slowly, letting the rhythm of everyone's breathing tell her what words couldn't. "Niklas?" she asked. "What did you learn about Alice?"

He didn't rush. "She sees by choosing," he said. "She likes her storms with neon and her quiet with company. She stitches honesty into everything—costumes, conversations. And she wants to savor more than she wants to conquer."

Alice blinked fast. "Objection," she muttered, eyes brighter. "Overruled."

Hikari typed. The speaker softened. "Any red flags?"

"None," Alice said. "Just… green. And one purple—because the outfit. But that's fashion."

"Noted," Rebecka said, smile audible now.

Alice flipped a page on the CASE FILE with theatrical flourish. "Final inquiry to the accused." She looked at Niklas, humor gentled into sincerity. "Can you hold all three of us without setting any of us down?"

He took that in like a charge, not a trap. "By talking often," he said. "Calendar visible. Check-ins weekly. I won't assume overlap without asking. If needs collide, we solve it in daylight, not at midnight. And I'll keep earning the word 'partner'—individually, not by copy-paste."

Rebecka set the wooden spoon aside and straightened. "Then I move we formalize."

Hikari typed: "Motion: Promote Alice to 'partner.' Structure: We keep our V's and triangles honest. Consent revocable anytime. Shared calendar colors unchanged—green solo, gold polycule. Add a tiny bat emoji for date nights that include arcade games."

Alice snorted. "Night Court approves."

Rebecka tilted her head toward Niklas. "Will you accept a third bracelet ceremony?" she asked, fond. "Symbolism is nothing without snacks, but we do have croissants."

"I accept," he said softly.

Alice darted to her room and returned with a thin black ribbon threaded with a tiny silver bead shaped like a crescent. "I was going to save this," she said, suddenly bashful. "But, um. Exhibit D."

She tied it around his wrist beside the black woven band she'd given yesterday. Her fingers trembled; he stilled his own, the rings warm against her knuckles.

Rebecka reached for his other hand and retied the red band she'd worn overnight onto him with a deft, certain knot—"So you don't forget who keeps the soup schedule in this house," she teased.

Hikari extended her arm; Niklas reknotted the blue she'd given him, then held out his wrist so she could tap the bracelet twice—her private yes. She typed one-handed, and the phone spoke like a seal pressed into cool wax:

"Verdict: Niklas is my partner.

Verdict: Niklas is Rebecka's partner.

Verdict: Niklas is Alice's partner.

Verdict: We proceed with joy."

Alice whooped and banged the spoon again. "Case closed!"

Rebecka reached across the coffee table, found Niklas's sleeve, and tugged him into the center. They folded into a hug engineered by committee: Rebecka steady at his heart, Hikari under his left arm, phone pressed to her chest like a purring cat, Alice slotted at his right with her forehead tucked beneath his chin. The bracelets bumped lightly—red, blue, black—like a code they all knew.

When they parted, Alice flicked the shared calendar open. "Administrative matters," she said, faux-brisk. "Tonight is a gold dot: celebratory dinner at home. Tomorrow: green dot, Niklas–Rebecka

braille-cookalong. Friday: green dot, Niklas–Hikari quiet movie with captions and anmitsu. Saturday: chaos TBD."

Hikari typed: "Add 'Sunday: pajama brunch. Agenda: nothing.'"

"Seconded," Rebecka said.

Niklas looked at the three of them—their different ways of looking back—and let that grateful shock move through him again, bright as morning. "I'll keep earning this," he said.

Alice tossed him the wooden spoon. "Good," she grinned. "Because you're on pancake duty, partner."

He caught it, saluted with unnecessary gravitas, and headed for the kitchen. Behind him, the tribunal devolved into music selection arguments and a heated debate over whether pancakes count as dessert or breakfast. (Both, Hikari's phone declared. "Sustained," Rebecka added.)

And just like that, the apartment adjusted around its new shape—still theirs, only roomier—while the smell of butter and sugar rose like a promise.

Morning begins with smoke—and laughter.

Pancakes are still black magic to Niklas. He stands at the stove with a sacrificial skillet and a look of Nordic determination, bracelets glinting as he flips another charcoal disk. The smoke alarm considers its options.

"Cease and desist," Alice declares, fanning the sensor with a magazine. "We do not summon breakfast by cremation."

Hikari's thumbs patter. Her phone's warm alto: "Rebranding them as 'cookie-crêpes.' Serve with dignity."

Rebecka pads in, cane tapping, hair in a loose braid. She sniffs, then grins. "Mmm. Notes of campfire. And… regret." She finds Niklas's elbow and squeezes. "Trade you. I'll toast bread; you slice fruit."

Deal. Breakfast becomes yogurt, fruit, toast, and exactly one honorary 'cookie-crêpe' split four ways for the comedy. They eat at the little table under the window while the city warms up outside.

"Daily stand-up?" Alice asks, opening the shared calendar—green dots, gold dots, a tiny bat emoji on arcade nights.

Niklas (WFH) lists his: standup at nine, feature branch by lunch, code review by four. Rebecka has a study block at the library—cataloging practice with a volunteer mentor—and an afternoon mobility lesson. Hikari types: "Stream at two, edit at five. Theme: 'Gothic tea party does your taxes.'" Alice snorts; her own lineup is café shift noon to six and a late sewing sprint for a commission.

"Check-ins on the hour?" Niklas offers.

"Every other hour," Rebecka counters. "We're not tomatoes with timers." She tilts her face toward the table's quiet. "But emoji are mandatory."

"Bat for okay, moon for need help, heart for 'tell me a nice thing,'" Alice decides, tying a ribbon in her hair.

They clink mugs. Fika pact signed.

✦

Mid-morning is a braid of routines.

Niklas codes at the dining table, tall frame folded over a laptop, crescent moon earring catching light when he leans. He narrates his plan softly—rubber-ducking to the silver claw resting like a small dragon beside the trackpad.

In the kitchen, Rebecka dots tactile stickers along the new spice rack—pepper, paprika, cumin—teaching the cabinet to speak to her fingers. She quizzes him as she works. “Second shelf, left?”

“Cumin,” he calls back. “And I will never confuse it with cinnamon again. On pain of pancake.”

She smiles. “Swift compliance.”

Hikari films B-roll for later: gloved hands arranging a tower of black teacups, a velvet tablecloth unfurling in slow motion, steam curling from a kettle like a ghost deciding to stay. Between takes, she pads to Niklas and sets a tiny bat sticker on his wrist. The phone: “For luck.”

He kisses the sticker like a contract. “I’ll deploy it carefully.”

Alice’s key jangles by the door. She’s in café uniform—frills, apron, the sort of bow that declares war on gravity. “Wish me tips.” She steals a lipstick-soft kiss from Hikari, a forehead press from Rebecka, and a swift hug from Niklas that smells faintly of cedar and determination.

“Bring home the staff meal leftovers,” Rebecka says. “If it’s curry, I’m proposing.”

“Noted.” Alice salutes. “Court adjourns. See you after the latte trials.”

✦

Noon: sunlight paints the room gold.

Rebecka’s cane clicks down the building’s stairs; Niklas shadows two steps behind for the corner outside, then peels off at the curb because independence is a love language, too. “Text if you want a walking buddy back,” he says.

“I will.” She taps the cane twice—a private yes—and sets off, confident and steady.

Back upstairs, Hikari streams. The chat floods hearts; the TTS voice becomes the channel’s familiar narrator, reading her typed quips: “Welcome to the Dark Audit. Today we sort receipts and souls.” She’s a gothic breeze: lace cuffs, soft mouth, precise hands. Between bits she sips tea and, off-camera, texts the others a bat (okay), then a moon (need help choosing a sound effect). Niklas sends three: a gavel, a cash register, and a cat meow. She picks the gavel. The chat cheers.

In the library, Rebecka’s fingers move quicksilver across braille labels while her mentor describes shelf logic. She smiles when the group chat buzzes against her wrist: a heart ask from Niklas. She types back, “You are good at hard things, even when they are sticky and your code screams.” The read receipt pings; somewhere, a Swede blushes.

✦

Afternoon tucks them into different corners and rounds them back again.

Alice gets her fifteen at the café and uses it to call—Rebecka on speaker. “How’s the catalog queen?”

“Triumphantly stickered,” Rebecka says. “How’s the latte duchess?”

“Seventy percent foam diplomacy, thirty percent crisis management.” A crash off-screen. “Make that twenty-nine.”

Hikari edits in headphones, slicing her own silence into jokes. Every thirty minutes, she stands, stretches, and waters the basil plant named Balthazar. She texts the group a bat (okay) and a photo: Niklas napping upright for twelve terrifying seconds with a debugger open. Alice captions it during her break: “Behold, the Rare Vertical Hibernation of the Goth.”

By five, Niklas merges his branch and sends a victory moon (need help celebrating). Hikari replies with a quiet video: the apartment empty, the window open, city breeze and a single piece of piano music. The phone voice, soft: “Lie down. Breathe. I’m next door.”

He does. The code’s hum moves out of his bones.

✦

Evening is a soft fuse.

They reconverge like a well-designed script. Alice drags in the staff meal: curry. Rebecka makes good on the proposal joke with a grand, ridiculous kneel in the kitchen, and Alice cackles into her hair. Niklas boils noodles; Hikari plates with the severity of a judge.

"Gratitude round?" Rebecka suggests at the table.

Alice: "For a customer who tipped in sugar packets and a poem. Honestly iconic."

Hikari (phone): "For Bat-emoji language. More expressive than words today."

Niklas: "For cumin being both where it belongs and not in the pancakes."

Rebecka: "For the three of you. And curry."

After dishes (Alice and Niklas tag-team; Hikari dries; Rebecka polishes the flatware by feel because it satisfies her ghost of a perfectionist), they migrate to the couch. Hikari curls under Niklas's left arm, phone on her knees; Alice sprawls against his right, feet in Rebecka's lap; Rebecka leans into Niklas's shoulder, head turned so she can hear his heart.

Movie night is subtitles on, volume low. Halfway through, they pause for anmitsu. Hikari feeds Rebecka a spoonful with mock formality; Alice steals a bite and gets faux-scolded by the bench.

"Calendar?" Niklas murmurs as credits roll.

Alice flips it open. "Tomorrow: Rebecka's study block, Hikari's collab stream, my fitting, your one-on-ones. Saturday: gold dot—market morning, arcade night."

"Add Sunday: pajama brunch," Hikari types, "with a pancake alternative."

"Waffles," Rebecka decrees.

Niklas nods, solemn. "I will redeem breakfast."

"You already do," Alice says, tucking the black ribbon on his wrist with her thumb.

They do the last ritual—hands stacked in the middle, bracelets knocking softly: red, blue, black. One by one, they speak their small vows for tomorrow.

"I'll ask for help early," Niklas says.

"I'll rest before I need to," Alice says.

"I'll let silence answer first," Rebecka says.

"I'll remember I am allowed to want," Hikari's phone says.

Lights down. The city purls. Somewhere, the silver claw waits on the shelf like a polite little dragon, off duty. On the couch, the four of them breathe into a shared rhythm, ordinary as tea, radiant as trust.

Average day, perfectly theirs.

They called it a "four-way first date," but the city called it Friday.

They met at dusk by the river market—lanterns like small suns, music from a busker who knew exactly three chords and ten feelings. Alice arrived with glossed lips and a black ribbon in her hair; Hikari in a velvet jacket and fingerless gloves; Rebecka in a flowing dress that moved like water; Niklas in a dark shirt and the crescent moon at his ear, the silver claw tucked into his pocket like a well-mannered secret.

They made a ceremony of little things: buying a bag of candied yuzu to pass hand to hand; choosing a single stem each from the flower stall—Rebecka, freesia; Hikari, a night-blooming cereus bud the vendor swore would open if you were quiet; Alice, a peony the color of a gasp; Niklas, a spray of eucalyptus that smelled like a new page.

"Group vow," Alice declared, eyes bright. "If tonight gets big, we stay small—words first."

Hikari's phone voiced the reply they all mouthed: "Words first."

They wandered through a tiny retro arcade (Night Court the bat gained a cousin—a pixel ghost keychain Alice named “Sustained”), shared karaage in a back alley with a cat who accepted precisely two pieces before judging them, and paused on a footbridge where the wind stitched the river to the sky. Rebecka counted the beats of their footsteps and smiled—four rhythms syncing without trying.

“Truth game?” Niklas asked, voice soft. “One honest sentence each, no fixing, no deflecting.”

Alice went first: “I’m brave when I’m performing. Sometimes off-stage I want to hide in someone’s chest like a pocket.”

Hikari typed. The phone’s warm alto: “I like leading when no one expects me to, and I am not fragile when I do.”

Rebecka touched the bridge rail. “I am learning that independence and leaning are not opposites.”

Niklas exhaled. “I have wanted something like this for years and didn’t have the word. I think the word is ‘home.’”

They stood in that small, trembling quiet, and then the city nudged them onward.

The love hotel they chose was less neon and more lullaby: a lobby of soft blues and a receptionist who handed them a key shaped like a moon. The room itself felt like a stage set built by kindness—wash of warm light, a low table with tea and fruit, a bed wide as a boat, a bathroom that seemed designed by a raincloud with excellent taste.

No one rushed. Shoes by the door. Jackets on the stand. They gathered on the tatami by the low table, knees almost touching, the night-blooming cereus bud placed carefully in the center like a wish they might overhear.

“House rules,” Rebecka said, smiling at the echo of other nights. “Words first. Check-ins often. Anyone can call pause.”

Alice tugged Niklas’s sleeve. “Accessory roll call? I want to see you put yourself on, piece by piece.”

He obliged—funny and reverent at once—setting the crescent, then the loop, then sliding the silver claw onto his finger with a small click. “Reminder to be gentle,” he said, and Hikari’s eyes lit like a nod.

They learned each other by degrees:

—Alice discovered that Niklas’s calm wasn’t stoicism; it was listening so hard the world got brave.

—Niklas realized that Alice’s laughter could escort fear to the door without making it feel silly.

—Hikari showed them what leadership looked like when you made a runway out of silence: she typed, arranged, directed the lighting with a raised brow and a tilt of her chin, and none of it felt like taking; it felt like offering.

—Rebecka revealed that her touch was cartography—fingertips mapping collarbones, jawlines, shoulders—with a patience that turned shy into sacred.

Consent threaded everything. “May I?” “Yes.” “Still okay?” “Still yes.” They were specific and unhurried: a hand to a cheek, a forehead to a shoulder, a kiss that started like a question and became an answer you could live with. When shyness arrived, they made it tea.

Hikari typed, set the phone on speaker, and the voice softened: “I want to choose the pace.”

“You’re leading,” Alice said, glancing to the others.

Hikari smiled, tapped again. “Lights dimmed, not dark. Music quiet. We keep talking. And call me beautiful.”

“You are,” Niklas said, like a fact.

They found surprises:

—Alice’s favorite place to be kissed wasn’t her mouth but the soft edge of her jaw, where a compliment lingered long after words.

—Hikari loved cadence; she would sigh “again” after a pattern—three kisses, pause, hand squeeze—and the repeat made her whole body say yes.

—Rebecka, who had learned to brace the world with her spine, melted when someone braced it for her—Niklas at her back, Alice’s hand in hers, Hikari’s voice saying, “You may lean.”

—Niklas, who’d been careful with his size his whole life, learned that careful could be shelter, and that being held—Alice’s legs over his lap, Rebecka’s head on his chest, Hikari’s hand wrapped in his—was not a contradiction of being strong.

They didn’t make a movie of it. They made a room where vulnerability could breathe with its mouth open.

When the night tilted toward the bed, they paused again. Hikari typed, the speaker low: “I would like us close. I would like less fabric. I would like no hurry.”

“Yes,” said Rebecka, the word a smile.

“Yes,” said Alice, eyes bright and wet in the soft light.

“Yes,” said Niklas, and kissed Hikari’s knuckles, then Rebecka’s palm, then the inside of Alice’s wrist like punctuation.

What happened after was a chorus, not a solo. They laughed when something tangled, adjusted pillows like engineers, asked and answered a hundred tiny questions. There were tears—good ones—when Alice admitted, voice shaking, “I didn’t know I could take up this much tenderness and not be told I’m too much,” and three voices said at once, “You are exactly right.”

At some point, the cereus opened—petals unfolding in silent applause, white as breath. Rebecka’s fingers found it by scent and heat and wonder; Hikari took a photo that somehow caught the hush; Alice whispered, “Of course it waited for us.” Niklas touched the pot with his ringless hand, as if to thank it for the timing.

Later, bodies warm and loose, they nested. Hikari tucked into the curve of Niklas’s left side; Alice slung across his right, hair spilling like ink; Rebecka lay half on his chest, half on the quilt, listening to the slow animal of his heart.

“I didn’t know love could be this… wide,” Rebecka murmured.

“Or this specific,” Alice said, smiling into his shoulder. “Like—look, there’s a us-shaped niche in the universe.”

Hikari tapped, then set the phone on the pillow so they all heard the truth she typed: “I thought I had to choose between being cared for and being in charge of myself. I don’t.”

Niklas stared at the ceiling where the dim light made little galaxies out of plaster. “I didn’t know home could be four hands finding mine in the dark without missing.”

Silence came like a blanket. The hotel hummed. Outside, somewhere, the busker learned a fourth chord.

They fell asleep in a tangle of bracelets and slow breaths, the night-blooming flower keeping watch on the table, white and unabashed. And when dawn lifted the room into soft color, nothing felt finished. It felt begun—deeper, steadier, a new room added to the house they were building in each other.

Words first. Then everything else, exactly as needed.

Morning arrived as a hush and a promise.

Steam curled from the kettle; toast clicked up; sunlight pooled on the tatami like honey. The love hotel’s small dining nook felt like a private chapel—low table, four cushions, a tray with miso soup, tamagoyaki, rice, pickles, and cut fruit. The night-blooming cereus—now fully open, petals like white fire—watched from the sideboard as if to witness the vows.

They came to the table the way people come back from a pilgrimage—soft-footed, newly sure. Rebecka found her cushion by the crease in the rug; Niklas guided her hand to the warmed bowl. Hikari, in a borrowed shirt and velvet ribbon, set out chopsticks with the precision of a ceremony. Alice, hair loose and mischievous, tucked herself between them all, the black ribbon on Niklas's wrist turned with her thumb until the bead faced up like a star.

"House rule," Alice said, voice bright and gentle. "We eat, and we say the thing that burns to be said."

Hikari's thumbs moved; the phone's warm alto filled the quiet. "I love you," it said, sure as sunrise. She looked at each of them in turn, then typed more, slower. "Niklas: I love how carefully you are large. Rebecka: I love how your steadiness makes rooms honest. Alice: I love how you turn fear into laughter without breaking it."

Rebecka's breath hitched. She set her bowl down, palms flat on the table like anchoring. "I love you," she answered, voice trembling, then strong. "Niklas: for the way you listen until the world reveals its shape. Hikari: for showing me that leadership can be quiet as a hand held out. Alice: for choosing joy like it's a discipline you practice every day."

Alice blinked hard, smiled like a crack of light. "I love you," she said, teeth on her lower lip to steady the flood. "Niklas: for being a harbor that still wants to sail. Rebecka: for the way you map the world with touch and teach me to slow down. Hikari: for your sovereign heart—you run on your own power and still make room for us inside the glow."

Niklas swallowed. He looked at the three of them as if memorizing the exact arrangement of breath and color. "I love you," he said, nothing tentative in it. "Rebecka: for the courage to lean and the stubborn kindness that holds us together. Hikari: for your command and your sweetness and the way 'beautiful' keeps finding new meanings when I say it to you. Alice: for your fierce generosity—you make space, you invite truth, you keep choosing us."

Silence took a seat with them—a good silence, thick with relief. They ate; soup warmed hands and bellies; the tamagoyaki was sweet enough to make Alice hum. Hikari slid the tiny dish of pickles toward Rebecka's fingertips; Niklas refilled cups before they emptied. It was ordinary, which made it radiant.

"Passion clause?" Alice said after a while, eyes bright with mischief and sincerity both. "Declarations are binding. Physical expressions encouraged."

"Seconded," Rebecka said, smile audible.

Hikari typed, then placed the phone down like a gavel: "Motion carried."

They leaned across the narrow table and kissed in turn—Rebecka first, a soft, steady press to each of their mouths, fingertips mapping jaw and cheek like reading a favorite line. Niklas followed, precise and warm, the crescent moon brushing Alice's hair as he kissed her, then Hikari's forehead, then Rebecka's temple as if crowning them. Alice made it playful—nose-bump, grin, then a deeper kiss that said, we meant every word. Hikari took Niklas's left hand—the one without the claw—and kissed each ring, the phone murmuring, "Beautiful," for herself this time.

"Promises?" Rebecka asked, when breath returned.

They spoke them like a litany:

"I will keep asking, even when I think I know," Niklas said. "And I will keep my calendar honest so my heart can be."

"I will believe the first yes and the first no," Hikari's phone said. "And I will lead when I want to."

"I will say when I'm tired before I turn sharp," Alice said. "And I will keep making delight on purpose."

"I will name what I need," Rebecka said. "And I will let you help me meet it."

They sealed each promise with a kiss to the wrist where the bracelets lived—red, blue, black, and the silver bead turning their joined hands into a small constellation.

Breakfast ended slowly, like a good song fading instead of stopping. They cleaned up together, clumsy and laughing around the too-small sink, bumping hips, stealing quick kisses. Hikari tucked the cereus photo into their shared album; Rebecka traced the edges of the pot one last time, smiling at the cool curve.

At the door, shoes on, the city waiting, they gathered one more time in the little foyer that smelled of soap and steam.

"Words first," Alice reminded.

"Words always," Niklas corrected, gentle.

"Love first," Hikari's phone added, warm.

"Love always," Rebecka finished.

Four hands found each other—an easy weave now—and squeezed. When they stepped out into the bright day, it felt less like leaving a room and more like carrying it with them: a breakfast table, a flower that opened when they did, and a vow spoken in four voices that all meant the same thing.

They went toward the elevator laughing, bracelets knocking softly like a heartbeat spelled out in code. Passion didn't make them hurry. It made them sure.

Chapter 4
The Shape of Us

The shelf kit arrived like a dare.

Niklas held the box as if it might bite him. “How hard can ‘Easy Assembly’ be?” he said, already apologizing with his smile.

“Famous last words,” Alice sang, sliding beside him with a kiss to his shoulder. She wore bike shorts under an oversized band tee, hair up, a pencil tucked behind one ear like a construction worker who had chosen glamour instead of a hard hat.

Rebecka stood by the dining table, fingertips gliding over the instruction booklet she’d asked Niklas to describe. “So—six planks, twelve screws, and something called a… cam lock?” She tasted the term like it might be a pastry. “Let’s take it slow, okay? We can do this.”

The tablet on the table blooped. Hikari had typed, and her TTS voice—soft, low, a velvet contralto—floated out: “We are building a shelf, not summoning a demon. We will set roles.”

Alice clapped. “Captain Hikari on deck!”

Hikari, hoodie sleeves flopping past her hands, glanced over the parts with the practiced eye she used for camera rigs. She angled her tablet so everyone could see her next message.

TTS: “Niklas—muscle and… optimism. Alice—layout manager. Rebecka—quality control and feelings check. I will call steps.”

Niklas, already blushing, said, “I can do optimism.” He set the box down. The cardboard groaned like it was also skeptical.

They cleared a patch of living room floor. Hikari placed her phone on a mini tripod and turned on a pomodoro timer, the screen a silent pulse. Alice sorted screws into tiny bowls like confectionery. Rebecka found her way to the couch arm, hands trailing lightly over its edge; she listened to the clinks and scrapes, mapping it all in sound.

“First step?” Niklas asked, brandishing a screwdriver like a ritual dagger.

Hikari typed.

TTS: “Lay the two side planks parallel. Smooth edges out. Grooved edges in.”

“Grooved edges in,” Niklas repeated, turning one plank the wrong way.

Rebecka’s smile warmed him before her words did. “Left hand—rotate toward you, ninety degrees.” Her fingers made the motion in the air; he followed, and the plank settled with a satisfying hush on the rug.

Alice bumped Rebecka’s hip with a fond little play-headbutt. “You’re magic, you know that?”

“Only if he keeps listening,” Rebecka said, amused.

Hikari’s TTS chimed again: “Insert dowels in the pre-drilled holes on Shelf A. Niklas, use gentle force. Gentle.”

“Me? Gentle? Perish the thought,” he said, and promptly jabbed a dowel that refused to seat. The dowel shot across the rug. Alice trapped it with a catlike hand.

“Sneaky,” she scolded the wooden pellet. “No running away from this love.”

They worked in starts and fits. Hikari broke each instruction into bite-sized beats; Rebecka narrated the way the parts should feel when right: “Flush, not proud,” she murmured, “no light under the seam,” and Niklas adjusted until her palm passed over the joint and relaxed. When screws argued with him, Alice swapped in a smaller driver and made a little celebration of every click.

They were three steps in when disaster struck: cam locks.

Niklas held one up. “These look like tiny clock faces.”

“Turn the clock to ten-thirty,” Alice read from the pamphlet.

TTS: “Clock faces turn to lock. Do not over-tighten.”

Niklas turned the first one to, perhaps, tomorrow.

Something cracked.

He froze. “…Oops.”

Rebecka’s head tilted, listening. “That was a… small crack. Not awful.”

“Okay,” Niklas said, exhaling. “Okay, okay. My bad.”

Hikari leaned in and tapped a short line.

TTS: “Pause. Feelings check.”

Alice plopped cross-legged next to the half-born shelf. “I feel like my boyfriend needs a cookie,” she said, already rummaging her emergency snack kit.

“I feel… embarrassed,” Niklas admitted, voice small around the edges.

Rebecka reached for him. He let her find his knee, then his hand. She threaded their fingers together. “You’re allowed to be new at things. You don’t get braver by being perfect; you get perfect by being brave.”

His laugh came out wet. “That’s backwards.”

“It’s us,” Alice said, handing him a chocolate biscuit. “We’re all backwards. It’s hot.”

Hikari typed, the cursor blinking steady as a heartbeat.

TTS: “We will switch the hard cams to me. Niklas will do alignment. Alice is morale. Rebecka, check every joint by touch.”

“Copy,” Alice said, saluting with a cookie.

They reset. Hikari’s hands were quick and precise now, the quiet confidence of someone who had built a life out of systems. She glanced to Rebecka for a nod after each lock clicked; Rebecka’s palm skimmed, found the seam, and pronounced: “Good.” Niklas learned the rhythm—breathe, align, hold; Alice convinced the stubborn screws to fall in love.

Time slid, punctuated by low laughs and the TTS’s gentle prompts.

TTS: “Hydration break.”

TTS: “Stretch.”

TTS: “We are doing well.”

At step nine, the shelf had to roll upright. “One, two, three—” Niklas counted, then realized he’d gone on “two” and winced. Alice cackled. They wobbled it upright together anyway. It stood. Crooked. A single degree off true, as if tilting its head at them.

“Look at that,” Niklas whispered, reverent. “It’s… alive.”

“Hmm,” Rebecka said, fingertips tracing the front. “Left foot shorter?”

Hikari typed.

TTS: “Felt pads. Stack one.”

Alice stacked two because cute, and the shelf protested with a tiny sway. “Far be it from me to argue with architecture,” she said, removing one. Niklas knelt and pressed the pad into place.

It settled. True.

They stared like it might leave if anyone spoke too loud.

Niklas exhaled a laugh that turned into something like relief. “I didn’t break the home.”

“You built it,” Rebecka corrected softly.

Hikari's TTS came warm as tea: "Team effort. Good co-leading, heart."

Rebecka's cheeks pinked. "Good captaining, love."

Alice threw herself over both of them in a gentle tackle-hug and then yelped. "Wait—christen it!" She sprinted to the kitchen and returned with a little origami crane, slipped it on the top shelf like a housewarming hat. "There. Now it's part of us."

They began loading it with their lives: Rebecka's braille novels, Alice's fabric swatches in labeled baskets ("glossy black," "blood red," "surprise"), Hikari's cable organizers like obedient snakes, Niklas's tea tins stacked with their scent notes facing out for Rebecka—bergamot, toasted rice, plum blossom.

When all that was left was a narrow middle shelf, Hikari typed without looking up, confident.

TTS: "Ramen bowl shrine goes here."

Niklas groaned. "You're never going to let me live that down."

"Never," Alice said sweetly. "Also, we banned you from pancakes but not ramen."

"Mercy," he said, hand over heart. "Tonight, I will not cook. I will fetch."

"Wait." Rebecka lifted a finger. "Before we celebrate—define 'fetch.' Last time 'fetch' included the mysterious convenience store gyoza."

TTS: "Proposal: Niklas orders. Alice plates. Rebecka chooses music. I set up a cozy 'nest' on the floor. Decision in 30 seconds."

They put it to a vote with thumbs. Four up.

While Niklas built a delivery order with his careful mouth muttering—"no mushrooms for Alice, spice level two for Hikari, extra scallions for Rebecka"—Hikari rolled out a rug and ringed pillows like a fortress. Rebecka queued a playlist of soft city rain and cello. Alice brought out placemats shaped like bats because of course she owned placemats shaped like bats.

When the food arrived, they picnicked under their brand-new shelf as if it were a bower. Hikari's TTS stayed quiet, her fingers instead spelling "thank you" on each of their wrists in a tiny code she'd invented: two taps, a stroke. Rebecka leaned into Niklas's side and breathed in toasted sesame. Alice fed him a noodle like he was a very tall baby bird, wickedly pleased with herself.

After, as they lazed in the glow of full stomachs and a job done together, Niklas looked up at the shelf and felt something settle in his chest that had nothing to do with screws.

"I know it's just furniture," he said, "but… I love how we did this."

Rebecka hummed her agreement. "This is us when it's good. You try. Hikari guides. I… translate. Alice celebrates." Her hand found the crane and tapped it gently. "We stay."

Hikari typed, then looked at him as the voice spoke for her.

TTS: "Next time—pancakes?"

They all groaned. Then laughed. Then, somehow, promised.

"Okay," Niklas conceded, eyes shining. "With a fire extinguisher and four spotters. We'll do it together."

"Together," Alice echoed, and their hands found each other's in the pile they'd made a ritual: Rebecka's steady, Hikari's cool, Alice's warm, Niklas's huge and careful. The shelf watched from above, perfectly, defiantly straight.

The apartment smelled like new paint and cardboard. Afternoon light pooled on the floorboards in lazy gold rivers, as if the sun itself wanted to help them unpack.

"Keys," Alice declared, dangling them like earrings before slipping them into the bowl by the door—a ceramic moon Hikari had chosen on a whim the day they'd signed the lease. "First house rule: cute things go here."

Hikari lifted her tablet, thumbs flicking.

TTS (gentle): “Second rule: paths stay clear. Rebecka gets clean lines to every room.”

Rebecka smiled, one hand on the doorframe, the other tracing the grain of the wall like it already had a heartbeat. “Mmm. I can feel the echo—high ceiling. We’ll sound like we’re in a cathedral when we laugh.”

Niklas, carrying a box labeled “NOT PANCAKES,” nudged it inside with a shoe. “Third rule,” he puffed, “I do not get to declare anything ‘easy assembly’ ever again.”

Alice kissed his cheek on tiptoe. “We’ve all grown.”

The bed arrived last, or maybe it felt that way because it was mythic: a custom, wall-to-wall cloud meant for four—mattress the size of a small continent, low platform wrapped in charcoal fabric. The delivery guys left with raised eyebrows and a story to tell; the door clicked shut, and silence padded in on bare feet.

Hikari typed.

TTS: “Operation: Nest.”

They turned the empty bedroom into a map. Hikari pointed with her whole body—dresser here, books along that wall, blackout curtains that would turn noon into midnight when they needed it. Rebecka measured distance in steps and fingertips, noting “two paces from door to corner,” murmuring landmarks for her mental atlas: “window seam, outlet plate, rug edge.” Alice opened boxes like birthday gifts: gauzy canopy, a storm of pillows, a quilt she’d stitched from fragments of their lives—Niklas’s band tee, Hikari’s old hoodie sleeve, a scrap of Rebecka’s favorite indigo scarf, black satin from Alice’s cosplay stash.

Niklas misread a diagram and installed a headboard bracket upside down, caught it, and then confessed anyway. Rebecka squeezed his hand. “Thanks for telling us,” she said, and Alice gave him a sticker shaped like a bat for honesty. He wore it on his shirt like a medal.

They stretched the fitted sheet—an athletic event. “Corner!” Alice cried. “Other corner!” Niklas countered, immediately losing his corner. Hikari typed with one knee on the mattress, hair falling forward in a black waterfall.

TTS: “Rotate clockwise. Three… two…”

They rotated. The sheet snapped into place with a sound like triumph.

Rebecka ran her palms over the surface, smoothing, listening. “No wrinkles. Like an ice rink.”

“Like an ocean,” Niklas murmured.

Alice scattered pillows—velvet, linen, some with silly embroidered fangs. She stepped back, eyes shining. “It looks like we invented sleep.”

They stood at the edge, four silhouettes in the soft afternoon. The room was still empty of art, the walls blank, the future unwritten—but the bed was there, patient as a promise.

Hikari typed.

TTS (soft): “We should test it.”

“Scientific method,” Niklas agreed, solemn.

They climbed on, careful at first—Rebecka counting her steps, Alice guiding her calf with warm hands, Niklas bracing the edge, Hikari nudging a pillow into the right place with precise little taps. The mattress gathered them without complaint, all gravity and give, the cotton cool under their palms.

They lay shoulder to shoulder, then diagonally, then in a gentle knot, because that’s what they did: Niklas a steady shore, Rebecka’s head on his chest, Alice flung half over both like a cat claiming sun, Hikari fitting along Rebecka’s back, her hand spelling a tiny message on Rebecka’s forearm—two taps, a line. Thank you.

The city hummed beyond the glass. Inside, the hum was slower, domestic, theirs.

"This is big," Niklas said, and then realized the obviousness. "I mean—the bed. And also… this."

Rebecka tilted her face toward the ceiling. "We're going to wake up here. A lot. That's my favorite thought today."

Alice nosed into his shoulder, voice warm. "My favorite is matching pajamas. And a ceiling projector. And breakfast trays. And—"

Hikari's TTS cut in, playful: "Rule four: No pancakes without a fire marshal."

Laughter ricocheted off the blank walls, sweet and cathedral-high.

They started placing anchors around the room, one by one, as if to teach the space their names. Rebecka arranged her braille books along a low shelf by touch; Hikari mounted cable tracks with crisp satisfaction, labeling tiny charging nooks; Alice taped a heart on the floor exactly where the sunbeam liked to land; Niklas affixed felt pads to every chair like a guardian against future scrapes.

When they were done, they sprawled again across their ridiculous continent of a bed. Alice produced a roll of washi tape printed with tiny stars and handed everyone a strip.

"Tradition," she said. "We each make a wish and tape it to the frame, so the bed knows what to keep safe."

Rebecka, thoughtful, taped hers just above where her hand could reach in the night. "Mine is for good endings… and better mornings."

Hikari fixed hers near the outlet—practical, precise.

TTS: "Mine is for calm systems. And courage when the plan changes."

Alice's went by the window. "Joy. Messy, glittering joy."

Niklas stuck his near the middle, then, embarrassed, moved it to the side. Rebecka's hand found his wrist and gently put it back to the center.

"What's yours?" she asked.

He swallowed, smiling at the ceiling. "Home," he said. "Just… home."

They let silence answer them, the kind that doesn't need anything.

Evening came on with a violet tilt. They dimmed the lights and tested every "goodnight" plan Hikari had drafted: path lights to the bathroom, the soft chime for reminders, the shared playlist that sounded like sleepy rain. Alice crawled to the foot to tuck the quilt's edge because she insisted good corners made good dreams. Rebecka checked the bed's left edge twice—habit, comfort—then relaxed, hand splayed open on the sheet like a flag.

"Do we fit?" Niklas asked into the hush.

Hikari typed slow, then didn't press play. She set the tablet down and answered with touch—she took his hand, brought it to Rebecka's, layered Alice's over both, then laid her own on top.

They fit.

"Ett hem," Niklas whispered, the Swedish soft in his mouth. A home.

"Ett hem," Alice echoed, mangling the vowel cheerfully.

Rebecka laughed, low. "Teach us properly tomorrow."

TTS (finally, warm as tea): "Tomorrow."

They turned off the last lamp. The apartment listened to their breathing and began, dutifully, to learn it by heart. The huge bed held them steady, a ship in a dark, calm sea, pointing toward mornings they hadn't met yet—together.

The new apartment gave each of them a room of their own, a place to retreat without having to leave the family.

Niklas called his the Chapel of Small Monsters: dark walls, model figures, brushes, and the patient chaos of unfinished projects. Rebecka's Listening Library was lined with books, tactile markers, warm fabrics, and a tea cart whose labels she could read with her fingertips.

Hikari's Order of Joy was a clean-lined studio of meticulously arranged equipment, soft status lights, and silence she could control. Alice's Atelier of Hearts overflowed with fabric, wigs, dress forms, and small tributes to the three people she loved.

They respected one another's doors. Visits began with a knock or a text, and a simple question—"Five minutes or less?"—became a household ritual. The rooms were private; the welcome inside them was real.

1) Rebecka → Niklas's "Chapel of Small Monsters"

The day chewed at Rebecka—bureaucracy, long holds, a librarian's dream meeting that fizzled into "maybe next year." She found the sigil plate beside Niklas's door and pressed two fingertips, light as rain.

Inside, a chair scraped. "Five or less?" Niklas called, gentle.

"Five," she said, and the syllable carried more weight than usual.

He opened. The room smelled like cedar and paint; the fan hummed. He didn't speak. He guided her to the stool by the painting desk and placed something small in her palm.

A finished miniature—smooth cape, ridged armor, a tiny book clutched to its chest. "Archivist Paladin," he murmured. "Sworn to keep stories safe."

She smiled where he couldn't see it, felt the cape's edge, the careful work. The day loosened. "You made me a knight?"

"I… might've needed one, too," he admitted.

She set the mini down carefully, found his wrist, and squeezed—gratitude in pulse language. "Two minutes left," she said. "Tell me one good thing, and then we trade."

He thought. "I learned to feather highlights without panic," he said. "Also I didn't glue my fingers together."

"Two good things," she corrected, then told him hers: "I said 'no' to an extra meeting. I kept my voice steady on the phone."

He exhaled, small and proud on her behalf. When she left, she tucked a reset token into his tray and whispered to the cases, "Guard him," because it felt right.

2) Niklas → Hikari's "Order of Joy"

Niklas's code refused to compile and so did his patience. He text-knocked: five or less? The door LED glowed yellow (editing). After a beat, green: free.

He slipped in like someone entering a chapel. Everything had a home; even the silence sat neatly. Hikari didn't look up, just slid a sticky note across the desk: Tea first with a tiny drawn cup.

He brought tea. She flipped her tablet:

TTS: "Put frustration in the borrow box."

He laughed, set the imaginary chunk of frustration into the labeled bin. "There. It's… on loan."

She patted the chair beside her. The desk timer showed twelve minutes left on an edit block. She typed again.

TTS: "You can be still here. No fixing."

He let his shoulders drop, watched waveforms shimmer on her screen. After the timer chimed, she rotated a monitor his way: a clean checklist titled Return of Sanity. Three items: breathe, rename files, try again later.

He read it out loud, voice steadier by #3. "I'll… try again later," he said, meaning more than code.

On his way out, he left a silica gel packet with a doodled smile in her offerings tray. She lifted it to eye level, precise, and aligned it with the others, equally precise. He grinned the whole walk back.

3) Hikari → Alice's "Atelier of Hearts"

Hikari's schedule slipped by two hours; a sponsor changed terms mid-thread. Anxiety prickled like static. She switched her door light to blue (away), collected herself, then drifted down the hall. She flipped Alice's consent peg to green and stepped across the glitter containment line with exaggerated care.

Alice looked up from a half-pinned gown. "Five or less?"

Hikari lifted both hands like a surrendered raccoon. TTS: "Five. Require: sensory reset."

Alice's smile warmed. "Sit." She cleared the beanbag, dimmed the task lamp, and pulled out the "emergency textures": velvet square, cool satin braid, a ridiculous faux-fur tail. Hikari closed her eyes, letting touch replace thought.

"Pick," Alice said softly.

Hikari pressed the satin between thumb and forefinger. TTS: "Moonlight."

Alice draped the braid over Hikari's shoulders like a medal. "Moonlight it is." She went to the shrines, dusted each, then came back with a rosemary sprig from Hikari's. "Breathe with me?"

They breathed. In on rosemary, out on music soft as thread.

When the five-minute timer chirped, Alice kissed the air beside Hikari's temple. "Want an extra two?"

Hikari typed, a little lighter. TTS: "Permission granted to hug."

Alice folded her in, careful not to dislodge the satin. The world returned with edges smoothed. Hikari, before leaving, straightened the pin cups into a perfect row and placed a reset token by the sewing machine. Alice pretended not to notice and then very much noticed later, beaming.

4) Alice → Rebecka's "Listening Library"

Alice's cosplay commission got postponed; her pep ran thin. She tugged Rebecka's braided cord—one gentle pull. Inside, rain and cello waited like a lap.

"Five or less?" Rebecka called.

"Five, plus a cuddle tax?" Alice asked, small.

"Always."

Alice sank into the beanbag island, head in Rebecka's lap. Fingers threaded into her hair, slow and sure—Rebecka's version of a reset button. "Tell me the colors you worked with today," Rebecka said.

Alice let the language spill: "Blood-rose satin, storm-grey crinoline, a scandalous black that eats light… and glitter that will outlive us all."

"Mm." Rebecka smiled. "The glitter has already filed its residency papers."

They giggled. The tightness in Alice's chest eased. Rebecka reached for the tea cart. "Citrus or lavender?"

"Lavender," Alice sighed. "To remind me I live in a body."

Rebecka poured. "One good thing you did for you today," she prompted.

Alice thought. "I asked for a later deadline without apologizing."

Rebecka's hand stilled in her hair, proud. "That's not small."

When the timer chimed, Alice stayed exactly one second more—because elasticity is a love language—and then booped Rebecka's nose. She pinned a quote to the corkboard on her way out: 'We are all stories in the end. Just make it a good one.' Below it, she added, and a comfy beanbag.

Coda (the hallway)

Later, they met in the hallway without planning it, each a little rearranged by the rooms they'd visited. Niklas offered chocolate with ceremonial solemnity. Hikari held up her borrow box—empty now—and tipped it like a hat. Alice flashed her lavender-scented wrist. Rebecka touched all three of them with a quick, grounding press.

"Five or less?" Niklas said, smiling.

"Exactly five," Rebecka answered, and they stood there together for the length of a gentle timer, doors at their backs, home in every direction.

The love hotel had a lobby like a secret carnival: velvet curtains, neon moons, a vending wall of themed rooms. Alice pressed her face to the glass like a kid at a candy store. "Space opera? Vampire manor? Oh—look at that one with the mirrored—"

Hikari's tablet chimed, velvet-low.

TTS: "Vampire manor. On brand."

Rebecka squeezed Niklas's arm, smiling. "Ready, sir? You're being taken to a castle."

"Define 'ready,'" he croaked, because the three of them were moving with a kind of storm-front purpose he had only seen in weather apps.

The door sealed them in with a hush. Candle bulbs glowed. A canopy bed spilled shadow like ink. There was a discreet basket on the console—hydration, towels, a little hourglass. Alice lifted the hourglass and grinned. "Oh, we won't need this."

"Counterpoint," Niklas said faintly, "we might need three."

Hikari tugged him by the belt loop to the chaise, typed with efficient thumbs.

TTS: "Quick huddle. Boundaries, safewords, water."

They gathered like teammates about to run the most intimate relay. Rebecka's voice stayed soft and certain. "Green is go, yellow is slow, red is stop. Hand up means pause. Who's first?" Her smile made the question a promise.

Alice bounced. "Election by enthusiasm?" She was already laying out their "kit": hair ties, mints, lip balm, and a ridiculous amount of bottled water. She clipped her hair up like she was clocking in.

Hikari's eyes held heat and focus in equal measure.

TTS: "I will time hydration. Niklas—tap me every ten minutes. Or sooner."

"S-sooner sounds good," he said, because three pairs of eyes had turned him into an altar.

What followed came in waves rather than details: the room breathing deeper; the canopy's shadow tide; laughter muffled in pillow-cotton; the precise hush of Hikari's fingers on his wrist checking "still good?"; Alice's wicked, sparkling delight as she took a turn leading; Rebecka's voice, low and steady, threading through it all—naming, asking, praising.

Somewhere in there, the hourglass flipped itself by magic (Alice). Somewhere else, Hikari's timer chimed and a straw touched his mouth, patient. "Hydrate," Rebecka coaxed, and he obeyed like a knight taking a sacred oath.

"Status?" Hikari's TTS murmured at one point, fond and merciless.

"Yellow," Niklas admitted, breathless, hand in the air like he was hailing a taxi from the underworld.

"Slowing," Rebecka promised, and the storm softened, became rain, became warmth. Alice kissed his palm in apology and then in promise.

They tag-teamed him with kindness and chaos in equal measure, the three of them moving like they'd rehearsed this in a dream—Hikari's precision, Alice's firework glee, Rebecka's anchoring tenderness. Niklas discovered new uses for the word "mercy," all of them affirmative.

At some delirious midpoint, the room phone chirped. Alice answered in a whisper. “Yes, we’d like to extend the time… No, we’re not tired yet… Yes, more water, please. And the good chocolate.” She hung up, eyes feral and sweet. “Resupply incoming.”

Niklas lay starfished across the velvet chaise, hair a riot, chest heaving, the bat ring on Alice’s finger gleaming like mischief. “I am… but a humble mortal,” he announced to the chandelier.

“Noted,” Rebecka said, kissing his forehead. “Beloved mortal.”

“Also resilient,” Hikari’s TTS added, sounding far too satisfied for his continued survival.

Round two was gentler, then not, then yes again. Round three turned into a pile of limbs and a chorus of giggles because someone’s foot (Alice’s) knocked the velvet bolsters to the floor like bowling pins. They all paused to laugh until they were breathless, and the laugh didn’t break the spell; it deepened it.

When the door finally clicked for the resupply, Niklas sat up too fast, wobbled, and grinned at himself. “I am fine. Everything is fine. I can… walk.”

“You don’t need to,” Rebecka said, tugging him back down by the wrist with scandalous kindness.

Much later—a time measured in empty water bottles and a pile of discarded hair ties—the four of them sprawled under the canopy like survivors of a glamorous shipwreck. Hikari pressed a cool towel to his neck; Alice fed him a square of dark chocolate like communion; Rebecka massaged his forearm in slow circles until his pulse stopped sounding like a drum solo.

“Post-op debrief?” Alice chirped.

“Scientific method,” Niklas agreed weakly. “Findings: I lived.”

“Conclusion,” Hikari’s TTS intoned, “team synergy optimal.”

“Recommendation,” Rebecka added, amused, “pajamas and a very slow morning.”

Niklas reached for all three hands at once and mostly succeeded. “Best near-death experience of my life.”

“Near-death?” Alice gasped, delighted. “Oh, we can do better.”

Hikari set the towel on his chest, cool as mercy.

TTS: “Tomorrow.”

“Tomorrow,” Rebecka echoed, drawing shapes on his shoulder with her fingertip that felt like promises.

They lay there listening to the old building hum and the air conditioner purr, the canopy cupping their quiet. Outside, the city glittered like an accomplice. Inside, Niklas blinked up at the velvet ceiling, bliss-stunned and still very much alive, and thought with full-hearted certainty:

“I am so, so doomed,” Niklas murmured. “In the best possible way.”

The room had gone quiet enough to hear the air conditioner breathe. Shadows from the canopy lay over them like calm water.

Hikari’s tablet lit first.

TTS (low, warm): “Debrief starts. Water, sugar, temperature.”

Alice propped herself on an elbow, hair a wild halo, and popped open a fresh bottle. “Hydration for my brave mortal,” she teased, but her eyes were serious. She steadied the straw at Niklas’s lips with two fingers and watched him drink like she was timing a race. “Good.”

Rebecka shifted closer, the sheet whispering. “Body scan?” she asked, voice small and careful, like checking a fever.

Niklas nodded. “Head… floaty. Chest okay. Thighs will write a memoir.” He smiled to show he meant it kindly.

Hikari placed a cool towel at his nape, precise as a prescription.

TTS: “Color check: you’re a little pale. Blood sugar.”

Alice produced chocolate like a magician. “Open,” she ordered, gently tyrannical, and fed him a square. He chewed obediently, eyes soft.

Rebecka’s hands were already moving—a slow, thoughtful inventory. “Any stings or sore spots you don’t want touched?” she asked.

“Left shoulder’s a no,” he said. “Everything else is—green.”

Her fingers detoured around the no, mapping the yeses with long, grounding strokes. “Good,” she murmured. “Tell me if green changes.”

They lay in an easy tangle for a minute, the four of them just… existing. Hikari set a quiet three-minute timer labeled breath. When it chimed, she typed again.

TTS: “Check-in words. One each.”

Alice went first. “Proud. Hungry. Tender.” She pressed a kiss to Rebecka’s temple and then to Hikari’s knuckles before bonking her forehead lightly against Niklas’s—her version of a medal ceremony.

Rebecka: “Full. Grateful. Soft.” She threaded her fingers with Niklas’s, and he squeezed back, small pulses of thanks.

Hikari looked at them all, then down at her tablet.

TTS: “Steady. Achy. Loved.”

Niklas swallowed. “Wrecked, but like, in a… cathedral-after-concert way? Also—safe.” He blinked. “Very safe.”

Alice beamed. “We should get that on a t-shirt: Wrecked but Safe.”

“New merch line later,” Hikari’s TTS deadpanned. “Now: stretch.”

They did, clumsy and giggling—pointing toes, rolling shoulders, slow neck arcs. Rebecka counted the beats so they stayed together. Niklas made an involuntary noise halfway through a hamstring attempt; Alice applauded as if he’d lifted a car.

Next came practicals. Hikari opened the discreet hotel kit and lined items up like little soldiers: electrolyte packet, balm, spare hair ties.

TTS: “Consent to clean-up assistance?”

“Yes,” Niklas said. “Please.”

They moved like a pit crew that loved him: warm cloths, fresh tees, the kind of careful that makes you want to cry a little. Rebecka’s hands were steady; Alice made jokes exactly when the air needed more oxygen; Hikari kept the tempo humane.

After, he lay under the robe Hikari had warmed in the bathroom like she’d bribed a dragon. The cool towel had been replaced with her palm, flat to his sternum, counting breaths.

“Status?” she asked with her eyes; the tablet stayed dark.

“Green,” he said, and meant it.

They circled into a quieter knot. Alice sprawled half on the duvet, foot lazily nudging the room service menu. “Debrief part two: compliments,” she declared. “Rebecka, your voice could guide ships home.”

Rebecka flushed. “Alice, your joy kept us brave.” She turned to Hikari. “Your pacing was… perfect.”

Hikari typed a single line and then deleted it, choosing touch instead—she traced OK on Rebecka’s wrist in their little tap-code, then repeated it on Alice’s. She looked at Niklas last.

“I’m okay,” he whispered, almost surprised. “Because you watched me.”

“Always,” Rebecka said.

“Obsessively,” Alice added, cheerful and true.

TTS (soft): “Attentively,” Hikari finished.

They ordered food in the laziest way—pointing at pictures, over-tipping the person who brought it, eating on the bed like rulebreakers. Hikari set another timer—a real one, fifteen minutes—labeled no debrief, just silly. For fifteen minutes they obeyed, telling stupid jokes, rating the hotel chocolates, arguing whether the chandelier looked more like a jellyfish or a ghost.

When the timer chimed, Rebecka rolled onto her side, facing them. “Last thing,” she said. “Would anyone change anything next time?”

Alice chewed on her lip, thoughtful. “I want a dedicated water fairy role. I liked doing it, but I also wanted to climb you like a tree, and those goals are… in conflict.”

Hikari nodded, approving the systems talk.

TTS: “We’ll rotate water duty. Also, more towels.”

Niklas stared at the ceiling, honest. “I… might say yellow sooner. I didn’t need to be a hero.”

“You’re our hero for saying that,” Alice said immediately, fierce with affection.

Rebecka smoothed his hair. “Thank you,” she whispered, as if he’d handed her a precious book.

TTS: “Log updated,” Hikari added, mock-serious, and then set her tablet aside. She curled in, head on Rebecka’s shoulder, hand resting over Niklas’s heartbeat.

They sank into the bed’s hush. Outside, the city shuffled its neon. Inside, the four of them drifted—fed, watered, cherished—until the kind of sleep that fixes people stole over them in pieces.

Just before he slipped under, Niklas murmured, “Tomorrow: the slowest breakfast.”

Alice, already drowsy, hummed. “And the best.”

Rebecka: “No pancakes.”

Hikari, not bothering to type, tapped a single word onto his wrist, one he felt rather than heard: Home.

The text from Rebecka came mid-morning, three words that sounded braver than they were:

forgot my lunch

Niklas stared at the message, then at the neatly packed bento sitting on the counter under a sticky note from Alice—“For our librarian. Contains love (and onigiri).” He grabbed it like a mission brief.

The campus library was all cool air and soft echoes. He paused at the door and texted: here—want me to come to you or meet at the atrium? A moment later:

atrium. by the fountain. two paces from the plant with the rough leaves.

He found her exactly there—one hand on the planter’s edge, the other hovering over the stone lip of the fountain as if feeling the shape of the water’s sound. She turned before he spoke, face tilting toward the familiar pattern of his breath.

“Sir Knight,” she said, smiling.

He puffed. “Your lunch, my lady,” and very nearly dropped the bento in his bow. Two left hands, one determined heart.

She laughed, soft and fond. “Saved from the vending machine dragon.”

They slid onto a bench. He set the bento on her lap, guided her fingers to the elastic band and the little tab Alice always placed at the top so it’d be easy to find. The elastic snapped free with a satisfying thrum.

“What did Alice pack?” Rebecka asked.

Niklas squinted at the handwritten insert tucked inside—Hikari’s neat block letters. “Inventory: two onigiri (salmon and ume), tamagoyaki, cucumber salad with sesame, and a tiny chocolate because morale.”

“Morale,” Rebecka echoed, pleased.

"Also chopsticks," he said, then paused. "And a fork backup. Because we respect all faiths."

She smirked. "Fork it is. I'm a heathen today."

He unwrapped the fork and placed it in her hand the way she liked—handle first, his fingers a gentle guide. She prospected the bento's landscape by scent and touch, found the rice triangles, and made a quiet "mmm" that melted his bones.

Between bites she asked, "How's your morning?"

He grimaced. "My code compiled and then immediately regretted its life choices. Hikari told me to put my frustration in the borrow box." He nodded solemnly. "It is currently on loan."

Rebecka covered a smile with the back of her hand. "Return date?"

"After lunch." He lifted a cucumber slice like a coin. "Payment up front."

They ate in companionable fits. Every so often, he rotated the box a quarter turn so each section came to her hand in a new arrangement; she teased him for narrating like a tour guide ("on your left, the fabled egg roll"), but she let him keep doing it.

A pair of students drifted past, whispering about a group project. The fountain threw light in small coins onto the ceiling. Somewhere a printer coughed like an elderly cat.

"Thank you for bringing it," Rebecka said after a while, thumb brushing the corner of the box. "I felt silly asking."

"I like being asked," he said, surprising himself with the ease of it. "My primary love language is 'carrying things.'"

"Mm." She tilted her head, a thought passing. "Secondary?"

"'Being told I did okay even when I nearly dropped the soy sauce,'" he said, because he nearly had.

"You did okay," she said, warm as tea.

He coughed to keep from making a ridiculous noise. "You, uh, have a… meeting after this?"

"Cataloging praxis," she sighed. "Which is a beautiful phrase that currently means 'everyone disagreeing politely.'"

"Can I give you a buff?" he asked, already fishing in his pocket. He produced a tiny vial—a roll-on of Alice's lavender blend labeled in braille and ink. "Calm systems, courtesy of Captain Hikari and our chaotic alchemist."

Rebecka held out her wrist, trusting. He dabbed a dot and fanned it with his hand, sheepish ceremony. "You smell like… a book spa," he decided.

"My natural habitat," she said, amused.

He repacked the empty bento, fussing with the elastic until it behaved. When he looked up, she had her hand raised halfway, feeling for him. He met it, their palms settling like puzzle pieces.

"One more thing," she said. "Walk me back?"

He rose, offered his arm. They moved at her pace—counted steps, familiar turns. He announced small landmarks the way she liked: "low table, left; stray backpack, two o'clock." At her office door she reached for the handle, then paused.

"Payment," she said.

"For delivery?"

"For being asked and still saying yes," she corrected, and leaned in to kiss the corner of his mouth—light, precise, devastating.

He blinked. "Tip accepted."

She smiled, then sobered just a shade. "Text me when your borrow-box returns its contents."

"I will," he promised.

On the way out, he almost collided with a wheeled cart and recovered with the grace of a startled giraffe. He glanced back; Rebecka had already slipped inside, the lavender trailing a soft signature.

His phone buzzed before he hit the steps: a message from Hikari—TTS (in text): “Proud of you. Also: bring home bento box. Alice wants to add a note for tomorrow.”

Niklas typed back: On it. Mission success. Librarian fed; morale high.

He pocketed the bento, squared his shoulders, and decided the code could wait five more minutes. First, he was going to buy two more chocolate squares—one for the librarian who forgot her lunch, and one for the mortal who remembered how good it felt to be useful.

The invite came as a single-line text at noon.

Family dinner tonight. Will you come with me?

Niklas read it twice, then a third time, because Hikari rarely used so many words without an emoji or a schedule link. He typed yes and then anything I should bring?

The reply arrived with a little typing bubble that felt like a held breath.

Omiyage is good. Also—tonight I want to be… soft-young. My choice. Are you okay to follow my lead?

He set his phone down carefully, like it might tip. Of course, he wrote, and then, because he’d learned specificity helped, You set the rules; I’ll keep pace.

Alice helped him pick a seasonal box of yokan and a tin of tea; Rebecka tied the ribbon and tucked a tiny lavender sachet in the bag “for courage.” On the train, Niklas held the loop and watched Hikari’s reflection: hoodie a shade lighter than her usual black, hair in twin low tails, a tiny star clip like a wink of childhood. Her tablet was slung with a strap covered in soft charms. She looked at him and signed a quick question with her eyes rather than her hands.

“You okay?” he whispered.

She nodded. Then she typed.

TTS (quieter, higher than usual): “Rules. One: Tonight I use my smaller voice. Two: I might hold your sleeve. Three: If I type ‘Pause,’ we take space.”

“Got it,” he said, offering his sleeve before she asked. “And I’ll do the grown-up stuff—doors, tea pouring, chopstick foibles, heroic dad-jokes.”

She smiled, shoulders easing. At the station exit, she tapped a message and didn’t press play. He read the screen instead: Thank you for letting me choose this.

Her parents’ apartment smelled like simmering bonito and orange peel. Slippers lined the genkan in neat pairs. Hikari slipped into her childhood ones without looking, the blue pair with tiny clouds. Niklas managed the slippers with only one moment of Scandinavian-foot comedy and bowed, gift bag presented with both hands.

“Yoroshiku onegaishimasu,” he said, careful and earnest.

Hikari’s mother was smaller than he expected and larger in presence, apron tied sharp, eyes quick. Her father had a bookish stillness and the kind of hands that remembered tools. Surprise flickered across both faces when Hikari tucked half-behind Niklas and held his sleeve, then softened as if a wind had changed.

“Welcome, Niklas-san,” her mother said in patient English, then to Hikari in Japanese, a question shaped like is this what you want?

Hikari nodded, typed a line, and let the tablet speak for her.

TTS (small, steady): “Yes. Today I want to be the youngest version of me. I brought Niklas because he listens.”

Her father’s mouth did something like a smile. “Then we will listen, too.”

They ate nabe around the low table—steam ghosting the lights, mushrooms bobbing, thin ribbons of beef curling in the broth. Hikari's mother kept the bowls rotating like a conductor; her father sneaked Niklas extra tofu with a conspirator's tilt of the chopsticks.

Hikari stayed close, sleeve in hand when she shifted, tablet on her knee. She used simpler words than usual, typed slower, and sometimes didn't type at all—communicating with nods, with the way she leaned into the steam like a plant toward sun. When conversation got quick and adult—taxes, apartment repairs—she pressed her thumb against Niklas's wrist twice: Pause. He matched her silence, a polite island inside the flow. When she was ready, she tapped three times: Back.

At one point, her mother rose to fetch a photo album and paused in the doorway. "Hikari," she said softly in Japanese, "do you want the old books?" Her eyes flicked to the star clip, the small voice, then back. No pity. Just a check.

Hikari typed with her knee drawn up, tablet against it.

TTS: "Yes, but can we look… just us and Niklas? Later?"

Her mother nodded, relief almost invisible. "Of course."

The evening unspooled in gentle measures. Niklas poured tea; he remembered to refill everyone else before himself. He listened more than he spoke, and when he did speak, it was to ask Hikari's father about the woodwork in the display cabinet (cedar, hand-cut), to tell her mother the yokan was "dangerously good," to brag softly that Hikari had optimized their apartment's cable chaos and saved at least three lives.

Hikari's father asked a quiet question in Japanese that Hikari's mother translated: "How did you meet our daughter?"

Niklas glanced at Hikari. She tipped her head: go on.

"At home," he said. "We are neighbors. Then friends. Now… family, I think." He looked down at the sleeve she held. "She chose me to come today. I'm honored."

Hikari's mother studied him with the exactness of someone measuring a seam. She seemed to find the fit acceptable. "Eat more," she said, which was the same as we like you.

After dinner, they migrated to the tiny living room. The photo album emerged after all—toddler Hikari with paint on her cheeks, school Hikari with neat braids and too-big uniforms, teenage Hikari behind a camera, always behind. Sometimes the captions were in her mother's handwriting, sometimes typed labels in neat strips. Hikari's fingers walked the edges of plastic sleeves, not quite touching the photos themselves.

She typed, not for the room but for Niklas's eyes only, the screen angled toward him.

People used to put me here. (A little arrow to a cutesy sticker on a page.) Today, I put myself here.

He nodded, throat tight, and kept his sleeve steady.

When it was time to leave, Hikari's mother pressed leftovers into their hands with a ritual's efficiency. Her father walked them to the genkan and stood there, grave, the way fathers do when they want to say much and will say little.

"You are… gentle," he told Niklas in English, an assessment more than a compliment. "This is good."

"Your daughter taught me," Niklas answered, bowing again.

On the sidewalk, the night air tasted like rain. Hikari kept hold of his sleeve until they turned the corner; then she let go and stretched both arms up like a cat coming out of a nap. She typed as they walked.

TTS (her usual voice again, lower, wry): "Thank you for being my… sleeve person."

"Anytime," he said. "Professional sleeve."

She bumped his shoulder, smile sideways. Then, a smaller line:

TTS: “I felt safe.”

He exhaled. “Good.”

They rode the train back in a comfortable sway. Halfway home, Hikari typed without looking, thumbs sure.

TTS: “It wasn’t pretending. It was me—just a different room in the house.”

“I like all your rooms,” he said. “I’ll knock the right way.”

She tucked her hand into the crook of his elbow, not needing the sleeve now, just choosing the closeness. When they reached their station, her tablet stayed dark. She spelled a single word on his forearm with two taps and a line, the quiet code they’d made together.

Proud.

“Me too,” he said, and they walked the last stretch under streetlights that made the pavement look like ribbon—two people heading home to an apartment where doors could close, and open, exactly when they decided.

The maid café lived up to its reputation: pastel thunderstorm, bell chimes, the smell of sugar doing cartwheels. Niklas paused under the awning, checked his text thread again.

Alice: permission granted to visit 💜

Rules: no touching, no monopolizing me, be cute, tip well.

Bonus rule: order the seasonal set. It’s ridiculous.

He straightened his collar (goth suit today; silver claw ring winking) and stepped inside.

A chime. A chorus: “Welcome home, Master!”

And there was Alice—sunbeam in black lace, ribboned apron, hair in soft curls with a tiny bat clip. Her persona slid on like a glove: bright, warm, just theatrical enough. She clocked him, eyes going heart-soft for a half second before she turned it into professional sparkle.

“Welcome home, Master Niklas,” she sang, perfectly in character. “One seat for a very tall, very handsome mortal?”

He managed a bow without colliding with the table. “Yes, please.”

She led him to a corner booth (good for his knees) and presented a menu decorated with doodled cats and suspiciously powerful parfaits. A discreet hand-squeeze hovered, didn’t land. Rules. He smiled anyway.

“First time?” she asked, pen poised.

“First time visiting my favorite maid,” he said, which earned him a micro-dimple and a quick behave look.

He ordered the seasonal set on faith. Alice scribbled, then lowered her voice a hair. “Manager’s watching. Be adorable.”

“I only brought my C- game,” he deadpanned.

“Unacceptable,” she whispered, then pivoted away in a cloud of skirts.

He watched her work as instructed: the way she floated between tables, how she remembered regulars’ quirks, how she coaxed shy patrons into the ritual—draw a heart in your curry with ketchup, chant the silly flavor spell so the omurice becomes “yummier.” He could see the precision under the sparkle: she timed things so the kitchen never bottlenecked, adjusted her smile for the overstim kids, used joke volume to drown out a loud table gently.

When his set arrived, it was a goth fever dream: charcoal pancake stack with powdered-sugar moons, a tiny bat-wing cookie, latte art shaped like—good grief—him (two dots and a little claw earring drawn in chocolate).

Alice presented it with ceremony. “To make it delicious,” she declared, “we have to do the charm together.” She poised her hands like paws.

He mirrored, solemn. They meowed. (He meowed.) The table of high schoolers next to him applauded. His ears went pink; Alice’s grin could have powered the city.

Between customers she flashed by with little asides only he could decode.

“Hydration check?” she asked, setting water down he hadn’t requested.

“Green,” he said.

“Posture,” she teased, nudging his shoulders back from a slouch with air-only hands. He straightened. She beamed. “Perfect.”

A small wobble hit mid-shift: a customer tried to push for a selfie with an arm around her. Alice’s smile didn’t flicker, but she took a half step back, hands folded. “Photos are okay from over here,” she chirped, pointing to the designated spot on the floor. “Thank you for remembering our rules!” The guy rolled his eyes.

Niklas didn’t stand; he didn’t need to. He just looked up, met the man’s gaze once—calm, steady, not challenging, just present. The guy blinked and adjusted like a shopping cart wheel that finally aligned. “Right, sorry,” he said, stepping to the marked spot. Click. Done.

Alice shot Niklas the tiniest salute. Team sport.

He finished his absurd pancakes with reverence (and a little fear of the powdered sugar), tipped like someone who understood service work in his bones, and wrote a note under the receipt: Proud of you. Also—best latte portrait of me I’ve ever seen.

Her break landed twenty minutes later. She asked with her eyes; he nodded. Staff door. Short hallway smelling of coffee grounds and hairspray. She ducked into the nook by the lockers, back against the wall, and exhaled the persona like a cloak slipping off a hook.

“Five minutes,” she said, normal voice, relief rich in it. “Can I—?” She lifted her hands, paused for yes.

“Yes,” he said.

Quick hug. Not long, not clingy—just a reset. Her forehead pressed his sternum exactly where Hikari liked to count breaths; her shoulders melted. “Thank you for following the rules,” she murmured. “And for the Look. That was a good Look.”

“I practice in the mirror,” he said gravely. “My ‘disappointed principal’ face is coming along.”

She laughed into his shirt. “You were so cute, doing the meow.” She tilted up, thumb brushing a sugar smudge from his jaw. “I’m keeping that memory forever.”

“Please don’t subpoena the security footage.”

“Too late. I’m getting it framed.” She checked the hallway clock, then him. “Status?”

“Green. Proud. Mildly sticky.”

She fished a damp wipe from her apron like a stage magician. “I’ve got you.” A few efficient swipes. “There. Less frosting; more boyfriend.”

He squeezed her hand and let go first. “Want me to wait and walk you to the bus after shift?”

“Yes,” she said, eyes bright. “But not inside. I’ll be too tempted to violate like three rules. There’s a bench across the street.”

“Bench it is. I’ll bring a victory drink.”

“Something with… lychee.” She kissed the air near his cheek—one centimeter from breaking a boundary, perfectly respectful. “Back to work.”

He returned to the café long enough to catch her re-donning the sparkle like armor: a twirl, a wink, a perfectly pitched “Welcome home!” for the next table. Then he slipped out to the bench, texted the

group chat (Rebecka: hope she sparkles today; Hikari: proud of both of you), and grabbed two canned lychee sodas from the corner store.

When Alice emerged at closing, hair a little wilted, feet tired, eyes still starlit, he stood and held one out like a medal. She popped it with a hiss, clinked it against his.

"To rules," she said.

"To choices," he answered.

"And to you meowing in public," she added, wicked.

"Never speak of it again," he begged.

"Absolutely not," she said, smiling, and tucked herself under his arm for the walk to the bus—off the clock, off the stage, still very much Alice.

They were four at the bus stop that night—Alice off shift with glitter still clinging to her hair, Hikari in her neat hoodie with the tablet cross-body, Rebecka in her indigo scarf, Niklas with two lychee sodas and the soft, foolish happiness of walking everyone home.

The sidewalk was a sleeve of light. The corner past the convenience store was not.

They noticed the men the way you notice weather—first as pressure, then as sound.

"Hey, maid-chan," one called, syrup-thick. Another whistle. Footsteps angling in.

Alice's smile tightened and dropped—professional sparkle off. She pivoted toward Hikari without touching her. "Close," she said, low.

Hikari slid to her side immediately, hand on the tablet; her other hand found Rebecka's wrist and passed it to Niklas's, creating a little chain. Rebecka's fingers squeezed once—ready—and he answered twice—with you.

The men fanned a loose semicircle, too casual. One took a step too near, wrist outstretched like he'd already been given something. "Selfie, cutie."

"Boundary," Alice said, clear as a bell. She pointed to the well-lit patch of pavement with the café's yellow CCTV sign still visible in the distance. "From there."

He smiled like he hadn't heard English before. "Come on."

Niklas felt it then—the thing he tried to drown. It didn't explode. It narrowed. The world reduced to edges and paths, to angles of elbows and the weight of a wrist in a hand. Heat left his face; his voice, when it came, was very calm.

"Back up," he said, stepping between Alice and the reaching hand. "Now."

Hikari's tablet spoke a fraction later, velvet-soft and perfectly audible. TTS: "We are recording live. Camera right. Police called if needed."

She wasn't lying; her thumb was already on the emergency app, location ping queued. Rebecka's head tilted, listening past the men—cars at the light, a couple across the street, a shopkeeper smoking under an awning. She projected her voice just so. "Sir? Would you mind watching these gentlemen with us?" The shopkeeper glanced over, surprised into participation by how politely he'd been conscripted.

The nearest guy tried to laugh it off and stepped again. Niklas stepped with him, larger, not touching, a wall that had been built for this exact moment.

"Back. Up." The words were flat stones laid on water. He didn't raise his voice. He didn't need to.

Something in his face must have changed, because Alice's breath hitched. She knew his sarcasm, his gentleness, his meow-for-parfait humility. This was different. His eyes had gone winter-blue, empty of everything but math: distance, force, exits.

Her hand hovered at his back without landing. "Niklas?" she asked, checking the thread.

"I've got you," he said, without moving his eyes.

The outstretched hand became a shove, small and mean, testing. Niklas caught the wrist—just the wrist—and set it down again with a precision that said I could far louder than any swing. The man's surprise blinked. The semicircle faltered.

Hikari's TTS didn't change tone. TTS: "Camera sees you. Path to the right is clear. Leave now."

Rebecka took a step diagonally, guiding the shape of their group toward the lighted pavement, body angled to keep Alice inside the triangle they made. "We are going that way," she told the air, as if narrating a safe crossing.

A second man muttered something ugly in Japanese. Hikari's thumbs flicked. TTS (same calm): "I understood that. Leave now."

The shove-wrist looked at Niklas again and recalculated. Whatever he saw—the height, the stillness, the very particular way the big man hadn't hit him when he had the chance—softened his bravado. He snorted, stepped back, gestured to his friends like this had been his idea. "Whatever," he said, already losing face for a different audience. "Not worth it."

They peeled off, loud on purpose, the way cowards do when the show is for each other. The shopkeeper gave a little salute. The crosswalk changed to WALK; the four of them moved on its permission.

Only when they were under the café's bright awning again did Niklas's shoulders drop. The cold left his face all at once. He swallowed, jaw shaking.

Alice reached for him. He flinched.

"Sorry," he said hoarsely, backing half a step. His hands were open as if he'd been caught with something sharp. "I—I didn't want you to see that."

Rebecka pivoted toward his voice, sensing the crack she couldn't watch but could hear. "See what?" she asked, gentle and exact. "Your boundary?"

"My… monster," he said, the word too loud in his own mouth. "The part that wants to break things when someone touches you without asking." He looked at his empty hands like they were stained. "I should have told you I have that in me. I try to drown it. I didn't want it to scare you."

Hikari stepped in front of him, small and absolute, tablet at her side. She tilted her chin up until he met her eyes. Then she typed.

TTS (soft): "I saw your choices. Not a monster. A line."

Alice exhaled and closed the rest of the distance, slow, telegraphing touch before she landed it—a palm on his chest over the sternum, where his heart knocked too loud. "You didn't swing," she said. "You didn't go hunting. You made a wall. You were… terrifying, but not to me. For me." Her laugh shook. "Also extremely hot, which we will unpack later with responsible systems and snacks."

Rebecka found his wrist and pressed her fingers to his pulse, steadying it with the absurd human magic of contact. "If you had hidden that part on purpose," she said, "I would be hurt. But you're naming it now, when it's hardest. That's not hiding. That's brave."

He choked on a laugh. "I feel… foul. Like I brought blood into the library."

"You brought a fire extinguisher," Rebecka corrected. "And you didn't pull the pin unless you had to."

Hikari leaned her shoulder into his ribs, the weight of her like an anchor dropping. TTS: "We'll design a protocol. For next time, if there is one."

"Next time?" he echoed, horrified.

"Life," Alice said, grim and sweet. "There's always a chance. So we make rules like we do for everything." She held up fingers, counting. "One: We try exit first. Two: Hikari calls and narrates. Three: Rebecka crowdsources witnesses with her polite librarian voice. Four: I do the theater—loud

boundaries, draw attention. Five: You stand between and only touch to remove or defend. Six: Code words."

"Code words," Hikari agreed, already typing. TTS: "When your protective mode switches on, say 'Red Wolf.' When we need you to downshift, we'll say 'Blue Tea.'"

Niklas let out a helpless sound that might have been a laugh. "You're giving it a leash."

"We're giving it a job," Rebecka said. "And a tea break."

He scrubbed a hand over his face. "I'm sorry."

"Thank you," Alice said at the exact same time, and then all three of them laughed because of course they did.

They didn't go home right away. The café's corner table held them like a harbor until the sea inside Niklas stopped throwing sparks. When the trembling settled to a buzz, he looked at their three faces and made a choice.

"There is something I need you to understand," he said, voice rough. "It's a dragon."

Alice's fingers tightened around her mug. "Okay."

He nodded, eyes on the table. "When it wakes, I don't get angry in the usual way. I get… empty and efficient. It decides the situation is a fire and it becomes the fire extinguisher—and if I go over the edge, I can't hear you fast enough. That's the danger."

Hikari set her tablet down and didn't type; she just watched him, steady.

"I didn't go over tonight," he went on. "But I need to be crystal about what happens if I do. You deserve the un-pretty version."

Rebecka leaned in, voice soft. "We're listening."

He counted on his fingers, slow and deliberate.

"First: signs I'm close. My face goes blank, I stop blinking, my answers shrink to one word, I start mapping exits and weapons without meaning to. If I plant my feet and drop my shoulders, that's two steps from… breaking point."

"Second: triggers. Someone smaller getting grabbed. Hands on your throats or wrists. Corners. That particular laugh some men do when they've decided the room belongs to them."

"Third: if I tip over—the dragon doesn't do threats. It moves. I will remove the threat as fast as possible and I will not hear jokes or endearments. I might not register you in the first seconds, and if you're between me and the threat, that's… bad."

Alice swallowed, but she didn't look away. "Thank you for saying it like that."

He met each of their eyes in turn. "So we need rules that protect you from me, too. Not because I want to hurt you. Because the dragon doesn't care who it singes on the way to the fire."

Hikari nodded once, businesslike, and tapped her tablet. The speaker announced, "Protocols."

They built it together, simple and firm:

Code words

Red Dragon = Niklas is entering protective mode, close to tipping.

White Candle = the group needs to slow everything down now (everyone freezes, narrates positions, no sudden moves).

Blue Tea = Niklas downshifts; if he responds appropriately, he says it back.

Positions

Hikari: distance + command center. Calls emergency, records, narrates clearly ("Two men at ten o'clock, moving away," etc.). Never touches Niklas when he's Red Dragon.

Rebecka: witness wrangler. She engages nearby adults in that calm librarian voice, creates eyes on the scene, stays behind Niklas's line, keeps Alice anchored.

Alice: theater and space-making. Loud boundaries, draws attention, points to cameras/bright areas. No physical contact with Niklas once he says “Red Dragon.”

Niklas: only blocks and extracts. No pursuit. If contact is unavoidable, release immediately once space is made; step back, hands visible, say “Blue Tea” out loud.

Hard stops

If Niklas does not respond to White Candle or cannot say Blue Tea within five seconds after space is created, Hikari calls police immediately and Rebecka names him to them so they know who he is and that he’s the protector, not the aggressor.

No one grabs Niklas from behind, ever.

After any incident, they go to light + people, then home. No hero laps.

They sat with the list a moment. The café hum filled the gaps.

Alice exhaled. “I hate that we need this,” she admitted, eyes bright. “I love that we have it.”

Niklas’s mouth twisted. “I am ashamed I bring a dragon to our doorstep.”

Rebecka shook her head, gentle and implacable. “You didn’t bring it tonight. It’s been with you a long time. Today you put a bell on it and told us where it sleeps.”

Hikari reached into her bag, produced a narrow white silicone wristband, and slid it across the table. Embossed in tiny letters: BLUE TEA on one side, WHITE CANDLE on the other.

“I made these after the bus stop,” she said. “I hoped we wouldn’t need them so soon.”

He turned the band in his fingers, throat tight. “Thank you.”

Alice sniffed, then tried for lightness and almost made it. “Also, for the record? The dragon is terrifying. And I am still not scared of you.”

“Even if I look… gone?” he asked.

“Especially then,” she said. “Because you told me what ‘gone’ means. I can help you come back.”

Hikari tapped the table twice, a small ceremony. “Practice?”

They stood in their little corner and rehearsed the worst day like it was a dance: Niklas said “Red Dragon” and stepped into a guard stance; Hikari backed to her command spot and used her phone to narrate positions in a calm voice; Rebecka turned to the room and asked a nonexistent barista to please keep an eye on things; Alice drew a bright verbal line on the floor, palms out. Then Hikari said, “White Candle,” and they all froze. Niklas made his breath big, visible. Alice said, “Blue Tea,” and he said it back, louder the second time.

By the third rep, his shoulders had come down. The dragon sat, watching, not banished—named.

They walked home through brighter streets. On the stairs, Niklas paused and faced them, the wristband catching the hall light.

“One more thing I need you to know,” he said. “If I ever do tip over and you can’t reach me with words… don’t be brave. Get away. I can survive hating myself for a night. I cannot survive hurting you.”

Rebecka stepped forward first, found his hand, and placed it flat against her steadying palm. “We won’t test that,” she said. “We’ll use our words. And our feet.”

Alice pressed her forehead to his chest for a count of three. “And our very loud indoor voices.”

Hikari lifted her tablet at last, typed a single line, and let it speak.

TTS (soft): “Systems keep love safe. Dragons included.”

He laughed, broke, and let them fold him in—the careful kind of hug that doesn’t crowd, that says home without demanding anything back. The shame didn’t vanish. It just had somewhere to sit that wasn’t his ribs.

Later, the wristband lay on the nightstand beside four glasses of water and a phone with their new emergency widget on the first screen. They slept with the light on low, not because they were afraid of the dark, but because they'd chosen to be seen.

Monday — Systems & Soft Landings

Hikari posts the Red Dragon / White Candle / Blue Tea protocol on the fridge (laminated, naturally). They rehearse once after dinner—thirty seconds, then Blue Tea and tea-tea.

Rebecka leads a short "how's your body?" round; Niklas admits to a lingering adrenaline hangover. Alice prescribes cartoons + foot rub rotation. They fall asleep on the huge bed like a four-piece puzzle, the bedside wristband catching lamp glow.

Tuesday — Workday Orbits

Niklas codes, hits a logic snarl, texts borrow box deployed. Hikari replies with a tiny checklist emoji.

At lunch, Rebecka records an audiobook snippet for a friend and tests Hikari's catalog app improvements. She messages the group: cello break at 15:00? They all put in five minutes of breathing when her timer chimes.

Evening: Alice hand-stitches boning into a bodice while narrating a scandalous historical fact every ten minutes to keep morale high. Hikari leans over and installs a new bobbin holder so the thread stops fleeing the machine "like a tiny horse."

Wednesday — Micro-Adventure

They try the neighborhood night market. Crowd noise = big. Hikari toggles her door-light keychain to green (all good), then amber when it swells. Rebecka threads her arm through Alice's; Niklas runs interference with smiles and "pardon me"s.

A street magician asks for volunteers; Alice volunteers Niklas's ring for a trick. He returns it with a flourish and a wink at the trio.

On the walk home, a scooter skids close—everyone's pulses spike—but no code words needed. Hikari still narrates "scooter left, moving away." Niklas breathes big on purpose. They grade themselves B+ and split a crepe for extra credit.

Thursday — Doors & Solitude

Everyone takes private-room hours seriously.

Rebecka cocoons in the Listening Library, beanbag plus rain soundtrack, marking passages with tactile tabs. She pins a quote to the corkboard: "Courage is not the absence of fear, but the triumph over it."

Hikari edits three shorts, plants watered, cables perfect. She leaves a sticky note for Alice: "You are allowed to rest mid-project."

Alice reworks a sleeve pattern, lights her partner shrines, whispers thanks, and actually naps.

Niklas paints edge highlights on a tiny cloak; messes it; learns to feather it back without swearing. He leaves a reset token in his own tray—self-grace counts.

Friday — Café Sparkle & Alley Calm

Niklas visits Alice at the café again (rules followed; meow performed exactly once under duress). A rowdy table snickers; Alice does theater, Hikari (remote) is on call; nothing escalates.

Closing time, they walk home the long-lit route. On the stairs, Niklas pauses, taps the wristband, and says Blue Tea anyway—not because he's triggered, but to condition the response. Alice salutes with a straw like a tiny sword. Rebecka laughs into his shoulder. Hikari logs "rehearsal in the wild—successful."

Saturday — Pancake Redemption (Kind Of)

The Pancake Arc begins at 10:00 with a fire extinguisher present and four spotters.

Hikari runs a two-burner plan.

Alice plates like a Michelin witch.

Rebecka reads texture by spatula resistance and calls flips.

Niklas does batter, whispers “please behave” to the skillet.

Result: two heroic pancakes, one abstract sculpture. They eat on the floor under the shelf they built, laughing. Niklas declares victory; Alice frames the ugliest one as modern art in the atelier (“Study in Hubris, 2025”).

Afternoon: board game in the Chapel of Small Monsters—Rebecka and Hikari co-strategize; Alice narrates like a sports caster; Niklas paints a base between turns.

Sunday — Family, Then Us

Brunch with Hikari’s parents again, this time in a park. Hikari chooses her adult register today; she hands her mother a printed copy of the “walk-home plan” because “systems reduce worry.” Her father asks Niklas about Swedish forests; Niklas talks mushrooms and the way twilight stretches in summer.

Evening debrief on the huge bed:

One gratitude each.

Alice: “Your patience with my chaos.”

Rebecka: “The way we practiced instead of pretending.”

Hikari: “Our protocols are boring now. Good.”

Niklas: “That you love all my rooms. Even the one with the dragon.”

They stack hands. The wristband joins the little bowl of reset tokens on the nightstand—used, known, quietly unscary.

Epilogue: A Text Thread Snapshot (Week’s End)

Hikari: “New widget: one-tap ‘we’re safe, heading home.’ Installed.”

Rebecka: “Whoever left bergamot tea on my cart gets first pick of tomorrow’s cookies.”

Alice: “I did, and I demand tribute in kisses. Also, I fixed the sleeve.” [photo: perfect seam]

Niklas: “Borrow box empty. Pancake sculpture gazing at me with judgment. I accept it.”

Hikari: “Judgment deferred. Pride confirmed.”

All three: “Goodnight.”

Niklas: “Home.”

A week measured not just in days, but in practiced kindness—the kind that makes the next week easier, and the dragon a little better at sleeping.

The sign said “Family Restaurant” in cheerful katakana, a bright island of booths and laminated dreams. Inside was all red vinyl, dessert posters, and the happy chaos of clinking plates. Perfectly ordinary—exactly why they’d chosen it.

“Table for four?” the host asked.

Alice lifted a hand like a tiny flag. “Corner booth, please—my boyfriend is tall and my girlfriends are adorable.”

They slid in—Niklas on the aisle (knees, fate), Rebecka beside him (hand steady on the table’s edge), Hikari and Alice across. The drink bar gleamed like a small casino. Alice gasped. “We have to mix forbidden sodas.”

Hikari’s tablet chimed, velvet-low.

TTS: “Mission parameters: one chaos soda allowed per person.”

“Dictator,” Alice whispered, delighted.

Menus arrived—illustrated symphonies of “seasonal,” “limited,” and “cheese.” Rebecka traced the raised laminate corners as Niklas narrated like a culinary tour guide. “Hamburg steak with demi-glace, napolitan spaghetti, gratin that looks like a lava field, pancakes—no, not today—”

“Correct,” Rebecka said, smiling. “I’ll try the hamburg. And the corn soup. And… tell me about desserts again?”

Alice leaned over, voice like an infomercial fairy. “Parfait tower with mysterious cereal at the bottom.”

“Say less,” Rebecka murmured.

They ordered like a tiny committee. Hikari calibrated timing (soups first, then mains), added a side of edamame “for finger fidgets,” and flashed a tiny thumbs-up at the waiter who took her tablet as easily as speech.

The drink bar became a pilgrimage. Niklas returned with hot coffee he swore smelled like courage. Alice concocted a cola-grape-ginger monstrosity and christened it “Purple Lightning.” Hikari layered melon soda and soda water to a perfect gradient, then added one illicit cherry. Rebecka chose hot tea and held the cup under her nose, smiling at the cinnamon note like a secret handshake.

“Toast?” Alice said, raising her glass.

“To family restaurants,” Niklas offered.

“To ordinary nights,” Rebecka added.

TTS: “To systems that let us be silly,” Hikari finished.

They clinked and giggled when Niklas’s claw ring made a tiny “ting.”

Food arrived in three waves, cheerful and fast. Steam halos. The hamburg sang when sliced; corn soup tasted like childhood; the napolitan draped ketchup like art. Alice fed Niklas a bite with the ceremonial seriousness of knighting him; he in turn rotated Rebecka’s plate clockwise between courses so “new landscapes” kept finding her fork. Hikari’s eyes kept smiling without moving; she’d chosen the creamy gratin and ate with the focus of someone solving a good puzzle.

A table of teens nearby dissolved into hysterics over a gacha app pull. A toddler two booths over announced a microscopically important fact in a yell-whisper. It was bright and busy and safe. When the crowd swelled, Hikari quietly toggled her keychain to amber. Alice clocked it and slid a little closer to the aisle; Niklas matched her without thinking. No dragon required—just choreography.

Dessert was absurd. The parfait tower arrived with Pocky like antennae, a flag of whipped cream, and the mysterious cereal layer that tasted like sweet pebbles. “Anthropology,” Rebecka decided after a thoughtful crunch. “I like it.”

They lingered until the dinner rush softened to a hum. Bills paid, tips added, leftovers boxed (Alice’s personal crusade). Outside, the night had put on its neon. A half-moon hooked itself over the buildings like jewelry.

“So,” Alice said, pretending to stretch while actually bouncing. “We could go home. OR.”

Hikari’s tablet lit.

TTS (blithe): “Vampire manor again.”

Rebecka angled her head toward the sky. “I did wear the good perfume.”

Niklas, already doomed, laughed. “I brought water and moral fiber.”

“Keep the water,” Alice said, taking his hand. “We’ll provide the rest.”

They chose a quiet side street. The love hotel’s sign glowed discreetly, a constellation of available rooms like elevator buttons. Hikari picked with a decisive tap; Alice looped Rebecka’s arm as they rode the lift; Niklas held the little bag like a squire—charger, snacks, consent kit.

The room was different tonight—soft lighting, paper screens, a bath that looked like a moonlit pond. Hikari set her tablet on the console and, without ceremony, started the aftercare kit pile: towels, water, chocolate, the small hourglass she always flipped even if they ignored it.

Alice, already barefoot, bounced once and caught herself. “Rules?”

Rebecka laced their fingers, small squeeze. “Yes. Quick.”

They gathered like they always did—team huddle in a velvet world.

TTS (steady): “Green/yellow/red. Ask more than assume. Hydration fairy rotates: Alice first 20, Niklas next, then me. No ‘heroics.’ If anyone says White Candle, we freeze. If Niklas says Red Dragon, we switch choreography and keep bodies behind him until it passes. Tonight should be soft; we can choose soft.”

“Choosing soft,” Alice echoed, suddenly quiet and shining.

Rebecka lifted her chin toward Niklas. “Status?”

He checked in, honest. “Green. Happy. A little reverent.”

“Me too,” she said.

They didn’t rush the rest. Shoes in a neat line. Laughter unpacked beside the mini-fridge. Hikari started the bath, steam threading the room like silk. Alice dimmed the lamps until the space turned honey-slow.

Everything after that was implication and warmth: whispered jokes traded like sweets, a choreographed clink of water bottles, the way Hikari’s hand spelled okay on a wrist before the tablet ever spoke it, Rebecka’s voice naming pleasures and pauses with librarian precision, Alice sprinkling joy like glitter exactly where it helped, Niklas saying Blue Tea once just because he could and hearing three soft echoes answer him without hesitation.

Later, the hourglass lay sideways, ignored and content. Four bodies floated in a bath big enough to be a small sea, hair slicked back, cheeks glowing. Alice balanced a Pocky stick over her lip like a moustache and made Rebecka snort-laugh; Hikari recorded exactly three seconds of the steam to remember the sound; Niklas pressed his forehead to the cool tile and thought: ordinary night, extraordinary we.

When they finally tumbled into the bed (a cloud this time, not a coffin), they did the ritual debrief even half-asleep—one word each.

Alice: “Joyful.”

Rebecka: “Held.”

Hikari (TTS, barely above a whisper): “Sated.”

Niklas: “Home.”

Outside, the city flickered. Inside, four people practiced being simple and safe and silly, and ended the evening where they always wanted to end up—together, and seen.

The blowup started as a calendar.

Hikari’s big screen showed the week in perfect rectangles. Purple: Alice—Con: Costume Contest, 18:00 Saturday. Green: Rebecka—Library: Author talk + accessibility Q&A, 16:00–19:00. Blue: Niklas—Community center: miniatures demo for kids, 14:00–18:00. Gold: Hikari—Charity collab stream, 17:00–20:00.

Four blocks. One evening. A single apartment’s worth of hearts trying to be everywhere.

Alice stared, hands on hips, lace-trimmed tee like a banner of joy at half-mast. “I told you about the contest a month ago.”

Hikari’s jaw was calm, eyes not. She typed, then didn’t press play; she spoke quietly instead. “The charity slot was booked six weeks ago. Contracts.”

Rebecka, on the sofa, set her phone down. “My author talk was… also six weeks ago. We did dates together, didn’t we?”

Niklas rubbed his eyebrow with the heel of his hand, the way he did when logic puzzles went sideways. “The demo’s for kids. They made flyers with my name.”

Alice’s laugh came out like a glitter jar knocked over. “Great. So none of you can be there when I face a thousand ring lights wearing a dress that took three all-nighters? Good to know.”

Hikari’s back straightened. “That’s not fair.”

“Neither is me finding out like this,” Alice shot back, immediate regret in her eyes but words already airborne.

Rebecka leaned forward, palms open. “Let’s not turn a scheduling knot into a loyalty test.”

“Too late,” Alice said, softer but still too sharp. “It already feels like one.”

Silence clapped down, awkward and hot.

Niklas took a breath to “fix it” and made it worse. “I can probably cancel the kids—”

“No,” Rebecka and Alice said at once—Rebecka kind, Alice horrified at herself. Hikari’s phone chimed its own firm objection.

Rebecka put two fingers against the table edge—tiny ritual. “White Candle,” she said, steady. “Freeze. We’re spiraling.”

They froze. Shoulders down. Breaths in the same slow count. Hikari flipped the little hourglass they used for hard conversations; grains hissed.

“Okay,” Rebecka said when the first minute passed. “New format. No rebuttals. Story I’m telling myself, what I need, one thing I can give. I’ll go first.”

She folded her hands. “Story I’m telling myself: I finally get to advocate publicly for blind readers and if no one’s there, it means I’m… doing it alone again.” She exhaled. “What I need: to know it matters to you even if you’re not physically present. One thing I can give: I can help plan rides and backup batteries so we’re not scrambling.”

She tapped the table. “Hikari?”

Hikari nodded once. “Story I’m telling myself: if I cancel a charity contract, I prove everyone right who thinks my job isn’t real. Also… I promised the org. What I need: explicit words that I’m not ‘abandoning’ you by honoring it. One thing I can give: I will schedule morale breaks around the contest time to cheer in real time.”

Alice swallowed, mascara an inch from trouble. “Story I’m telling myself: I’m the ‘fun’ one so it’s fine to leave me to perform alone. What I need: one of you in my line of sight when I walk on stage—even if it’s a camera. One thing I can give: I can move my pre-judging to earlier to increase the chances someone can be there for part of it.”

They all looked at Niklas.

He stared at the calendar blocks like they were enemies he couldn’t paint over. “Story I’m telling myself: I’m the least… important one. Minis. Kids. It’s not a Big Cause. So I should be the one to give way, and if I don’t, I’m selfish.” He winced at his own honesty. “What I need: permission to keep a promise to the small humans without you thinking less of me. One thing I can give: I can set up livestream links and be your offsite tech squire so I’m basically in three places at once.”

The hourglass hissed to a stop. No one moved.

Alice pressed her hands to her eyes and spoke through her fingers. “I’m sorry for saying ‘Good to know.’ I was scared and I turned it into drama. I don’t think your work isn’t real, Hikari. And, Niklas, you’re not the least anything.”

Hikari's voice stayed low. "I'm sorry for going flat. I felt… accused. I should have said 'I'm hurt' instead of 'that's not fair.'"

Rebecka bit her lip. "I'm sorry for acting like we could logic our way out before touching feelings. I should have called 'White Candle' sooner."

Niklas's mouth quirked. "I'm sorry for 'I can cancel the kids.' That was… my shame talking, not my values."

They didn't rush the fix. They made a plan like four adults who wanted to stay in love.

Hikari would do the charity stream from the green room at the con venue for the first hour, so she could physically walk Alice to pre-judging and be present for a quick pep—and then return for the last contest segment after signing off. She messaged the charity team for a slightly adjusted run of show. They said yes. (She'd built trust for exactly this.)

Rebecka would emcee the author talk (she'd been asked to anyway), then leave at 18:30 with a pre-arranged car to meet Alice and Hikari for the awards segment at 19:00. The library director, looped in with kindness, cheered and arranged a colleague to wrap the last Q&A.

Niklas would run the kids' demo joyfully, then set up a private video feed from his phone to a tiny clip on Alice's bouquet ribbon, so when she looked down before steps, she'd see his face grinning like an idiot. He'd also time his break to the exact moment before Alice walked out, duck into a stairwell, and be a disembodied but very real voice: "You've got this; your seam work is a miracle; remember to breathe on the turn."

Alice would block out two fifteen-minute windows before and after judging to send quick voice notes: one to the library (good luck to the author!), one to the charity chat (break a leg, streamers!), and one to the community center kids ("your skeleton warriors are cooler than mine, don't tell anyone").

They put it on the calendar and, more importantly, in their mouths.

"I will not think less of you for keeping your promises," Alice said to Niklas, hand steady on his.

"I will not hear 'your job isn't real' in the silence," Hikari's phone said to Alice as Hikari tapped OK on her wrist.

"I will not read 'alone' into you not being in the front row," Rebecka said to both, voice like linen.

"And I will not… martyr myself," Niklas said to all of them, cheeks pink. "If I need you, I'll say it, not hope you guess."

They breathed. Shoulders dropped. Nobody had "won," which felt like the win.

Later, as they made dinner (no pancakes), Alice bumped shoulders with Hikari. "Can I ask something dorky?"

Hikari's mouth softened. "Always."

"If the charity chat is between segments, can you send me one 'systems love you' at T-minus-two minutes?" Alice asked.

Hikari's eyes warmed. "I will schedule it. And I'll mean it."

Rebecka slid a bowl toward Niklas. "And you? One dorky ask?"

He scratched his cheek, shy. "Could you… pin a little quote to your corkboard for me? For Saturday? Something like 'It matters to small humans when big humans show up.'"

She smiled. "Done."

They ate at the table, a little raw and a little proud. Before bed, nobody reached for the wristband or the safety widget; instead, they wrote three tiny notes and taped them to the fridge:

Alice: I want you there. If you can't be, I still want you.

Hikari: Work is real. Love is, too. We can hold both.

Rebecka: Together ≠ same place. Together = same direction.

Niklas: Promises kept are love languages.

They slept close but not clutched, the kind of closeness that breathes. In the morning, the calendar still had four rectangles. None had moved. But all of them had.

Chapter 5
Home, in Small Rituals

Morning slips into the apartment like a cat—quiet, inevitable, and already making itself at home.

The kettle clicks off. Hikari pads across the tatami in oversized socks, sleeves swallowed by a black cardigan that looks two sizes too big. She moves with the practiced hush of someone who's learned to be gentle with noise. A soft chime from her phone—tonight's stream reminder—she flips it face down and exhales through her nose, as if filing the thought away in a tidy drawer.

Hikari typed into her phone, careful not to disturb the morning. The speaker murmured, "Tea. Rebecka? You up?"

From down the hall, the faint tapping of a cane against the door frame. Rebecka emerges, hair a little rebellious, pajama shirt misbuttoned by one loop. She is smiling already—she usually is in the mornings, like a person who has decided sunrise is a promise kept.

"I'm here," she says, and pauses to locate the smell of the tea. "Hojicha?"

"Mm." Hikari presses the warm mug into Rebecka's hands and lets their fingers overlap a second longer than necessary. "Alice should be off soon."

"Did she text?"

Hikari tilts her head toward the coffee table, where a phone buzzes like an excitable beetle. "Yep."

Rebecka's cane finds the low sofa, a chair, then the edge of the coffee table. Hikari narrates the room's little hazards with a quick, familiar cadence: "Cosplay bin on the left—watch the open lid—braille labels are facing you. I left your bag by the umbrella stand. Phone is near your wrist."

"Arigatou." Rebecka's fingers skim the braille tape Hikari stuck on the storage bin last week: gloves, ribbon, EVA foam. "You added 'ribbon.'"

"You kept stealing the sash for your hair."

"I was accessorizing."

The lock snicks, the door swings open, and Alice pours in with a gust of late-morning city air. She's still half in uniform from the night shift—black-and-white maid dress under a plain jacket, collar askew, a tiny lace headband clipped in her hair because she forgot it was there. She's carrying a paper bag that smells like warm melon pan and fresh coffee.

"I brought bribes," Alice announces, then softens instantly as she spots Rebecka. "—And breakfast. Mind the shoes; I left them lined up straight this time. Hi, you." She leans to kiss Hikari's temple, stopping just short as if asking permission with her eyes. Hikari tips her head, and Alice smiles, pecks lightly, then sets down the bag.

Rebecka grins in their direction. "If it's melon pan, I call first pick by virtue of being the earliest awake."

"You weren't awake when I decided to buy them," Alice counters, already moving through the room like she grew up here, lifting a stack of pattern books with her foot, balancing a roll of fabric on her shoulder. "Also, I owe you two for proofreading my con schedule. So yes, first pick."

Her wrists are inked with faint red grooves where elastic sleeves have lived all night; she rubs at them and rolls her shoulders. Hikari's eyes find the marks. "Do they still dig in?"

"Only if I forget to breathe," Alice says, wry. "Which I do, because table four thinks the latte art is a performance piece."

Hikari's mouth lifts at one corner. "It is."

Alice points. “See? Validation.”

They eat on the floor because the table is a sewing battlefield. Morning hums: a kettle reboils, the laundry machine argues with itself, a scooter complains on the street. Rebecka tears the bread gently, memorizing the size of each piece. Hikari refills her tea without asking; Alice tucks a napkin into Rebecka’s palm like a magician revealing a card.

“Library practice today?” Alice asks.

“Mm.” Rebecka nods. “Sorting donations. I like the way dust sounds.” She taps her ear, smiling at her own joke. “And the new Braille labeler came in. Hikari’s promised to help me set the shortcuts.”

“I have.” Hikari’s voice has the softness of a secret kept. “And I’ll be back before your volunteer shift ends. Stream starts at nine tonight.”

Alice’s eyes flick up, quick and bright. “Theme?”

Hikari opens the notebook lying by her elbow, pages fanned with sticky notes. She has drawn a tiny bat, a lace choker, a cartoon teacup. “Gothic ‘Mommy’s Study Hall.’ The chat’s supposed to do their homework. Nothing weird, just… accountability co-working.”

Alice practically vibrates. “You’re going to deadpan at them when they forget to hydrate.”

“I am,” Hikari answers, but she’s blushing at the edges. “And I’ll keep the voice low.”

“Mm, the voice,” Alice says, dreamy and too honest. Then she catches herself, cheeks going pink. “I mean—it’s effective.”

Rebecka laughs, a warm bell. “It is. Even I sit up straighter on the couch.”

They clean together without assigning roles, the shared choreography of people who have learned each other’s rhythms. Hikari clears dishes first—quiet, precise. Alice gathers stray pins from the tatami, counting aloud so Rebecka can help (twelve… thirteen… there’s always one that hides). Rebecka folds the spare blanket by the balcony, fingers smoothing along the knit ribs until the corners are square. When she finishes, she lingers there, face tilted toward the slice of outdoor air and traffic lullaby. Tokyo has a taste at this hour: metal and bread and morning spores.

“I’ll walk you,” Hikari says to Rebecka, and the way she says it is small but absolute.

“And I’ll crash here,” Alice adds. “My shift was feral. Wake me before dinner and tell me to eat a vegetable.”

“You will eat two,” Rebecka decrees.

Alice bows, theatrical even in exhaustion. “Hai, Librarian-sama.”

On the way to the door, Hikari stops at her streaming corner—just a desk and a mic, a ring light that lives mostly off—and checks the angle by muscle memory. She taps the foam pop filter like she’s tapping an old friend’s shoulder. Rebecka’s cane clicks softly while she ties her shoes.

“Hey,” Alice calls from the futon she’s commandeered, voice already sliding toward sleep, “send me your outfit plan for Sunday. Con staff wants the guest list early.”

“You’re not staff,” Hikari reminds her.

“I’m a benevolent terror adjacent to staff.” Alice mimes typing on an invisible tablet, eyes closed. “Also… I like organizing the things you’re excited about.”

Hikari opens her mouth, closes it, and then says, very quietly, “Thank you.”

They leave Alice a glass of water and a note that says: two vegetables. Alice has drawn a tiny carrot frowning in authority.

Outside, the hallway is cool and smells faintly of someone else’s curry. Hikari narrates the environment for Rebecka the way she always does: “Three paces to the elevator. Button is left column, second one down. The janitor’s left the wet floor sign, triangular, to your right. I’m here.”

“I know.” Rebecka’s hand finds Hikari’s sleeve and squeezes. “But keep telling me anyway.”

The elevator hums. Hikari counts the floors under her breath, not because she needs to, but because Rebecka likes the rhythm, and because Hikari loves giving useful music to silence. In the lobby, the city is fully awake—bicycle bells, a child protesting a backpack, the sigh of bus doors. Hikari slips the hand loop of Rebecka's cane against her wrist while they wait at the crossing, a ritual that says more than protection; it says partnership.

"Are you nervous?" Rebecka asks, casual as tea cooling.

"About the stream?" Hikari pretends to think. "A little. The persona feels… large today."

"Then we shrink it when you're off," Rebecka says. "We wash the makeup and eat something unserious."

"Pancakes?" Hikari suggests, hopeful.

"With too much syrup," Rebecka confirms.

The signal chirps. They step off the curb together.

Back at the apartment, Alice dreams in stitches—zigzag, backstitch, running stitch—until the smell of evening finds her nose: soy and garlic and the warm green of something sautéed. She sits up, hair an obedient mess, and catches sight of a little note propped on the ring light: Stay hydrated, bunny. —M

Her face goes soft in a way she doesn't let anyone see at the café. She drinks half the glass and pads to the kitchen, where Hikari is in a plain T-shirt with her sleeves rolled, hair tied back with a scrap of black ribbon. Rebecka's voice floats from the little dining table, reading aloud from a braille volume, fingers gliding. It's a book about cataloging systems. It should be dry. She makes it sound like a poem.

"Two vegetables," Alice announces, and steals a snow pea from the pan. Hikari swats, misses on purpose.

Dinner is easy. Alice tells a story about a customer who tried to order a 'cosplay cappuccino' and then got embarrassed when she asked what that meant. Rebecka explains a volunteer she loves because the woman's laugh is off-tempo. Hikari listens like a collector, filing colors and shapes she'll use later when the stream turns on and the voice lowers and she becomes the gothic tutor who shepherds chat through their to-do lists.

When the time comes, she doesn't have to ask. Rebecka clears the table with efficient hands; Alice sets up the camera, checks the mic levels, angles the light away from Hikari's eyes. There's a moment just before they go live when Hikari takes a breath and hesitates. Alice is there, light, a kiss to the knuckle of Hikari's hand. Rebecka squeezes her shoulder, steady as bedrock.

"You've got this," Rebecka says.

"Go be terrifying," Alice adds, grinning.

Hikari nods, settles. The stream counter flickers awake. The red light blooms. Her voice lowers—silk with a spine.

"Good evening, class," she purrs into the mic, all velvet and command. "Let's begin."

Off-camera, Alice and Rebecka start their own tasks: pinning a seam, labeling a folder. The room becomes a small engine of parallel care. When chat forgets to drink water, Alice tips her own glass toward the camera with a silent toast. When someone in chat says they're scared of a big exam, Rebecka mouths: You can do it, as if the pixels can hear her. And when the stream ends, the persona folds away like a carefully hung coat, and Hikari returns to the couch, to the hands that take the weight off her shoulders without asking.

This is their everyday: not drama, not spectacle, but the gentle architecture of three lives braided together—tea and pins, braille and light, a city's hum beneath their shared roof—and the quiet promise that each night they will help each other become the softest, bravest versions of themselves again.

Sry can you rewtite it as hikari is mute and uses text to speech to communicate

Morning slips into the apartment like a cat—quiet and already at home.

The kettle clicks off. Hikari pads across the tatami in oversized socks, black cardigan swallowing her hands. She scoops up her phone, thumb flying. A soft chime, then her text-to-speech app speaks in a gentle contralto she's tuned to be warm and slow:

Rebecka appears at the hall, cane tapping the doorframe, pajama shirt misbuttoned by one loop. She smiles toward the steam. "Hojicha?"

Hikari nudges a mug into Rebecka's hands and lets their fingers overlap a second longer than necessary. Another tap on glass:

PHONE: "Alice—almost home."

The lock snicks. Alice breezes in with city air and a paper bag that smells like melon pan. Still half in maid uniform, collar askew, lace headband forgotten in her hair.

"I brought bribes," she declares—then softens. "And breakfast. Shoes lined up straight. Hi, you." She leans for a temple kiss; Hikari tips her head in permission, eyes smiling.

They settle on the floor because the table is a sewing battlefield. Hikari narrates the room's hazards with quick taps that become the phone's calm voice:

PHONE: "Cosplay bin open—left. Braille labels facing you. Bag by umbrella stand. Phone near your wrist."

Rebecka's fingers find the raised tape. "You added 'ribbon.'"

Hikari flashes her screen: a short message with a winking emoji. The speaker obliges:

PHONE: "You kept stealing the sash for your hair."

"I was accessorizing," Rebecka says, smug.

Alice rubs at the faint grooves on her wrists from elastic sleeves. Hikari notices, tilts her head, types:

PHONE: "Do they still dig in?"

"Only if I forget to breathe," Alice says. "Which I do, because table four thinks latte art is performance."

PHONE: "It is."

Alice points. "See? Validation."

They eat. The laundry argues with itself; a scooter complains on the street. Rebecka tears bread into even pieces. Hikari tops up her tea without asking. Alice tucks a napkin into Rebecka's palm like a magic trick.

"Library practice today?" Alice asks.

"Sorting donations," Rebecka nods. "And the new braille labeler's in. Hikari's promised to help set shortcuts."

Hikari taps:

PHONE: "Yes. Back before your shift ends. Stream at nine."

Alice perks up. "Theme?"

Hikari turns her notebook toward them—little sketches: a bat, lace choker, teacup—and types:

PHONE: "Gothic 'Mommy's Study Hall.' Chat does homework. Accountability co-working."

Alice practically vibrates. "You'll deadpan at them when they forget to hydrate."

Hikari's cheeks pink; she writes shorter:

"Effective," Rebecka says, trying not to laugh. "Even I sit up straighter."

Cleaning is unassigned choreography. Hikari clears dishes—quiet, precise. Alice counts fallen pins aloud so Rebecka can help (twelve… thirteen… always one that hides). Rebecka folds the balcony blanket, smoothing the knit ribs until the corners go square. When she finishes, she tilts her face toward the outdoor slice of air. Tokyo tastes like metal and bread.

Hikari's screen lights beside Rebecka's elbow:

PHONE: "I'll walk you."

"And I'll crash," Alice says, flopping onto the futon. "Wake me and make me eat a vegetable."

"Two," Rebecka decrees.

On the way out, Hikari checks her streaming corner—mic, ring light, the vocoder box she sometimes pairs with TTS for effect. She taps the foam filter like an old friend. Rebecka ties her shoes, cane resting on her knee.

From the futon, eyes already lidding, Alice calls, "Send me your outfit plan for Sunday. Staff wants an early list."

Hikari thumbs a reply; the speaker purrs:

PHONE: "You're not staff."

"I'm terror-adjacent," Alice mumbles, smiling. "Also, I like organizing what you're excited about."

Hikari hesitates, then types:

PHONE: "Thank you."

They leave a glass of water and a sticky note for Alice: two vegetables. Alice adds a doodle of a stern carrot before drifting off.

The hallway smells faintly of someone's curry. At the elevator, Hikari gives her usual, steady map:

PHONE: "Three paces. Button left column—second down. Wet floor sign right. I'm here."

"I know." Rebecka squeezes Hikari's sleeve. "But keep telling me anyway."

The elevator hums. Hikari counts floors with soft taps, then lets the phone voice them like a lullaby. Outside, bicycle bells and bus sighs. At the crossing, Hikari loops the cane strap gently over Rebecka's wrist—ritual, not rescue.

Rebecka asks, casual as cooling tea, "Nervous?"

Hikari types, pauses, edits, then lets it speak:

PHONE: "A little. Persona feels big today."

"Then we shrink it after," Rebecka says. "Wash the makeup. Eat something unserious."

"With too much syrup."

The signal chirps. They step off together.

Back home, evening smells like soy and garlic and the green snap of something sautéed. Alice wakes, hair a polite wreck, and spots a new note propped on the ring light: Stay hydrated, bunny. —M. Her face softens; she drains half the glass and pads to the kitchen. Hikari is in a plain T-shirt, sleeves rolled, hair tied with a scrap of black ribbon. Rebecka's voice floats from the table, reading cataloging rules like poetry.

"Two vegetables," Alice announces, stealing a snow pea. Hikari swats and misses on purpose, then types:

Dinner is easy. Alice tells a café story. Rebecka praises a volunteer with an off-tempo laugh. Hikari listens like a collector, thumbs resting on her phone, ready.

When stream time nears, Rebecka clears the table; Alice checks mic levels and positions the ring light away from Hikari's eyes. Hikari sits, posture settling, and opens the TTS app she uses on-camera—the same velvet contralto, now paired with a light reverb. She hesitates. Alice kisses her knuckles. Rebecka's hand rests on her shoulder, steady.

"You've got this," Rebecka says.

"Go be terrifying," Alice grins.

Hikari taps one line, then another. The counter flickers alive. Red light blooms. The room hears the persona arrive:

[STREAM VOICE]: “Good evening, class. Back straight, water nearby. Let’s begin.”

Off-camera, Alice pins a seam. Rebecka labels a folder. When chat forgets to hydrate, Alice raises her glass toward the lens in a silent toast. When someone types they’re scared of an exam, Hikari’s thumbs fly:

[STREAM VOICE]: “Fear acknowledged. Open your notes. We’ll climb it together.”

The session ends; the voice folds away like a coat on a careful hanger. Hikari returns to the couch where two pairs of hands make the world lighter without asking. This is their everyday: tea and pins, braille and light, a city’s hum under a shared roof—and the quiet promise that each night they’ll help each other become the softest, bravest versions of themselves again.

Chapter 6
Stolen Minutes

Monday

Niklas wakes before the alarms. He moves like a tide through the quiet apartment, setting phones on chargers, laying a heat pack across Rebecka's shoulders where she fell asleep over braille notes, and pressing a thermos into Alice's tote—coffee that tastes like dark chocolate and survival. He texts the group chat:

N: "Stand-up at 9. I'll cook tonight. Something soft on the throat."

Hikari lifts her phone, thumb floating. A soft synthetic voice blooms from the speaker:

Hikari: "Proud of you. All of you. Also, eat fruit. Doctor orders."

She's wearing an oversized hoodie with tiny embroidered bats. She pops a tangerine into Rebecka's hand, folds Rebecka's fingers around it, then taps her twice—a code that means with love, with luck.

By 8:15, Alice is already in transit, eyeliner sharp enough to deflect malice. She leaves a sticky note on the door in big marker letters for everyone else who will leave after her: "You're doing great even if your brain is yelling. —A" Under it, a little doodle of a wolf—then she frowns, scribbles it out, and replaces it with a dragon, big-eyed and fierce.

Tuesday

Rebecka is a constellation of lists and textures. She labels a new row of spice tins with braille dots that read "cumin, coriander, courage," and smiles to herself. Between classes, she sends voice memos—soft, careful Swedish vowels tucked into Japanese sentences—

"Jag saknar er. I miss you. Tonight, I will read to you. Ten minutes, no more, I promise."

Hikari's stream runs long; collab obligations. She messages the group as soon as she unplugs:

Hikari: "Door is locked. Soup on stove low. Do not apologize for being late. Just come home."

She sets bowls out, each with a different little garnish—scallions for Niklas, sesame for Alice, crispy garlic for Rebecka because the crunch makes her grin. Then she curls on the couch, phone on her chest like a purring cat, waiting.

Niklas arrives last, rain on his jacket. He pauses at the threshold to steady his breath; the dragon is a low room-temperature hum. Hikari crosses to him and presses her phone against his sternum; the voice is barely above a whisper:

Hikari: "You came back."

He laughs, a crack in the storm, and everyone exhales.

Wednesday

Alice's double shift tries to eat her alive. Between tables she records a whisper in the staff bathroom, the hand dryer roaring like surf:

"Hydrate, gremlins. Also, I saw a couple arguing, then he cut her omurice to look like a heart. Humans are weird, romantic, and annoying. Text me a photo of the cat if you see him."

Back home, Rebecka sits cross-legged on the rug, hair damp from the rain, cat in her lap, phone balancing on her knee.

"Photo sent," Niklas texts, adding: "The cat looks judgmental."

Hikari: “Cat is head of household.”

Rebecka’s reply is a single heart emoji followed by a tiny voice memo where she giggles and you can hear the cat meow like he’s adding his vote.

That night, while everyone showers in turn, Alice threads a new elastic through Hikari’s favorite hoodie and repairs the sleeve that always traps on door handles. She leaves it folded like a secret on the chair Hikari always misses on purpose.

Thursday

The morning is batteries and cords. Niklas does a silent sweep before work: plugs coiled, laptop bricks tucked into bags, power banks topped off. He leaves a square of dark chocolate by each toothbrush.

At lunch, his team deploys and everything catches fire. He stares at the code until the text becomes static and his hands forget how big they are. He messages the group:

N: “May be late. Don’t wait up.”

A second later, Hikari shares a playlist called “Sprint Boss Battle (But Cozy).” The first track is a rain-on-window loop. The second is soft piano. The third is silence—thirty seconds—to remember to breathe.

Alice: “Sent you a photo of my sternest maid-glare. Deploy will fear it.”

Rebecka: “Jag tror på dig. I believe in you.”

He sets the playlist to repeat and the code stops hissing.

Friday

Rebecka’s professor changes a deadline. She stands in the hallway, palm flat on the cinderblock wall—a lighthouse touch—breathing in through her nose and out through her teeth. The cane is a metronome for the soft panic.

Her phone chirps.

Hikari: “Can you talk?”

They don’t, exactly. Hikari sends little vibrations of attention—heart emojis, tiny chimes, and a link to an app that turns deadlines into tactile patterns on the screen. Rebecka runs her fingers across the new schedule and laughs once, ragged.

“Thank you,” she says to nobody and to three people at once.

Evening: Alice staggers in with takeout. The bags are warm, the sauces leak in gentle mercy. She kisses the air next to cheeks and foreheads—too tired to aim—and says, “I am a husk. Fill me with noodles and praise.”

Niklas sets the table like it’s a victory march. Hikari’s phone says, “Praise acquired,” and then, softer, “Proud of you.” Rebecka taps the tabletop twice: with love, with luck.

Saturday

Laundry mountain day. They don’t have time for dates, so they make intimacy out of domestic physics. Alice sorts like a goblin accountant; Hikari folds with crisp, almost origami precision. Rebecka pairs socks by texture while telling a story about a librarian who fights off a dragon by reading it a bedtime story.

Niklas lingers at the window. The week has worn calluses into all their voices. He turns and says, “Field trip.”

They protest. He insists. Five minutes later, they're under an awning five blocks away, sharing a paper bag of taiyaki. Steam ghosts the chilly air. Everyone takes a bite from the tail first, chaos. Hikari lifts her phone:

Hikari: "We are allowed to be happy for ten minutes."

They are. They are.

Sunday

They don't make it to brunch. They make it to the couch. The cat claims Hikari's lap; Rebecka leans back into Niklas's chest; Alice drapes her legs over all available knees like a cat made of silk ribbons. The TV plays a documentary no one is following.

They practice micro check-ins, the version for when eggshells feel too loud.

"How's the dragon?" Alice murmurs without looking.

"Sleeping," Niklas says. "Dreaming of spreadsheets."

Rebecka's hand finds Hikari's wrist and stays there, pulse-to-pulse.

Hikari's phone says, "Thank you for not asking me to speak today."

Alice squeezes her ankle. "You are speaking."

Before bed, there's ten quiet minutes that Rebecka promised. She reads from a book about a lighthouse that keeps shining even when the keeper is tired, even when the fog is rude, even when the sea forgets its manners. Her voice is soft, measured. The room smells like clean laundry and orange peel and the last of the taiyaki sugar on someone's sleeve.

Lights off. The city hums.

In the dark, small acts keep happening: a hand smoothing hair off a forehead; a phone set face down so its glow won't wake anyone; a whisper that might be Swedish or Japanese or just the sound a heart makes when the week is finally over.

No grand gestures. No love hotel. Just a stressful week that didn't beat them, and the steady, stubborn work of being each other's ease.

Chapter 7
The Conversation Hikari Types

The apartment was soft with rain-sound—steady, pattering, the kind that made the tatami smell like tea. Rebecka sat cross-legged on the floor cushion with a mug cupped in both hands, head tilted toward the window. Hikari set her phone between them, the text-to-speech app open and waiting. Her thumbs hovered, then typed.

The phone's voice was calm and a little too formal: "Can I talk about something awkward?"

Rebecka smiled. "Those are my favorite kind."

Hikari's mouth tugged at one corner. She typed again, longer this time, then pressed play.

"I want to talk about what it means that I have neoteny. That I look young. And that I am an adult woman who is sexually active. How those truths bump into each other."

Rebecka set her mug down. "I'm listening."

Hikari folded her hands in her lap, knuckles pale. She typed. The voice continued:

"Sometimes people think this face answers the question of my age. It doesn't. But the world reacts to faces, not files. That makes everything… complicated. I carry my ID everywhere. Even to the convenience store. I plan routes to venues that won't hassle me. And when I go on a date, I ask the host for a corner table so no one can take photos and whisper."

She paused, watching Rebecka's brow gather with concern.

"It's not fair," Rebecka said softly. "But it's real. And it's not your fault."

Hikari nodded and typed.

"I know. But I still build rules to keep everyone safe—me, you, Alice, Niklas. Rule one: clarity. I tell partners early. Not as a confession—just a fact of my body. Rule two: no age-play, no 'pretend younger' jokes, not even ironically. I need distance from the idea that my appearance is a costume. It isn't."

Rebecka's fingers found Hikari's and squeezed. "We already hold that line with you."

Hikari's eyes warmed. She typed.

"You do. And I feel brave with you. But I also think about third parties. A neighbor in an elevator. A bouncer. A nurse in an ER. If something goes wrong and we need help, I need everyone to be safe from misunderstandings. That means paper trails. Photos time-stamped with us at adult spaces. Friends who can vouch. It means I text you before I leave and when I arrive."

Rebecka nodded. "I like that plan. It's practical. Anything else?"

Hikari hesitated, then typed more slowly.

"Clothing is politics for me. If I dress cute, some people think I am a child; if I dress severe, others say I'm 'playing grown-up.' I pick what makes me feel in control. For dates, I choose silhouettes that read 'adult' at a glance—tailored jacket, heavy boots, structured lines. Not for shame. For safety."

Rebecka's smile tilted. "Your jackets are hot, by the way."

A small laugh escaped Hikari; she typed:

"Noted."

They sat with the rain a moment. Hikari's thumbs moved again.

"Consent has extra layers for me. I ask for verbal confirmation more often than most couples would. I like scripts: 'Is this okay?' 'Yes, and here's my boundary.' I also like safewords that don't sound childish—simple, neutral words. And after, I need check-ins, not because anything went wrong, but because the outside world calls me a question mark. I want our inside world to be exclamation points."

Rebecka's voice trembled a little. "We can do that. We already do some. We can do more."

Hikari typed:

"Thank you. Another thing: legal landmines. Some spaces are dangerous because people scan and judge. I avoid love hotels with glass-front lobbies, bars with door photos, anywhere that requires a student ID to enter. I pick places where staff are trained, where the policy is clear. If someone challenges us, we leave. No debates."

"Agreed," Rebecka said. "No proving games to strangers."

Hikari glanced down, then up again, eyes glossy. The phone spoke:

"I don't want to carry shame that isn't mine. I am not an apology. I am a woman. I am allowed to want and be wanted. I just need our wanting to be careful with the world we live in."

"You are not an apology," Rebecka repeated, firm as a vow.

Hikari exhaled, shoulders loosening. She typed:

"Practical notes for you, too. If we're affectionate in public, pick gestures that read adult—hand on shoulder, arm-in-arm, forehead touch. Save the rest for private. If anyone asks rudely about my age, don't answer—redirect to me or walk away. And if I go quiet, it's not 'no'; it's me choosing not to perform for strangers."

Rebecka squeezed her hand again. "What do you need from me right now?"

Hikari's thumbs moved with new certainty.

"Two things. First, your language. When you talk about me—to friends, to doctors—say 'woman,' 'partner,' 'girlfriend.' Not 'looks young but.' No caveats. Second, promise we won't make my body the plot twist of our love. It's a detail, not the headline."

Rebecka's smile was sunlight through rain. "I promise. Woman. Partner. Girlfriend. And the headline is that I love you."

Hikari blinked fast and looked toward the window, pretending to study the rain. Her phone spoke one last time, voice a little robotic, words impossibly tender.

"I love you, too. Thank you for helping me be real in a world that keeps trying to make me explain."

Rebecka slid closer until their shoulders touched, and for a long, ordinary minute they just listened—to water on glass, to their own breathing, to a small brave quiet that felt like the opposite of apology.

The apartment had gone quiet in that late-hour way, the kind where the refrigerator hum felt like a lullaby. Niklas stood at the sink, sleeves pushed to his elbows, drying the last plate. Hikari sat on the counter by the window, boots knocking softly against the cabinet. She'd been still for a long time, eyes on the city outside.

Her thumbs moved. The phone on her knee spoke in its careful voice: "Niklas… how can you be attracted to me—looking as I do?"

He set the dish towel down like it might startle her if he moved too fast, then leaned on the opposite counter—close, but not crowding. His dark-blue eyes found hers. "Do you want the short answer or the true one?"

She typed: "True."

He nodded, breathing once. "I'm attracted to you because you are an adult woman I admire, who also happens to be devastatingly beautiful in ways that are yours. I'm attracted to your mind first—the way you cut to the point like a scalpel and then wrap it in velvet. I'm attracted to your courage—how you build rules not out of fear but out of love for everyone in the room. I'm attracted to how you move when you decide something; it's like gravity remembers you."

Hikari's mouth softened, just a little. The phone: "But my face… people think things."

"They do," he said quietly. "And I don't pretend that away. Your face makes strangers project stories. Mine is to never feed those stories. I choose places that keep us safe. I say 'partner' and 'girlfriend' without asterisks. I make sure consent is a ritual and a habit, not a mood. None of that is because I doubt you. It's because I won't let the world misname what you are."

She looked down, thumbs hesitating. "And what am I to you?"

He smiled—small, earnest. "You're Hikari. The woman who texts me a checklist for a date and then improvises poetry with her eyes. The artist who can summon a thousand people with a stream and still worry about the one person in the back row. The person who picked a jacket that makes you feel taller and then actually stood taller. The one who set a boundary and taught me to love you better by honoring it."

Her phone: "You don't… wish I looked different?"

Niklas shook his head. Red-brown hair fell across his brow; he pushed it back with a ringed hand. "I wish the world treated you differently. You? No. Desire, for me, is clarity and context. I'm not attracted to you in spite of anything or because of some game. I'm attracted to you because when you stand in a room, I feel the room align. And when you say yes, I hear a grown woman choosing me. That 'yes' is everything."

Hikari swallowed, eyes bright. The voice softened: "Sometimes I worry my body will be the headline."

"Then let's write our own," he said. "Headline: 'Hikari chooses joy.' Subhead: 'Niklas keeps pace.' The rest is story beats—tea, jackets, check-ins, laughter against a shoulder." He glanced at her boots. "And your stompy shoes conquering stairwells."

A small laugh escaped her, silent in her throat but visible in her eyes. She typed: "You're a dork."

"Documented," he said. "But I'm your dork, if you want me."

She slid off the counter, closing the distance until her boots were between his. She tilted the phone up, thumb ready: "I do. I want you. I just needed to hear the shape of the wanting."

He angled his body so the window light cradled them both. "Then hear me: I want you as you are, and I want to be the kind of man who makes the world safer around you. If that ever changes, I'll say it out loud. Until then—my hands are steady, my eyes are clear, and my yes is as deliberate as yours."

Her shoulders eased, the tension unwinding like a spool. She typed one last line and pressed play, the phone's voice a little robotic and somehow impossibly tender: "Kiss my forehead—adult, private kiss. Then hold my hand and make tea."

"Yes, ma'am," he said, and did exactly that—forehead, warm and reverent; fingers, lacing with hers as the kettle began to sing. Outside, the city kept its opinions. Inside, their headline held.

The rain had thinned to a mist by the time Alice let herself into Hikari's apartment with the spare key. She toed off her boots, set a convenience-store bag on the counter, and followed the quiet to the bedroom. Hikari was curled on top of the duvet in her structured jacket like she'd meant to leave and couldn't make her feet do it.

Alice eased down beside her, careful, a practiced orbit. "Hey, star," she murmured, brushing a stray strand of hair from Hikari's cheek. "I brought your favorite onigiri and the good peach tea."

Hikari's thumbs moved over her phone. The app's voice came out soft and precise: "Hi. I'm sorry."

"Mm-mm. No sorrys today." Alice slipped an arm under Hikari's shoulders and sat them up against the headboard, blanket over both their laps. "You're worried. Why today?"

Hikari stared at the window for two beats, then typed.

"Because the world pressed its face to the glass again."

Alice waited, still as a held breath.

Hikari's next line was longer. "A streamer clipped me from last night—just a silhouette and my boots—and said 'childcore cosplay, yikes.' The comments got cruel. Someone DM'd to ask Niklas' age and 'how we can live with ourselves.' I blocked and reported, but it stuck like burrs."

Alice's jaw flexed; she breathed through it. "Okay. That's a lot." She kissed Hikari's temple. "What else?"

Hikari swallowed and typed. "Clinic called to reschedule my checkup. The receptionist asked if my 'guardian' could confirm. I corrected her. She apologized. I said it was fine. It wasn't."

Alice's hand found Hikari's, thumb drawing slow circles. "That's two hits in one morning."

Hikari nodded, eyes shiny. "And the elevator neighbor stared when I held Rebecka's hand yesterday. She didn't say anything, but I stored it anyway. Then I asked Niklas how he could be attracted to me looking how I do. He answered well. I believed him. But belief fights gravity."

Alice exhaled, then nudged their foreheads together. "Thank you for telling me all of it. Do you want comfort, strategy, or both?"

Hikari typed, a tiny smile tugging. "Both. In that order."

"Copy." Alice scooted down the bed so Hikari could tuck into her shoulder, then pulled the blanket higher. "Comfort: I love you as you are. You are a woman. You are my girlfriend. Today is heavy because people were clumsy with your humanity, not because there's anything wrong with you. Their words are litter, not architecture."

Hikari's shoulders eased a fraction. The phone: "More please."

Alice grinned. "You are brilliant and terrifyingly cute. Your jackets could run for office. Your 'yes' is a cathedral. And anyone who wants to drag us into their bad-faith story can knit fog."

A small laugh shook through Hikari. She typed: "Fog knitters. Good image."

"Right?" Alice squeezed her hand. "Now strategy."

She clicked into the practical cadence Hikari liked. "One: I'll handle reporting the clip; I'm good at paper trails. Two: we set a phrase for when online stuff starts to spiral—text me 'burrs,' and I'll jump in and handle blocking/reporting while you step away. Three: for clinics, I'll draft a one-liner you can paste: 'I'm the patient. I'm an adult. Please speak to me directly.' We'll add it to your notes so it appears on file."

Hikari typed, eyes steadying. "Yes. Also: can we make a media boundary post for my community? 'No age discourse, no speculation, instant ban.'"

"Absolutely. I'll write it; you approve." Alice hesitated. "Do you want me to tell Niklas and Rebecka about the clip and the call, or would you rather do it later?"

Hikari considered, then: "Please tell them. Facts only. I don't want to perform it twice."

"Done." Alice kissed her hair. "Four: joy armor. Tonight we do something aggressively adult and boring—tax folder sorting and takeout, then a movie with lots of talking and zero explosions."

Hikari typed: "That sounds… perfect."

"Five," Alice added, softer. "If the elevator neighbor stares again, I'll say, 'Good evening,' with my Customer Service Voice and keep walking. We don't feed ghosts."

Hikari tipped her phone up. "Thank you."

Alice pulled back just enough to meet her eyes. "One more thing. If you want, I can post a photo later: the four of us cooking, timestamped, captioned 'Family dinner.' No discourse. Just us."

Hikari's mouth curved. "Yes. I want that."

Alice sat up, tugging Hikari with her. "Tea time. Peach, as promised. Then you, me, a shared hoodie, and a bad spreadsheet."

Hikari typed: "Kiss first. Forehead—public safe. Then cheek—private."

Alice obliged, gentle as a seal being pressed on a letter. “Orders obeyed, my love.”

As Alice stood to put the kettle on, Hikari watched her with a steadier gaze. She typed one last line and let the phone say it out loud, like a flag planted:

“Today the world was loud. Thank you for making our inside quiet.”

Chapter 8
Four Nights, One Heart

day 1 — alice × niklas / hikari × rebecka

alice & niklas.

Alice sweeps out of the maid café in a black coat, a flash of garter peeking when she twirls for him. Niklas shows up in the suit again—silver claw, rings, twin earrings catching streetlight. They hit a late exhibit—fashion through decades—and he lets her set the pace, asking questions that make her gush about stitching and boning and hidden seams. On the station platform, she leans into his shoulder.

"Don't move," she says, and snaps a photo like he's her runway. He blushes.

They share taiyaki, trade bites, and talk future shoots: "gothic emperor & saint," she decides.

At the love hotel with velvet wallpaper and rose lamps, she presses her forehead to his. "I want slow and adored." His answer is a kiss that promises both. The door closes on a chorus of soft laughter.

hikari & rebecka.

A quiet café with braille menus and a low hum of jazz. Hikari's text-to-speech purrs from her phone, warm and a little shy tonight: "Blind tasting?"

They line up tiny cups—cocoa, hojicha, cinnamon apple—and Rebecka calls each one by scent and warmth, grinning when she nails three in a row. Hikari dabs a ribbon of whipped cream to Rebecka's lip and thumbs it away, eyes shining.

They walk the river path, fingers laced. Hikari types: "I like when you lead." Rebecka squeezes once and answers simply, "Then trust me."

The love hotel is all soft stars on the ceiling. Hikari queues a synthwave playlist; Rebecka traces Hikari's cheek with a careful, reverent hand. The music swells. The lights dim. Fade.

day 2 — alice × rebecka / niklas × hikari

alice & rebecka.

Ueno's market is loud, bright, delicious. Alice becomes Rebecka's scout, describing color like candy: "neon melon, lipstick red, dragonfruit pink." Rebecka maps the world with fingertips—silk scarves, knotted ropes, carved fans.

In a quiet corner, Alice guides Rebecka through a confidence-posing lesson—chin angle, shoulders back, "feel the camera right here." Rebecka laughs and says, "Then kiss me right here," and Alice does, soft as the silk.

Their love hotel has a karaoke box in the room. Alice sings a husky ballad, and Rebecka joins on the chorus, off-key and radiant. The microphones clack down together, and the screen times out to a glowing heart.

niklas & hikari.

Arcade date. Niklas turns out to be a menace at rhythm games, sleeves rolled, veins up in forearms; Hikari records him, looping his concentrated scowl with a goofy sticker crown. Her TTS admits: "I thought you'd be too tall for DDR."

"Rude," he grins, breathless. "Challenge me again."

They win a plush bat from the claw machine and name it "Boss." Ramen after—he orders her favorites without asking, remembered from deliveries.

At the love hotel, Hikari types: “Tonight I want brave. Show me the storm, but keep me safe.” He cups her face, the dragon curled and leashed behind his eyes. The door sighs shut.

day 3 — alice × hikari / rebecka × niklas

alice & hikari.

Cosplay workshop night. Alice has a half-built gothic empress; Hikari wears a simple black dress and a choker that says “Hush.” They swap roles—Hikari directs, Alice obeys. Soft commands on the phone: “Left sleeve tighter. Slit higher. Look at me.”

They shoot in a half-lit stairwell; every click steals a breath. Alice whispers, “You’re dangerous.” Hikari’s phone answers, “Only for you.”

Their love hotel has a giant circular bed. They tumble onto it, laughing, crown of wig pins scattered like stars. The camera blinks red once, then sleeps.

rebecka & niklas.

Library-after-hours, courtesy of a kind librarian friend. The stacks smell like dust and stories. Niklas reads poetry in Swedish, then in halting Japanese so Rebecka can feel the shape of his smile between lines. She asks for his hand and maps the silver claw, each ridge committed to memory.

“Do you ever feel too much?” she asks.

“All the time,” he says. “But ‘too much’ is often just ‘exactly enough’ in the right arms.”

The love hotel is quiet, inky blue lighting. She asks him to describe the room like an audiobook; he does, slow and playful, until words become kisses and the night turns tender.

day 4 — all four

Group dinner at a family-style place with shared plates and clinking glasses. Hikari orchestrates with her phone—“Rotate dishes clockwise!”—and they do, laughing every time Niklas overserves everyone. Alice feeds Hikari pickled plum with chopsticks; Rebecka taps her glass for a toast: “To us. To choosing each other, again and again.”

On the walk, they link into a chain: Niklas–Alice–Hikari–Rebecka, swapping places at every crossing like a dancing puzzle.

The love hotel suite tonight is capacious: a soaking tub, a star projector, a speaker thumping soft bass. They choose a safe word for giggles, pile their phones away, and draw a bath that becomes a constellation of shared warmth and whispered promises.

They tumble into the bed in a tangle of limbs and trust. Before the lights dim, Hikari types one last line and holds it up like a vow: “Four hearts. One home.”

And the city outside keeps breathing, while their week folds itself into memory—lust threaded with care, heat braided with gentleness—each night a promise to meet in the morning and want each other still.

ohhh karaoke chaos night—private booth, four mics, too many snacks, and a vibe that keeps tipping from playful to molten. no love hotel this time; the room becomes the whole story.

private room 17 — “do not disturb (we’re singing)”

They start with the safe stuff: retro anime OPs, croony enka, one power ballad that makes the glass tremble. The booth light cycles from violet to blush-pink, and the table collects a small mountain of fries, karaage, edamame, and neon mocktails. Someone keeps hitting the smoke button by accident. (It’s Niklas. It’s always Niklas.)

Hikari taps her phone; the soft voice from her speaker goes: “House rules. We rotate. Two sing, one lookout, one… quality time. Pause for snacks between sets.”

Alice claps like it's choreography. Rebecka's smile is mischievous and certain.

set 1 — lookout: rebecka | singers: niklas & hikari | quiet corner: alice

Singers. Niklas picks a Swedish pop classic; Hikari joins, nailing harmonies with that gentle TTS guide in her ear like a metronome only she hears. He grins down at her, proud and a little dazzled.

Lookout. Rebecka perches near the door, cane across her lap, head tilted to catch footsteps in the corridor. She can hear elevator dings like punctuation, the squeak of a staff cart, laughter two rooms down.

Quiet corner. Alice slips behind the couch, drawing the curtain a little. Hikari raises her phone between verses: "Kiss for luck?"

Alice answers without words, brushing a kiss to Hikari's knuckles first, then her lips. It stays sweet—just enough to make Hikari's next harmony float.

Snack pause: Rebecka taps the table. "Hydrate." Everybody drinks. Alice feeds her karaage, heat passing hand-to-hand like a secret.

set 2 — lookout: niklas | singers: alice & rebecka | quiet corner: hikari

Singers. Alice goes full-stage, choosing a sultry city-pop track and guiding Rebecka through the chorus with a hand at her hip, breath counting, "two-three-step." Rebecka's pitch wanders, then lands, laughing into the mic—she sounds free.

Lookout. Niklas stands at the door in his suit jacket, tie loosened. He watches the hallway in the reflection of the dark TV edge, a calm sentinel.

Quiet corner. Behind the half-drawn curtain, Hikari tugs Alice's scarf free as the song ends—thumb stroking the hollow of her throat. She types, shows: "One minute." Alice nods, eyes bright, then returns to singing like nothing happened, voice just a shade huskier.

Snack pause: Gyoza arrives. Hikari arranges sauces in a meticulous gradient and types: "Order of heat. Choose your destiny." Niklas, reckless, goes last. He coughs and laughs, eyes watering; Rebecka hands him his drink, smug.

set 3 — lookout: hikari | singers: alice & niklas | quiet corner: rebecka

Singers. A duet—Alice picks a thunderous rock ballad, Niklas takes the low lines like rolling thunder. By verse two they're more acting than singing, foreheads close, grinning between lyrics.

Lookout. Hikari sits cross-legged by the door like a tiny gatekeeper, browsing the hallway through the fisheye near the handle. Her phone says, "Coast clear. Ninety seconds."

Quiet corner. Rebecka curls into Niklas when the song ends, tugging him down behind the curtain. "Describe me the room again," she murmurs. He does: the light turned rosy; the way the star-lamé couch throws tiny constellations on her hair. She maps his face with her fingertips, then kisses him slow, deliberate, reverent. He exhales like a promise and keeps it—soft, contained, careful.

Snack pause: someone orders shaved ice with condensed milk "for science." Hikari types, "This is dessert snow." Alice steals the strawberry syrup and draws a tiny heart on Rebecka's wrist. Rebecka blushes; no one mentions it, everyone notices.

set 4 — lookout: alice | singers: hikari & rebecka | quiet corner: niklas

Singers. Hikari cues a mellow duet; Rebecka follows the gentle melody, their voices (one sung, one vocoded guide in Hikari's ear) landing together like a hush.

Lookout. Alice, at the door, slips into "professional mode"—she leans, chewing a stick of gum like a bodyguard, and flashes a smile at a passing staffer through the crack. "Extra napkins? Arigatou~" Crisis averted.

Quiet corner. Behind the couch, Niklas presses his brow to Hikari's, grounding. Her phone murmurs: "Dragon. Leash on?"

"Always," he whispers. Their hands lace, pulse to pulse. It's gentle, synced breathing and the kind of kiss that leaves both of them steadier.

Snack pause turns into mini-lesson: Rebecka teaches them a Swedish drinking cheer; everyone butchers it; they do it again, perfect, and clink.

last call — everyone sings / no one behaves

The final queue is unhinged: a rave track, a lullaby, an 80s anthem. Hikari, emboldened, types "Lights off." The booth drops to starfield dim. Four silhouettes become a constellation: swaying, laughing, bumping shoulders, stealing quick kisses between lines. They keep the lookout rotation like a dance they invented together—door check, curtain slide, a kiss, a verse, a bite of fries, repeat.

When the staff knocks—polite, apologetic—Alice answers with a breathless, "One more song?" They get it. One more.

They sing it badly and beautifully, all four. On the last chorus, Rebecka lifts her mic and says, clear and soft, "To us." Hikari holds up her phone: "To us." Alice and Niklas echo it, four voices, one chord.

The receipt prints like a streamer tape. They pack up slowly, cheeks flushed, eyes bright, hands reluctant to let go. Outside, the hallway is cool and ordinary. Inside them, the room keeps glowing.

No love hotel tonight. Just a shared elevator ride, exchanged looks that say "later," and the giddy promise that sometimes all you need is a couch with a curtain, a mic in your hand, and the right people doing door duty while the song goes on.

morning light, messy hair, and a battlefield of breakfast—pancakes (acceptably singed, sorry Niklas), fruit, coffee, and a bowl of whipped cream someone keeps "accidentally" stealing.

"one thing we learned," Alice declares, tapping her mug like a gavel.

Rebecka goes first, thumb circling the warm ceramic. "Niklas smells like cedar when he's trying to be brave," she says, smiling toward him. "And Alice… when you sing without thinking about the camera, your voice lands right here." She taps her sternum. "Hikari knows every footstep in a hallway, even through a door."

Hikari's phone speaks, soft and a little sly: "I learned Rebecka leads best when we don't crowd her. I learned Alice can command a room with a look—curtain becomes a stage. And Niklas?" She types a beat more. "He can turn a storm off like a light when I ask. That's… safety." Her cheeks pink; she steals another spoon of cream.

Niklas rubs the back of his neck. "I learned Hikari's the best tactician in any chaos. Give her a tiny screen and she runs the world." He nods to Rebecka. "You map people with your hands better than I do with my eyes. You found edges I didn't know I had." He glances at Alice, a half-grin. "And you—if I stand close enough during a duet, I suddenly sing in tune."

Alice pretends to preen, then softens. "I learned Niklas says fewer words when it matters, but each one is a vow." She squeezes Rebecka's fingers. "You don't need a lens to take a perfect picture—you make me feel seen without seeing." She bumps Hikari's shoulder. "And you… your silence is the loudest 'yes' I've ever heard."

They sit in that quiet a moment—coffee steam, fork clinks, the hum of a Saturday outside.

Hikari types one last line and turns the screen so all three can read: "Four hearts. One home. Again today?"

"again today," they echo, almost in unison—then Alice steals the whipped cream, Rebecka catches her wrist, Niklas laughs, and the day begins the way the week ends: warmed by what they've learned, greedy for what's next.

Chapter 9
Whispers in the Staff Room

The lunch rush had a hum to it—steel spoons tapping porcelain, the door chime batting its little bell every thirty seconds, the espresso machine sighing like an overworked dragon. Alice floated through it the way she always did: smile pre-loaded, ribbon perfect, heels kissing the floor with practiced grace. Two omelet sets to Table 6, a caramel latte with a foam heart to the couple near the window, a wink to the child who kept peeking over the dessert display. Easy.

It wasn't until she pushed through the staff-room curtain for a quick water break that the hum turned into words with edges.

"…and she went home with all three? Like, all three?" Aya's voice had that conspiratorial bounce people use when they believe they've discovered the secret level of someone else's life.

"Not at the same time," Tomo answered, faux-sage. "I think they rotate. There were, like, karaoke booths? Private ones. I'm just saying, our Alice-chan has stamina—"

"Stop," Yui's voice cut in, soft but definite. "You don't know anything."

Alice froze with the curtain still brushing the backs of her knees. She could have cleared her throat, made a noise, turned it into an awkward comedy beat. Instead, she stood there, holding the paper cup like it might heat her hands through the cold prickle that ran across her knuckles.

Aya lowered her voice as if that made it kinder. "I'm just worried, okay? This kind of thing… it follows you. Management hears 'love hotel' and 'multiple partners' and suddenly your shifts get weird. I like Alice."

"Then talk to her like a person, not a headline," Yui said.

Tomo snorted. "People will judge, Yui. Customers judge. I got a table last night asking if she does 'special services' with the uniform."

The paper cup creased under Alice's fingers.

She could smell the staff room: lemon disinfectant, burnt toast crumbs, fabric softener from the spare aprons. She could picture the tiny calendar pinned up—kittens in teacups—and the plastic drawers where they kept emergency safety pins and eyelash glue. All the small, normal things that made the room feel like a pocket of safety. And now, not.

Yui must have noticed the curtain tremble because she looked up at the doorway. "Alice," she said, neutral and open, a lifeline tossed across a too-bright room.

Three expressions pivoted toward her. Tomo's was halfway to a shrug. Aya's had the rigid smile of someone rehearsing innocence. Yui's was just there, steady.

Alice walked in and set her crushed cup gently in the bin. She tucked a loose curl behind her ear, the way she did in meet-and-greets when people wanted a clearer shot for photos. On the tray of the staff mirror, her lipstick sat next to a spare bow. She didn't reach for either.

"I heard some of that," she said, and her voice didn't wobble. "Do you want the actual version?"

Silence shook its head, afraid of making eye contact.

Tomo tried a laugh. "No one's attacking you. We're just—venting."

"About me." Alice met his eyes. "About my partners. Who are, for the record, real people with names. Not a rumor category."

Aya's cheeks bloomed pink. "I wasn't— I mean, I meant it when I said I worry."

“Thank you,” Alice said, and she meant it enough to let it soften the angle of her shoulders. “I worry, too. I worry about the customers who feel entitled to my body. I worry about how things can get twisted.” She glanced at Yui, gratitude warm in her chest. “I also have a manager who knows all of this and cares that we’re safe at work. And I have a polycule that is consensual, boringly domestic most days, and very private—unless someone corners me in a hallway and asks if we color-code date nights.”

Tomo almost smiled. “Do you?”

“Sometimes,” Alice said dryly, and the tiniest flicker of humor let the room breathe a little. “Because three calendars are chaos.”

Yui huffed a quiet laugh. Aya’s shoulders dipped with a sigh. “I’m sorry,” she said. “I really am. I didn’t think about how it would sound.”

“It sounded like I wasn’t in the room,” Alice said gently. “I don’t need you to like my life. I need you to respect me in the workplace. If a customer harasses me, you step in. If you have a question, ask me, not the rumor mill. If my personal life ends up in your mouth, please check whether it has my consent first.”

The curtain flicked again and Riku, their manager, leaned in. His expression took in the scene in one sweep: the stiff shoulders, the bin with the crushed cup. He didn’t ask what happened. “Heads up,” he said, “bus of tourists just parked outside. We need all hands. Also—” His eyes flicked to Alice. “If anyone gives you grief, you tag me. Policy hasn’t changed.”

“Got it,” Alice said.

“Good.” Riku looked around at the others and let the silence carry the rest: professionalism wasn’t optional. He vanished back into the noise.

In the half-second of quiet that followed, Alice’s phone buzzed in her apron pocket. Group chat: 💜🍰 Coven + One Dragon 🐉. She thumbed it open as Aya and Tomo straightened their aprons and Yui squeezed her elbow.

Hikari had sent a short voice note, the soft synthetic timbre of her text-to-speech threaded with mischief: “Alert: Alice-shaped sunshine levels dropping. Deploying emergency love. Repeat, deploying emergency love.” Then a sticker of a chibi bat throwing hearts.

Rebecka followed with a message typed carefully, her punctuation like beads: “I am proud of you. If you want, I will come sit by the door and listen to the chime. I like your chime.” Another line: “Also, I can bring the good tea.”

Niklas: “Standing by with umbrella at 17:00. If anyone stares wrong I will… practice extreme politeness at them. Proud of you, älskling.”

Something in Alice’s chest unclenched. She typed, thumbs quick. “I love you. Crisis managed. Tourists incoming. Save me something sweet.”

Back on the floor, the air felt the same but she didn’t. The tray wasn’t heavier; her smile wasn’t faker. If anything, she placed it down with more certainty. At Table 8, a group of women in matching scarves watched her with the simple delight of people on holiday. One of them asked, in halting Japanese, if they could take a photo with her because she looked like the character on their keychains.

“Of course,” Alice said, and her bow was perfect, but the thanks she felt wasn’t for the compliment. It was for Yui’s steady gaze, for Riku’s twenty-five words of policy, for the buzzing pocket where synthetic-sweet love lined up to catch her if she slipped.

As she leaned into the photo, someone at the counter called loudly, “Alice-chan, caramel latte, extra foam heart!”

“On it!” she sang back, voice light, heels kissing the floor. If they were going to talk, let them talk about her latte art. Let them talk about the way she ran a shift like a conductor, about her cosplays lined up crisp in garment bags, about how the bow in her hair never fell out even when the café was chaos.

Her life didn't fit everyone's template. That was fine. She had built something that did fit—with calendars and color codes and a group chat that made room for her to be soft when she needed. Out at the machine, she poured steamed milk into a spiral and then drew a heart without thinking. It came out a little lopsided from the adrenaline, honest and warm.

She set it on the counter and rang the bell. "Caramel latte! Extra heart!"

Chat slid in like a tide the moment the "Starting Soon" card flipped to Hikari's model: pale skin, midnight lace, little horns curling like question marks. Her avatar breathed softly with the BGM—plucked strings and rain on paper walls—while the chat blur jumped from hello spam to curiosity at light speed.

[10:02]

Chat: hiiii Dark Mother!!

Chat: new nails?? show!!

Chat: MOMMY STEP ON ME—

Chat: rumor says gf reveal when

Chat: wait is it gfs??

Chat: is it true about the poly—

A soft chime. The TTS voice—a bell-glass version of her—came through, warm and calm.

"Good morning, little bats."

On-screen, a tiny chibi bat waddled in carrying a silver teapot. Hikari's avatar lifted a porcelain cup to her lips. She adjusted her overlay: today's stream title hovered in calligraphy—COZY Q&A + sticker sketching—beside a goal bar labeled 'Tea Money' filling at a steady drip.

[10:03]

Chat: she's so pretty today

Chat: sip sip

Chat: PLEASE ANSWER ABOUT LOVE LIFE

Chat: i'm only curious!!

Chat: parasocial is fake news i'm normal :3

A mod wrench flickered in the flood.

Mod_Rook: Gentle reminder: no prying into personal life. Keep it comfy or time-out. 🕯️

The questions didn't stop. Someone dropped a dono with an all-caps tease. Another tried to couch it in concern. "We're worried for you" wore the same shape as "Tell us."

Hikari's avatar tilted, listening. The chime again; her TTS was soft but deliberate:

"I see the questions."

She tapped a key. A tiny bonk hammer descended and bopped three messages into confetti hearts. Laughter bubbles popped up from the chat; a tide of "LOLOL" and bat emotes rose—then stuttered as the confetti drifted down and the room tone settled.

"I know you care. Caring is good."

"I also keep some doors closed."

The chibi bat put down the teapot and held up a painted shoji screen. On it, inked in black: BOUNDARIES.

"On this channel, we share tea, games, art, cozy chaos, and spooky bedtime stories."

"We do not share my private relationships."

[10:05]

Chat: that's fair

Chat: boundaries!! let's gooo

Chat: sorry for pushing

Chat: my bad, Dark Mother

Mod_Rook: Thank you for understanding. Back to nails or I release the moths.

A stray message tried once more: “But isn’t honesty part of parasocial trust?” The bonk hammer returned—gently, almost affectionate—then whisked it away.

Hikari’s TTS kept its velvet pace:

“Honesty is telling you what this stream is.”

“Privacy is choosing what it’s not.”

“You get the garden I tend for you.”

“The map of my heart is not content.”

Her model smiled, eyes lidding. The chat slowed into hearts and bat stickers. A few apologies dotted the scroll.

“If you came for romance gossip,” the TTS added, a hint of mischief threading in, “I can offer the greatest love story: me and this week’s nail set.”

She swapped scenes. A top-down cam overlay appeared: a stylized desk with gothic decals and a digital hand-cam rendering that matched her model’s fingers. On a little velvet mat lay her nail palette—onyx, pearl, a glitter that caught the light like frost. She flicked to her sticker canvas: a set of four chibi bats, each with a different accessory.

“Question time,” she chimed. “Ask me about art tools, streaming setup, tea blends, my favorite boss fights, or how to survive Mondays.”

“If you ask about love life again, the moths will carry you into the moon.”

[10:08]

Chat: FAVORITE TEA GO

Chat: what tablet do you use??

Chat: how many layers in that PSD?

Chat: can we get a ‘moth carry’ emote lol

Mod_Rook: Sub goal unlocked: 🦋🚫 nosy mode

A respectful dono slid through: “Thanks for modeling healthy boundaries. Proud of you.”

Her TTS softened:

“Thank you for listening. Boundaries make the cozy real.”

“Now—nails.”

She dabbed digital onyx onto a bat wing. The model’s eyes glowed, delighted. Chat leaned in with the right kind of nosy: “matte vs gloss?”, “top coat recs?”, “pls rate my scuffed starter set”.

The stream breathed. The earlier buzz thinned into steady chatter. A new follow alert chimed, a sticker sheet peeled itself on-screen, and Hikari’s TTS resumed its gentle hosting rhythm:

“Gloss for drama, matte for mystery.”

“My tablet is old but loyal.”

“Today’s tea is genmaicha—cozy, crunchy, safe.”

A single message popped up—just a heart and a bat—from a familiar username. She let it pass like a paper boat on a calm river and smiled without saying anything.

“Little bats,” she murmured through the speaker, “thank you for keeping this our room.”

“Question: crescent moons on the ring finger—yes or very yes?”

[10:14]

Chat: VERY YES

Chat: moon me mommy

Chat: sorry srry— moon please

Mod_Rook: Approved phrasing. Proceed. 🌙

Hikari placed a tiny moon on the ring finger, perfect and luminous. The chat cheered like a stadium in miniature. The shoji screen labeled BOUNDARIES folded itself neatly and slipped off-screen, not as a fortress, but as a quiet, normal piece of furniture that belonged there.

The stream found its rhythm again—stickers, stories, small joys—and the door that wasn't for chat simply stayed closed, as gently and decisively as a teacup set back in its saucer.

The izakaya on the corner had paper lanterns like low moons and a menu that stuck to your elbows if you weren't careful. After the release went live, the team spilled in with relief and the kind of laughter that only happens when the pager is, for once, quiet. Highballs arrived sweating. Yakitori hissed on the grill. Someone ordered way too much karaage. Niklas—broad-shouldered, sleeves rolled, hair pulled back with the elastic he kept on his wrist—felt the hum of it settle his spine.

"Skål," he said, clinking glasses with Kana, their team lead. She grinned.

"Kanpai," she returned. "To closing tickets and not reopening them in production."

"Dream big," Jun snorted.

It took exactly two drinks for the table to tilt.

"So, Niklas," Saitō drawled, tipsy confidence draped over his shoulders like a cheap jacket, "we heard you're… very efficient with your dating pipeline." He wiggled his eyebrows. "Parallel processes? Load balancing?"

Miki kicked his shin under the table. "Don't be gross."

"I'm just asking!" Saitō protested. "Like, is it… open? Rotations? Is there a sign-up sheet?" He laughed at his own joke and reached for edamame.

Jun, gentler, tried to make it sound like concern. "People talk, man. I don't care what anyone does, but—just watch your reputation? Japan can be… you know."

Kana didn't say anything, but her eyes slid to Niklas in a way that said: I'll back you. Do you want me to?

Niklas took a sip of his highball. Cold, clean. He set it down with careful fingers, the way you set down a truth you've chosen on purpose.

"Okay," he said, voice even. "I'm going to set some boundaries and then we can go back to arguing about tabs versus spaces like civilized people."

A ripple of laughter, uneasy but listening.

"First," he said, counting on thick-knuckled fingers, "my love life involves other human beings who did not sign up to be content for after-work drinks. Out of respect for them, I don't discuss details at work."

He let that land. Saitō ducked his head, the grin faltering.

"Second," Niklas continued, "if you've heard the word 'polycule' and that makes your brain write fanfiction—pause. It's adults, with consent, with a lot of calendars. That's the boring truth. We're not a rumor category, we're human."

Miki nodded, eyes warm. "Sounds like project management, honestly."

"Exactly," he said, a corner of his mouth quirking. "Third: I'm happy to correct bad assumptions, but not to entertain curiosity. So, correction: I'm not dating 'around,' I'm in committed relationships. Also correction: my private life does not affect my work, unless you count the way love makes me less grumpy in standup."

Jun's ears went a little pink. "Fair."

“And fourth,” Niklas added, looking right at Saitō but without heat, “jokes about ‘sign-up sheets’ or ‘services’ are out. You’re better than that. If a customer at a maid café made that joke to someone you care about, you’d shut it down. Same principle.”

Saitō winced. “You’re right. That was… sorry.” He scrubbed his face with his palms. “I was trying to be funny.”

“You can be,” Niklas said, the edge softening. “You’re hilarious when you’re not punching down.”

Kana exhaled like she’d been holding a breath. “Thank you,” she said, to Niklas and the table both. “Company policy backs this. We don’t pry, we don’t sexualize colleagues, we escalate if anyone gets harassed. If anyone gives you trouble, come to me.”

“Noted,” Jun said. “Also, tabs.”

“Spaces,” Miki shot back instantly.

“Sweden says ‘lagom,’” Niklas deadpanned. “Just enough indentation.”

They laughed, real this time, the tension breaking like thin ice.

Saitō lifted his glass, earnest now. “To boundaries,” he said. “And to… being less of an idiot.”

“Skål to that,” Niklas said, clinking his glass lightly against Saitō’s. “And since I’ve used my adult voice and we’re done with me, I would like to bring up something crucial: Miki’s dark theme PR. It’s brilliant. Merge when?”

Miki brightened, hands already talking. “I just need a final review on the contrast ratios. I stole your accessibility helper script, by the way.”

“Good,” he said. “Steal more.”

The conversation slid back onto safe rails: release postmortems, a bug that had hidden for months like a gremlin in a switch statement, the eternal rainbow of editor themes. Kana ordered another round and a plate of salted cucumbers. Someone started a “worst interview question you’ve ever been asked” contest that had them wheezing into their sleeves.

At some point, Niklas’s phone buzzed. He glanced: the group chat.

Alice: how’s the dev herd?

Hikari (TTS clip): “hydrate, Dragon. men of code forget water.”

Rebecka: I saved you a cinnamon bun. It smells like home.

He smiled into his drink and typed under the table: Boundaries set. No casualties. Coming home with karaage for you lot. Then he slid the phone facedown and returned to the table.

Later, as the check came and people started the polite ritual of “no, let me,” Saitō hovered awkwardly by Niklas’s shoulder.

“Hey,” he said. “Thanks for not… breathing fire.”

Niklas’s laugh was quiet. “Dragon’s for emergencies. This was just a conversation.”

Saitō nodded, eyes relieved. “I’ll do better.”

“I know,” Niklas said. He clapped his shoulder once—solid, friendly—and stood, stretching. “Alright, team. Trains wait for no one. And I have people who will fight me if I don’t bring the promised karaage.”

“Give them my apologies,” Saitō muttered.

“Better,” Niklas said, slinging on his jacket, “give them the respect you’d want someone to give yours.”

“Deal.”

They stepped out into the night air, cool and city-scented. Lantern light pooled on the pavement, and somewhere a bicycle bell chimed. The team peeled off toward their stations, laughter thinning with distance. Niklas adjusted the takeout bag in his hand, imagined the smiles when he opened it at the door, and walked toward home, the boundaries set behind him like stones in a path—visible, solid, easy to follow.

The seminar room smelled like dry paper and citrus cleaner. Rebecka found her seat by counting chairs from the door—three in, two right—and set her cane against the desk. Her refreshable braille display hummed to life under her fingers, pins rising like cautious hedgehogs. Today's topic on the syllabus: Information Ethics & Privacy in the Public Sphere.

Which would have been funny if it didn't arrive with the sound of someone's whisper trying very hard to be quiet.

"…is that her? The maid café girl's girlfriend? Or one of…"

A chair scraped. Mei—kind voice, careful steps, the only classmate who always asked before moving Rebecka's water bottle—leaned over. "Hey, Bex. I put your notes file on the shared drive. Also, uh… heads up? People saw a cosplay photo thread this morning. Your name is in the replies. They're… curious."

"Curious," Rebecka repeated, and let her mouth find a smile. "That word is working overtime this week."

Mei huffed a laugh. "Want me to run blocker?"

"Maybe." Rebecka adjusted her earbud. The screen reader ticked through the lecture outline. She had dressed simple today—soft sweater, sensible skirt, hair braided. She liked feeling like the version of herself who unpacked boxes in archives and whispered to books. Her phone buzzed.

Group chat: 💜🍰 Coven + One Dragon 🐉.

Alice: You've got this. Want a lunch date defense squad?

Hikari (TTS clip): "Deploying bat emotes in spirit. Boundaries spell prepared."

Niklas: Proud of you. If anyone is unkind, I will think extremely polite thoughts at them until they wilt.

Beneath the table, Rebecka typed with two thumbs, careful as always: I am okay. Today's lecture topic is convenient. I will let the professor help. She added a tiny bat and a cinnamon roll.

Professor Kato perched on the desk when class began, all cardigan elbows and dry humor. "Privacy," he said, "is the right to decide which parts of your story you lend to the world. Librarians are guardians of that choice." He clicked the projector. Case studies bloomed. The discussion warmed. Half the class argued about public figures and consent; the other half wallowed in hypotheticals.

When break came, it happened fast: the swirl of bodies, the click of cans opening, the little flock of two—no, three—classmates making a beeline for her desk.

"Rebecka?" A voice like bubble tea with extra sugar. "We saw a thread about your—um—relationships? Is it true you're in a… poly—poly-something? With the maid café girl and the VTuber? And a foreigner? Is it safe? Is it… allowed?" The last word held the tone of someone peeking into a museum room with velvet ropes.

Rebecka rested her hands on the braille display. The pins were smooth under her fingers. She could feel Mei go very still beside her.

"I'm going to make this easy," Rebecka said, and her voice was steady. "I prefer not to discuss my private relationships at school. Out of respect for the other people involved. They did not enroll in this class."

"Oh! We didn't mean—" the second girl started.

"You meant well," Rebecka agreed, and aimed a small kindness at her tone. "Curiosity is human. So are boundaries."

A beat. Someone shifted their weight. Paper rustled.

The first girl tried another door. "It's just—people talk. And I worry. Like, do you ever feel pressured? Does he—do they—"

Rebecka lifted a hand, gentle, stopping the sentence before it became something she would resent. “I will correct a few assumptions,” she said. “Then I will ask you not to ask more.”

They waited.

“I’m in consensual, committed relationships with people who are good to me. We do a lot of calendar math and dishes. It is not a scandal. It is also not your business.” She tilted her head toward the front of the room, where the word PRIVACY still glowed on the slide. “I would appreciate you practicing today’s lesson on me.”

Mei let out the smallest, proudest breath.

To their credit, the trio didn’t bolt. The sugar-sweet voice softened. “I’m sorry. That was nosy.”

“It was,” Rebecka said, and smiled to take the sting out, “and you’re learning. So am I.”

She tapped the braille display, changing files. “If you want something to be curious about, I will gladly talk for twenty minutes about the ethics of cataloging queer relationships without labels that flatten them. Or how subject headings lag behind lived reality and make people invisible.”

One of them laughed, surprised. “You would, wouldn’t you?”

“Yes,” Rebecka said. “With references.”

Professor Kato’s voice floated over from his desk. “Ms. Alvarez,” he called mildly, “would you like to bring that exact point to the second half? The Library of Congress isn’t here to defend itself, but I am.”

Rebecka’s smile curled into something mischievous. “Gladly.” She turned her face toward the trio. “There. Much better question.”

When class resumed, Kato ceded the floor. Rebecka spoke with her hands open, palms hovering above the braille pins like birds over water.

“We talk about privacy as a lock and key,” she began, “but in cataloging, it’s also the difference between being shelved where you belong and being shoved into ‘miscellaneous.’ Labels help people find themselves—or miss themselves.” She talked about controlled vocabularies that didn’t have words when people needed them. About the violence of misclassification in medical archives, the erasure in school libraries, the kids who typed questions into a search bar and found only shame.

At one point, someone tried to steer it back—“But what about your—”—and Kato gently redirected. “The example is the system, not the student,” he said, and his chalk tapped the board like a gavel. The room learned.

After, as people packed bags, the sugar-voice girl came back alone. Her shoes squeaked. “Rebecka? I’m sorry again. I learned something.” A pause. “Also, um, I found a braille copy of The Left Hand of Darkness in the library basement last week. It looked lonely. Do you want me to hold it for you?”

Rebecka’s heart did a small, delighted tilt. “Yes,” she said. “I would like that very much.”

“Cool.” The girl hesitated. “And… if anyone gives you trouble, I can say something.”

“Thank you,” Rebecka said. “I can say something, too. But allies are nice.”

Outside, the corridor smelled like rain coming. Her phone buzzed again as she folded her cane and shouldered her bag.

Alice: How was it? Do I need to show up after class with a dramatic bow and a tray of macarons?

Hikari (TTS): “Deploying academic bats. Proud.”

Niklas: How’s my librarian?

Rebecka walked slowly, feeling the echo of the classroom in her ribs—the firm edges of her own voice, the way it had not wavered. She typed, the words lined up neat as books: Handled. Corrected assumptions. Taught a mini lecture on metadata. Someone is holding Left Hand of Darkness for me. I feel… steady.

Alice: STEADY QUEEN. Also I’m making tea. Come by?

Rebecka smiled and let her cane tap a happy rhythm on the tile. Yes, she wrote. Please. I would like the good tea.

She slipped her phone away and headed toward the stacks before tea—because a braille Le Guin waited, and it seemed right that on a day about names and privacy and choosing how to be seen, she'd go claim a story that had always understood that people were bigger than the boxes built for them.

Sunday night settled like a blanket—soft lamp light, the kettle's small song, the quiet that comes when everyone's home. They'd pushed the table against the window so they could sit on the floor with cushions; Hikari's projector threw slow paper-lantern shapes on the wall. On the table: karaage leftovers, sliced pears, the "good tea."

Alice lined up four ceramic cups like a ceremony. "Check-in night," she said, trying not to sound like the camp counselor she absolutely was. "Same rules: Rose, Thorn, Seed. Then: one ask, one offer."

Hikari lifted her phone; the TTS chimed warm.

"I love our little therapy cult."

Rebecka smiled, folding her cane and tucking it close. "We are librarians about our feelings," she said. "We catalog them."

Niklas snorted, already loosening his shoulders like he was shedding office static. "Skönt," he murmured. "Let's do it."

Alice went first. She curled her legs under her and breathed. "Rose: I handled the staff room without crying in the bathroom. Yui was a rock. Riku remembered policy." She set a hand over her chest. "Thorn: the 'sign-up sheet' joke stuck under my skin for a bit." A breath. "Seed: I asked for help in the moment. That felt… adult."

Hikari bumped her shoulder. The phone chimed.

"Ask?"

Alice nodded. "If I text 'heart low' on shift, one of you send me a silly sticker or… tell me a thing you like about me. Offer: I'll pack everyone's lunch one day this week. Cute bento. Overkill bow."

"Accepted," Niklas said solemnly.

Hikari's turn. She pushed a small plate of pear slices toward the middle. The TTS voice softened.

"Rose: I said 'no romance gossip' on stream and chat listened."

"Thorn: a donor tried to buy a boundary."

"Seed: new 'moth carry' emote made people laugh and remember."

She typed a few more words, cheeks a little pink even under the goth overlay on her phone case.

"Ask: if I get shaken mid-stream, can I send the safe emoji and one of you drop a 'proud of you' dono? Doesn't need to be money. Just… loud support."

"Offer: I'll do nails for everyone. Moon accents optional, Alice."

Alice squeaked. "Very yes."

Rebecka rested her fingers on her braille display, letting the pins hum under her touch as she found the shape of her report. "Rose: I explained to my classmates that curiosity is human and boundaries are, too. Professor Kato backed me." Her mouth tilted. "And there's a braille Left Hand of Darkness waiting for me."

"Nice," Niklas said.

"Thorn," Rebecka went on, voice smaller. "Being asked if it's 'allowed' felt like being sized for a box." She straightened a little. "Seed: I turned it into a mini lecture on cataloging. It helped."

"Ask?" Alice prompted, gentle.

“I would like a companion walk to the library tomorrow,” Rebecka said. “Not because I can’t go alone. Because it would be nice.” She added, precise as ever, “Offer: I’ll brew the good tea all week and read aloud from Le Guin after dinner.”

“Deal,” Hikari’s phone chimed instantly.

“I’ll be your bat escort.”

Niklas rolled his neck once, set his glass down. “Rose: after-work drinks turned into test-the-Swede night. I set boundaries without going full dragon. Saitō apologized.” He let the muscle in his jaw unclench. “Thorn: the way people think they’re owed details. It makes my hands… heavy.” He flexed his fingers like he was setting down a weight. “Seed: I brought the joke back to tabs versus spaces. That helped the room breathe.”

Alice reached across, squeezing his wrist where the silver rings sat cool. “Ask?”

“If one of you hears something getting messy around me, please say ‘we’re not a rumor category,’” he said. “It’s the sentence that works in my head.” He took a breath. “Offer: I’ll do breakfast runs all week. Cinnamon buns included. And I’ll tighten the loose cupboard hinge because it squeaks like a ghost.”

“Approved,” Rebecka said, with librarian authority.

They shifted into the second loop, smaller things, nervier things—the micro “thorns” that grow if you don’t pull them. Alice admitted she’d been sleep-scrolling comments at 2 a.m. Hikari confessed she’d turned down a collab because the other VTuber made “jokes” about mute girls. Rebecka said she sometimes worried that her neat texts made her sound cold when she was actually just careful. Niklas owned that he sometimes went quiet for hours after tanking a meeting and forgot to say “not about you.”

They practiced tiny corrections like drills.

“If I go quiet,” Niklas said, hand on his chest, “I’ll send a 🔧 to say it’s work, not us.”

“If I’m careful, it’s love, not distance,” Rebecka said. “I will add a heart.”

“If I doomscroll,” Alice said, “I will put my phone in the cookie jar and ask for a hug.”

“If a collab feels icky,” Hikari’s phone chimed,

“I will say no and send the ‘moths’ gif to this chat for cheers.”

They laughed, because the moths gif never got old.

Alice poured the tea, and the steam made the room smell like toasted rice and something sweet. Hikari put on soft rain again. They leaned into each other in a way that made the whole floor feel wider.

“Gratitudes?” Rebecka offered, because she liked ending strong.

They went around like kids at a campfire.

“I’m grateful for Yui,” Alice said, “and for Riku’s forty-second speech that made me feel safe. And for your dumb faces.”

“I’m grateful for chat learning quickly,” Hikari’s phone added,

“for our mod, and for pear slices.”

“Grateful for Saitō apologizing,” Niklas said, “for karaage leftovers, and for your braille lectures that teach me new words.”

“I’m grateful we don’t fit,” Rebecka said simply. “And that it doesn’t matter.”

Silence settled, not heavy—full. On the wall, paper lanterns drifted. Outside, a bus sighed. Inside, the small mechanics of care clicked into place: alarms set, lunch plans made, the week already a little lighter because the four of them had named the things and shared the weight.

Alice lifted her cup. “To the garden we tend.”

They clinked, soft. Four sounds, one note.

Hikari’s phone chimed one last time, quiet as a kiss.

“Boundaries make the cozy real.”

“Also,” the TTS added, a thread of mischief,

“Niklas—breakfast tomorrow? Pancakes?”

Niklas groaned. “Why do you hurt me like this.”

Alice grinned. “Because we love you.”

Rebecka, dry: “We will supervise the heat.”

“Fine,” he said, laughing. “Pancakes. With a fire extinguisher nearby.”

They made a plan. They stacked the cups. They folded the night around them, soft and ordinary and good. And when they finally turned off the lamp, the room felt like a place someone had cared for on purpose. The kind you came back to. The kind that made the next week possible.

Chapter 10
When Family Disapproves

The bell above the door of the family café chimed the way it had since Alice was a teenager—two bright notes, then a soft click. It smelled like butter and coffee and the strawberry jam her mother refused to buy because store-bought "never sets right." Sunday lunch hour had thinned; four tables left, two by the window. Her parents had chosen the far booth, the one with the scuffed edge where Alice carved a tiny star when she was eleven.

Her mother stood, arms already open. Then she saw the people behind Alice.

Niklas—a respectful bow that looked too large for the narrow aisle. Rebecka—white cane folded, smile small but sure. Hikari—hood up, phone in both hands, a soft chime as her text-to-speech app woke.

The hug stalled. Her mother's arms hovered like broken parentheses. "Oh."

Her father, who never wasted syllables, pushed his glasses up. "We thought it would just be you."

"It is just me," Alice said. "And the people who love me."

They sat. Niklas took the end because he always took the end—easier to get up if anyone needed space. Rebecka slid in beside Alice so their knees touched under the table, and Hikari perched on the edge opposite, thumbs flying. The phone's voice came out in that gentle, careful diction she'd tuned to almost match the softness of her real voice.

"Thank you for having us. I'm Hikari."

Her mother flinched at the speaker, just a flicker. "Of course," she said, too brightly. "Alice said she'd bring…friends."

"We are her partners," Hikari's phone cooed.

The brightness drained from her mother's face like someone had opened a plug at the bottom. "Partners."

Her father's mouth made a line. "Like business?"

Alice interlaced her fingers with Rebecka's. "Like love."

The quiet was thick; the clock above the counter ticked louder than it had any right to. Someone dropped a spoon in the kitchen. A latte machine hissed like a startled cat.

Her mother set her napkin down with ritual neatness. "Alice, people will talk."

"They already do," Alice said. "They talked when I bleached my hair, when I quit the office job, when I started the maid café. Talking isn't the problem."

"What is the problem," her father said, "is that this is…unstable. It won't last. Someone will be hurt." He looked at Niklas as if measuring him for blame. "Men usually go along with this for the wrong reasons."

Niklas swallowed, then met his eyes. "Sir, if it helps, I can step outside. I don't want to make this harder."

"No," Alice said quickly. "You're here."

Rebecka's fingers gently squeezed twice—one-two, the grounding rhythm they'd made theirs. When she spoke, her voice was quiet but edged. "I don't see with my eyes, but I can feel when a room wants me smaller. I won't be smaller for your comfort."

Her mother's breath hitched. "I'm not— That's not— We just want what's best for Alice."

"Then trust me," Alice said. She could feel the tremble in her own hands and hated it. She anchored it by pressing their joined fingers to the table, by tracing a tiny circle on Rebecka's knuckle. "Trust that I can set boundaries. That I can leave if I'm unsafe. That I'm loved by three people who check in with me more diligently than anyone I've dated before."

Hikari's thumbs moved again; the phone spoke in that tender, clipped way. "We practice consent. We communicate. We do conflict like grown-ups. We are boringly healthy, I promise."

Her father's eyes flicked to the phone, then to Alice. "You can't marry three people."

Alice almost laughed. "We're not asking for a seating chart and a priest right now, Dad. We're telling you who sits next to me when life is heavy."

Her mother's voice dropped to a whisper. "What will your grandparents say? What will customers think if they see—"

"Mom." Alice's tone gentled. "If a customer leaves because I'm loved by more than one person, they can take their bad attitudes and their wallet to the chain down the street."

"It's not just customers," her mother shot back. Her hands trembled, and that hurt Alice in an old, familiar place—because her mother always trembled when she saw a storm she couldn't steer her daughter away from. "It's family dinners. It's holidays. Where do they sleep? How do we…how do we fit…this?"

Hikari's phone: "We can take the floor with futons. We already do weird logistics." A small, almost mischievous pause. "We are very good at Tetris."

Rebecka bit back a smile; the corner of Alice's mouth tugged despite the tension. Niklas's shoulders eased a fraction.

But her father wasn't smiling. "It feels like you are daring us to approve of something we do not understand."

"I'm not daring you," Alice said softly. "I'm inviting you to meet the people I love."

Her mother looked at Rebecka's folded cane, at Hikari's phone, at the way Niklas's large hand hovered near the water pitcher as if prepared to pour for everyone and no one. Her mouth worked. "Are you being taken advantage of? Alice, sometimes…girls like you, with big feelings, you—"

"Stop." The word landed with a weight Alice didn't know she could hold. "Don't make me the naive one so you can be the wise ones. I know what I am doing. I chose this. They chose me."

Silence again. The café hum returned in pieces—the scrape of a chair, the hiss of milk, the world insisting on continuing. Her father took off his glasses and polished them with a corner of his shirt, which meant he was buying time.

When he put them back on, he looked older in a way that made Alice want to kiss his forehead and break a window, both. "I don't think this is right," he said. "I can't pretend I do."

Her mother stared at the table. "I don't know how to explain this to your aunt."

"You don't have to," Alice said. Her throat tightened. "But I won't hide."

Her mother's eyes lifted, wet and raw. "Then I don't know what to do today."

Alice nodded. The knot in her chest loosened into something slow and aching. "Then we end lunch now. We try again another time, if you want. With ground rules. You can ask us questions, but you don't get to insult us. You can have your feelings, but you don't get to make me choose."

Her father opened his mouth, closed it. Her mother folded and unfolded the napkin like a small bird that wouldn't fly.

Hikari typed. The phone's voice came small as a lullaby. "We care about Alice's family because they are hers. We can leave—so you can breathe."

Niklas rose first, the motion quiet, deliberate. He poured water into all four glasses anyway—a small, stubborn kindness—and tucked the pitcher back into place. Rebecka stood, cane clicking open like a punctuation mark.

Alice hesitated. “I love you,” she said into the place between her parents’ silence. “That part is not negotiable.”

She walked out with her partners. The bell chimed again. Outside, the noon sun was flatter than she expected; the air snapped cool against her cheeks. She realized she was shaking only when Niklas shrugged off his hoodie and settled it around her shoulders without asking. It smelled like cardamom and laundry soap.

Hikari bumped their hips together, then held up her phone so the speaker tilted toward Alice’s heart. “Breathe with me,” it said. “In for four. Hold. Out for six.”

Rebecka tucked her hand into Alice’s and counted on her skin—one-two-three-four, hold, one-two-three-four-five-six—until Alice’s lungs felt like something she could own again.

“I’m sorry,” Alice said, the words rough.

“For what?” Rebecka said.

“For making you sit in there while they…while we were small enough to fit in their idea of me.”

Hikari typed. The phone’s voice was steady. “We were never small. We were just folded.”

“We unfold,” Niklas said, and the way he said it made the word a promise and a plan.

Alice looked back through the window. Her mother had her face in her hands; her father was staring at the untouched water like it might confess something. It hurt. It would keep hurting. But she could stand it.

“Okay,” she said, more to herself than anyone. “Okay.”

“Ramen?” Hikari’s phone offered. “And a movie with too many explosions.”

“Then a check-in,” Rebecka added, practical as ever. “We name our feelings. We make hot tea. We decide what boundaries we want next time.”

Niklas smiled, the soft one that startled his own eyes. “And I’ll text my mom for the cardamom bun recipe. Comfort carbs.”

Alice laughed, and it cracked something open that let in a little light. She took one last look at the café, at the curved bell and the scuffed booth and the star she’d carved that nobody had ever sanded away.

“Let’s go,” she said, and they did, unfolding together into the afternoon.

Chapter 11
Paper Bats and Honest Hearts

The apartment looked like a pocket-sized carnival of shadows.

Paper bats skimmed the ceiling. A jack-o'-lantern grinned from the windowsill, its candle turning the glass warm and honey-gold. Alice had draped gauze over the floor lamp to make a ghost that wobbled in the draft from the balcony. Hikari had set her phone to loop a soft music box track—half lullaby, half haunted house. And Rebecka, fingers deft and certain, had hung tiny bells along the bookshelf so the room answered every movement with a chime.

"Okay," Alice announced, hips swishing in her witch dress, "we have pumpkin curry, we have apple cider, and I have an emergency bag of candy in case the neighbors' kids decide to trick-or-treat out of season."

Hikari flicked her phone screen. Her text-to-speech voice—soft, childlike, the one she'd chosen long ago—spoke from the speaker: "Emergency candy is an essential disaster supply. Government website should recommend."

Rebecka laughed, the sound small and warm. "Where do we put the photos?" she asked, patting at the table.

Niklas carried the little wooden stand he'd carved last week. He wasn't in a Halloween costume so much as… Niklas: black button-down, silver rings, the crescent moon in one ear, and a black ribbon laced around his right wrist like a promise. He set the stand in the center and lined its edge with four tea lights. The room quieted without being silent; the music box trilled, the city hummed beyond the glass, and the bells on the shelf made a shy sound as he moved.

"Here," he said, voice low.

They placed what they'd brought. Alice set down a Polaroid of her grandmother cackling in a plastic vampire cape at a family party. Rebecka ran her fingertips over embossed braille labels she'd made with the labeler—Grandma Luz, Papá—then slotted their frames into the stand. Hikari laid a small origami crane beside a printed selfie of her and an older woman with the same eyes: her aunt, the one who used to paint her nails.

Niklas set a photo last. It was a sunset where the sun had already slipped away and left the ocean shining iron-blue. In the lower right corner, a half-circle of people sat with their backs to the camera. "Family," he said, an explanation and an apology all at once. "Summer house on the coast. It's the only one that has everyone."

Alice reached for his hand under the table and squeezed. "Hey, you don't owe us explanations."

He gave her a small smile. "No, but I want to give them."

He lit the candles one by one, striking the matches carefully, letting the sulfur's bite bloom and vanish in the air. "In Sweden," he said, "we have All Saints'—Alla helgons dag. Not the party night—well, people party anyway—but the day after, when it gets very dark very early. We bring candles to the graves. Whole cemeteries glow. Sometimes there's frost. You can see your breath. It's like… a city of little suns for the dead."

Rebecka tilted her head, listening as if to a story she could taste. "It sounds beautiful," she said. "Like the night is big and kind instead of big and scary."

Niklas nodded. "Yeah. The first year after—" He paused. The bells on the shelf shivered. "After we lost my morfar, my mother held my hand so tight I thought she'd never let go. I remember thinking: it's okay. If she never lets go, it's okay."

Hikari typed. Her phone spoke, a whisper. “You can hold mine now.”

He did. Her hand was small and cool, and she curled her fingers around his with fierce gentleness. Alice’s thumb kept brushing his knuckle. Rebecka moved her chair closer until her knee rested against his calf under the table, a quiet anchor.

He took a breath. “I like the costumes and the candy. I like being someone else for a night, or making the city a stage, or being silly. But this—” He gestured to the candles and the photographs. “This is the part that matters to me. Because I’ve spent a lot of years pretending the past is a locked door. If I don’t look at it, it can’t come through. But it always did, just… louder. In worse ways.”

He didn’t say dragon. He didn’t have to. They all felt it—the shape of that old heat in him, the way it crouched behind his ribs.

Alice’s witch hat dipped as she leaned in. “So we look at it with you,” she said simply.

Rebecka reached for the nearest frame, her fingers mapping its edges, the weight of it. “Tell us a memory,” she said. “Pick one that fits in a teacup.”

“Something small,” Hikari’s phone chimed.

“Something that won’t break when you take it out,” Alice added, then bit her lip. “I mean—”

“No, that’s good.” Niklas smiled, slow and a little lopsided. He looked at the sunset photo and said, “My grandfather made pancakes on a cast-iron pan we had to oil with a scrap of bacon on a fork. He’d stand there in his socks, humming some old song out of tune. He burned the first pancake every time. He used to say the pan needed a sacrifice.”

Rebecka grinned. “Pancakes are dangerous magic. I’ve heard the legends.”

“We made too many,” Niklas went on, “and we ate them anyway, with cloudberry jam so tart you got lightning behind your teeth, and he told the same three jokes every Sunday. The last time he made them—” Another pause, not as jagged. “The last time, he hummed in tune by accident. For one song. He laughed, and then he messed the next verse on purpose.”

Alice’s eyes went wet all at once. She pressed his hand to her cheek. “I love him already,” she whispered.

Hikari typed without looking down. “We could make a sacrifice pancake tonight,” the phone suggested gravely. “Asbestos detectors permit?”

“It’s a tradition now,” Niklas said, grateful for the laugh that escaped him.

They lit each candle, and for each one they spoke a name and a small, safe memory. Alice told the story of her grandmother teaching her to sew crooked hems and rewarding every catastrophe with a piece of chocolate “because brave girls get treats.” Hikari typed about her aunt sneaking her kohl eyeliner and showing her how to smudge it on the train because “no one looks closely on Monday mornings.” Rebecka spoke of Papá’s voice, low and warm over audio books he recorded just for her; how he mispronounced English words on purpose so she could catch him, and how proud he sounded when she did.

When the last candle was bright and steady, Niklas sat back and let the light do its work. It gilded Rebecka’s cheekbones. It threaded copper through Alice’s hair. It made Hikari’s eyes go glossy and bottomless, like the sea just before dark. The city outside might as well have been the cemetery he remembered: a wide, breathing quiet with islands of flame.

“I used to think,” he said, voice quiet, “that remembering kept me stuck. That if I let the memories fill the room, I’d drown. But I think… I think the room is the same size either way. If we turn the lights off, we just trip over the furniture.”

Hikari squeezed his fingers. Her phone said, “We rearrange it together.”

Alice leaned her shoulder into his. “We make space for new stuff and we keep the old stuff that still fits. Like your terrible collection of goth belts.”

"They're excellent belts," Niklas protested.

Rebecka canted her head toward the window. "Can we go outside with the lanterns?" she asked. "I want to hear how the street sounds different when we carry the light."

They had two paper lanterns from the festival drawer—one fox, one moon. Alice clipped the moon's handle to Rebecka's hand, guided her to the balcony, and the four of them stepped out into the night. The air had that late-October edge to it, thin and crisp. From somewhere below came the sound of children laughing, a chorus of tiny monsters escorted by tired parents in hoodies.

On the sidewalk, the lanterns made little islands. People looked up and smiled—some because of the fox's sly face, some because lanterns meant festival, and festival meant "we're allowed to be soft for a minute." The bells on Rebecka's shelf couldn't follow, but their echoes seemed to.

They walked around the block: past the convenience store with its display of plastic vampire fangs, past the bakery that would be Kaine's in the morning making the street smell like butter and dawn, past the quiet shrine where even the stone foxes seemed to be wearing the night like a silk kimono.

Rebecka tilted her head and listened to the way their footsteps joined and parted on the pavement. Alice hummed the melody from the music box app, matching it to the rhythm of passing windows. Hikari's lantern threw the fox's smile across the sidewalk, then across Niklas's palm where he'd raised his hand to catch it. He looked at the light moving over his skin and thought of all the silhouettes he carried—the dragon-shaped one, the little boy-shaped one, the one that belonged to the man who burned the first pancake on purpose so he could laugh about it.

"The past is invited," he said, more to the night than to anyone else. "It just doesn't get to drive."

Alice bumped his shoulder with hers. "Shotgun is for girlfriends," she said primly.

Hikari typed. The phone said, "And boyfriends. Democratic rotation."

"Then the past can have the back seat," Rebecka decided, smiling toward his voice. "It can look out the window and tell us where we've been."

They circled home. In the kitchen, they made one sacrificial pancake—black at the edges, butter in the middle, a tiny comet in the pan. Hikari held up the spatula like a priestess. Alice declared, "To the beloved dead and to the not-dead-yet." Rebecka added, soft and sure, "To tomorrow."

Niklas cut the pancake into four crooked quarters. They each ate a bite, grimaced, laughed, and chased it with sweet cider. The candles on the table burned lower, steady in their small work.

He looked at their faces, at the glow on their skin, and felt something inside him settle—not an ending, not a cure, but a chair pulled up in the right place with room for him to sit down.

"Thank you," he said, not to fill the air but to mark it. "For being here with me. For making the room bigger."

Alice kissed his temple. Hikari pressed her forehead to his shoulder. Rebecka found his hand in the warm, sticky dark and laced their fingers.

Outside, the city moved on. Inside, the past flickered and stayed. They stood there, four points of a strange, sturdy compass, and let the night be big and kind, and let the light be enough to walk by.

They left the apartment quietly, as if they were carrying water that might spill.

The fox and moon lanterns went dark for the walk—Hikari held her phone screen down to keep the light from showing. Alice had packed a small tote: a bundle of white chrysanthemums, four LED tea lights, a thermos of sweet cider, and a folded paper with braille labels Rebecka had made earlier in the day. Niklas wore his black coat despite the mild night and tucked a tiny sprig of rosemary into the buttonhole.

The cemetery lay on a low hill behind a modest church that served half the expats in the district and whoever else needed a quiet place to talk to their dead. The gate was open. Someone had hung a

handwritten sign by the lantern: “All are welcome. Please use LED candles.” Beyond it, pathways unwound between stones like calm streams.

They didn’t speak as they entered. The city noise flattened into hush. It was the hush of leaves resting; of names waiting to be found. Patches of light dotted the slope—little saucers where other visitors had already placed their tea lights. Not Sweden’s ocean of flame, Niklas knew, but the shape of it was the same. Countless tiny suns, steady in their work.

Rebecka touched the map plaque at the entrance, fingertips traveling the raised lines until she oriented herself. “Paths make a big X,” she murmured, half to herself. “Bench in the middle.”

Hikari typed without looking down, and the phone gave them a whisper-soft voice: “Let’s sit there first.”

They walked slowly. Gravel ticked under their soles. Somewhere nearby someone coughed, a polite little sound that might have been a swallow trying not to disturb the night. Alice threaded her arm through Niklas’s. He felt the cool shape of her bangles through the coat. The rosemary on his lapel breathed.

At the bench, they set the tote down. Alice passed out the LED candles. The four little plastic flames looked silly in the bag and somehow sacred in their hands. Rebecka found the braille labels and read the names she’d prepared, letting her thumb rest on each set of dots as if to feel the heartbeat trapped inside.

“Before we go,” Niklas said, “can I say it out loud once? What we’re doing?”

Alice nuzzled his shoulder. “Please.”

He looked at them in turn—the alarm-clock glow on Hikari’s screen reflected in her eyes, the soft black ribbon of Alice’s hair, Rebecka’s attention like a held breath. “In Sweden, we light the graves for All Saints,” he began. “It’s about remembering, but it’s also about… walking with. Not dragging. Not running. Just—walking. I used to think if I let the past walk beside me, it would pull me backward. But it turns out it keeps pace if you ask it to. And it tells good stories when it’s ready.”

Hikari’s phone stayed dark; she didn’t make it speak. Instead, she typed, then turned the screen toward him. The words were simple: We’re here. Keep going.

They rose. The first candle they placed was for Alice’s grandmother. The stone they chose had no relation to the woman herself—it bore a different name entirely—but Alice rested her palm on the cool granite and whispered, “For the one who taught me to be brave with a needle.” She tucked a chrysanthemum at the base and set the tea light in the dish the caretakers had provided.

“For Tía Mina,” Hikari typed next, and Niklas carried her candle because she needed both hands to type and hold the flowers. She bent and lined up the LED with obsessive care until its tiny flame sat perfectly centered. Then, without using her phone, she pressed two fingertips to her mouth and touched the stone. A kiss, noiseless and complete.

“For Papá,” Rebecka said, and Niklas guided her to a place where the ground leveled out. She crouched, listening—the way sound changed with the shape of the stones told her more than any map. “He loved bad puns,” she added, smiling. “He would have liked all these lights. He would have counted them and lost track and started over.”

Niklas placed his last. He didn’t look for a Swedish name. He didn’t need a border to make the moment real. He chose a stone near the trunk of a gingko, its fan-leaves littering the earth like small golden hands. He set the candle. “For Morfar. For pancakes and out-of-tune songs. For the last verse you got right. For the way you made the pan a dragon we had to appease.”

Alice slid her hand into his. “For the way you gave him to us,” she said softly. “So now he lives here, too.”

They sat on the bench again with the last two chrysanthemums and the thermos. Steam twisted in the lantern light as Niklas poured. They shared the sweetness, letting the heat climb back into their fingers. No one tried to make it bigger than it was. The night didn't need grand gestures; it had this: four people on a wooden bench, the smell of rosemary and chrysanthemum, the hush of names.

"Do you want to say them?" Alice asked after a while. "The names you haven't said tonight?"

Niklas nodded. He didn't close his eyes. He didn't need to. He said them, the ones that fit in a teacup and the one that still needed a bowl: first names, a nickname, the little private syllable only family used. The words pooled in the air and then soaked in, the way rain disappears into thirsty soil. When he finished, his shoulders had dropped without him noticing.

"Future names, too," Rebecka said. "We don't know them yet. But they'll be here one day." She turned to find his knee and tapped it, light as a moth. "We'll teach them this walk."

Hikari typed: We'll teach them LED candles if open flames are not allowed. The phone's voice delivered the line with its soft, earnest seriousness, and they laughed, a small spill of sound that didn't break anything.

They stayed until the gingko dropped a leaf directly into Hikari's lap. She held it up, tracing its bifurcated fan with a thumb. "Two halves that make one leaf," Alice said. "Seems appropriate."

"Four quarters that make one pancake," Niklas countered, and the smile that followed had no weight to it at all.

On the way out, the slope looked different. Not because the lights had changed, but because they'd learned the paths. They moved more easily around the corners, skirted the stones without the little stutter-steps of uncertainty. At the gate, Niklas paused and looked back. The hillside spread out like a sky flipped upside down—a constellation you could walk through, if you were careful with your feet.

He breathed in, and it didn't snag. The past stood beside him, patient as a friend waiting at a crosswalk. He didn't push it away. He didn't ask it to lead. He just nodded to it, and it nodded back, and they stepped into the street together.

On the sidewalk, Alice threaded her arm through his again. Hikari brushed her shoulder against his coat and typed one-handed, the screen angled so it lit none of their faces. Rebecka walked on his other side, her palm resting lightly on his sleeve, trusting the shape of him more than the ground. The night ahead was ordinary—stairs, elevator, a kitchen with cups to rinse and a table to clear of candle stubs and labels. Ordinary, and therefore precious.

"Next year," Alice said, voice warm, "we bring more LEDs."

"Next year," Hikari's phone agreed, "we bring Kaine and Una."

"Next year," Rebecka murmured, "we come early enough to watch the sky turn on."

"Next year," Niklas said, "we'll know the paths from memory."

They didn't rush. They walked home at the exact speed of four people who had room for what they'd carried and hands enough to share it, and the hill behind them went on glowing—a small city of suns, lighting the way for anyone else who needed it.

Chapter 12
Black Lace, Red Face

The bell above the door gives a bright little chirp that absolutely does not fit the vibe. Inside, the shop is a forest of satin and lace, mannequins in pastel frills and bow-knotted innocence. Niklas, six-foot-something in a black coat and silver rings, looks like a thundercloud that took a wrong turn into a cupcake café.

He clears his throat and pretends to study a rack of baby-pink bralettes. Wrong direction. He pivots, finds a darker corner—black mesh, lace, touches of velvet—and relaxes a millimeter. Then the sizes start laughing at him in tiny numbers and indecipherable cuts. Longline? Balconette? Non-wire bralette? He rubs the bridge of his nose. "Okay," he mutters, "we can do this. For Hikari."

"Doing what?" comes a familiar, warm voice at his elbow.

He turns, startled. Rebecka stands there with her white cane tucked against her leg, a knit beanie tucked over her hair, sunglasses perched up in the beanie like a second, shyer pair of eyes. Her smile is already crooked with amusement.

"Oh thank god," he says, all dignity gone. "I'm being defeated by underwear."

She giggles. "Tragic. For whom?"

"For me. For humanity." He lowers his voice. "I'm trying to find something goth for Hikari. Not… y'know. Too much. Just—her. But everything here is either sugar explosion or… questionable architecture."

Rebecka tilts her head, listening to the rustle of hangers, the soft murmur of other shoppers, the faint synthpop pulsing from overhead. "Okay. Parameters?"

"Black. Maybe violet. Lace is fine but comfort first. She uses TTS and spends hours streaming—sitting—so nothing that digs. She's… petite. I don't want anything that makes her feel like I'm… I don't know… treating her like a doll."

Rebecka's smile softens. "You're sweet, Niklas." She taps the cane lightly, then pockets it and lets her fingertips graze the hems nearest her, mapping texture with a librarian's care. "Follow my lead."

He does, gladly. Rebecka moves with a confidence that makes the aisles part; she's a sonar of touch and sound, catching a velvet panel here, a scalloped edge there. She stops at a rack he'd overlooked completely and lifts something from it.

"Feel," she says, guiding his hand. The fabric is thick, pliant, not shiny—velvet with a whisper of stretch.

"Longline bralette," the shop clerk supplies from nowhere, cheerful and gentle. "Soft boning, front clasp, adjustable straps. We have it in black, wine, and… ghost violet."

"Ghost violet for the win," Rebecka says, grinning. "Hikari will like that the color feels like a secret."

They build from there. Rebecka finds high-waist shorts with a lace hem and a tiny crescent moon charm that clinks so quietly only someone listening for it would notice. She pairs it with sheer thigh-highs patterned with little bats you can only see when the light hits right. A matching choker catches under her finger—velvet ribbon with a tiny silver ring. She lifts it, weighing the hardware.

"This one?" Niklas asks, skeptical. "Too… on the nose?"

"Not if it's soft," Rebecka says, rubbing the ribbon between thumb and forefinger. "And only if it's offered, not… expected."

"Offered," he says quickly. "Always."

They circle back to sizing. Niklas looks helpless again. Rebecka pulls out her phone and opens her OCR app; the camera hums and the app reads the tag aloud, flat and practical. The clerk confirms with quiet professionalism, offers two neighboring sizes just in case, and tucks in a set of satin strap-cushions "for streaming shoulders," which nearly makes Niklas cry from gratitude.

Rebecka, meanwhile, keeps handing him pieces that feel like Hikari rather than Hikari-as-someone-else's-idea: a mesh shrug with velvet cuffs; a pair of soft cotton briefs with a stitched black cat; a garter skirt that can sit over the high-waist shorts if she wants a bit of theater without any pinch.

"You're a miracle," he says, balancing a growing pile at the counter.

"Librarian instincts," she says, smug. "We curate."

His phone buzzes. Group chat.

—Hikari: [TTS] are you lost, moonman?

—Alice: he is absolutely lost. i can feel it from across town.

—Hikari: [TTS] bring home something soft and wicked. both.

—Rebecka: already rescuing him. expect softness. and wickedness.

—Alice: pics or it didn't happen

—Rebecka: denied until reveal night 😌

At the counter, the clerk wraps everything in tissue the color of midnight. The bag itself is matte black with a satin ribbon handle. It looks like a secret even before it leaves the store.

Outside, the cold air smells like rain. Niklas breathes, shoulders finally unclenching. "I would have bought a pink ruffle monstrosity out of panic."

"I would have laughed," Rebecka says, hooking her arm through his. "And then Hikari would have worn it once, taken a thousand pictures to bully you forever, and retired it to the costume drawer."

He groans. "You're right."

She leans her head lightly against his arm, listening to his heartbeat thump steady under the coat. "You're good at loving her carefully," she says. "That's the part that matters."

He swallows. "Trying."

"You're doing," she corrects, then brightens. "Tea? We can plan the reveal. Candles. Dark chocolate. I'll make a playlist that sounds like velvet."

He lifts the bag like a trophy. "Lead on, Curator."

They step into the afternoon, two conspirators with a secret stitched in ghost violet, already hearing Hikari's text-to-speech laughter in their heads as the door chime rings behind them like the tiniest bell of victory.

The apartment is dim on purpose—Rebecka's doing. She's drawn the curtains just enough to let streetlight make long silver ladders on the floor. A little bluetooth speaker hums with something slow and velvety. On the coffee table: three tea cups, a plate of dark chocolate, and a matte-black gift bag tied with ribbon like a secret.

Hikari sits curled in the corner of the couch, oversized knit sweater swallowed around her, knees tucked under. Her phone is in her hands; the tiny speaker glows, waiting. Alice perches on the armrest, practically vibrating. Rebecka is all calm hands and soft composure, denim neat, cane tucked just within reach. Niklas stands for a heartbeat too long in the doorway, then steps forward and puts the bag down with ceremonial care.

He clears his throat, suddenly shy. "For you," he says, voice low. "Curated by Rebecka, incompetently hauled by me."

Hikari tilts her head; the phone blips and her text-to-speech renders a small, wry smile in sound: “[TTS] presentation accepted. moonman and curator, proceed.”

Alice claps and then immediately stuffs both hands under her thighs to stop herself from grabbing the ribbon. “I’m composed,” she lies.

“Uh-huh,” Rebecka says, mouth hitching. She reaches out, fingers finding the ribbon by touch, and teases it loose with slow precision. “Ready?”

Hikari taps. “[TTS] ready.”

They open the bag together: tissue paper the color of midnight sighs aside. Rebecka’s hands hover over the first piece and then offer it into Hikari’s waiting palms.

“Longline bralette,” Niklas says, nerves folding into gentle facts. “Soft boning, front clasp, adjustable straps. Color… ‘ghost violet.’” He winces at his own earnestness.

Hikari’s fingers explore the velvet: the give, the plushness, the careful seams. She lifts it, and the dim light catches a violet so subtle it looks like a secret whispered into black. Her phone pips. “[TTS] wicked and soft.”

Alice makes a quiet, delighted noise. “There’s more.”

There is. High-waist shorts with a lace hem that brushes like a sigh under Hikari’s thumbs. A pair of sheer thigh-highs, the tiny bat pattern only visible when she tilts them toward the lamp and the shapes ripple like shadows flying. A mesh shrug with velvet cuffs. A choker—just a ribbon, satin-smooth, with a small silver ring that clicks softly against her fingernail.

Hikari pauses on that last one. The phone hums. “[TTS] offered?”

“Only offered,” Niklas says, steady now. “Never required. You decide what any of it means.”

Rebecka smiles, warm and proud. “We picked for comfort first. And for you second. Fashion third.”

“Hey,” Alice protests. “It’s very fashionable third.”

Hikari’s shoulders loosen. She sets the ribbon across her palm, testing softness against the inside of her wrist. The speaker gives a small chime. “[TTS] i feel seen.”

Something in Niklas’ chest unclenches. “Good,” he says, almost a whisper.

They don’t rush the rest. Alice breaks chocolate squares and passes them around like communion. Rebecka reads Hikari the care tags, neat and practical, letting the words become anchors: cold wash, lay flat, stretch, breathe. The room stays tender and easy, the kind of hush that isn’t empty but full.

Hikari slides off the couch with the bag tucked to her chest, then pauses. Her phone lights. “[TTS] fashion show later. private. for me first.” A beat, then a softer chime. “[TTS] thank you.”

Niklas nods. “Of course.”

She hesitates again, then steps close enough to press her forehead to the center of his sternum, sweater brushing his rings. He stands very still, a tall silhouette around a small, brave gravity. His hand lifts and hovers, then settles lightly between her shoulder blades—only enough to say I’m here.

“Picture?” Alice whispers to Rebecka, trying to capture the memory without breaking it.

“Let’s take one of the bag,” Rebecka murmurs back, smiling. “The secret, not the secret-keepers.”

They do: matte black, ribbon untied, tissue like a night sky peeled back. Afterwards, they return to the moment. Hikari tips her head back, phone already in hand.

“Playlist time,” Alice declares, grabbing the remote and dimming the lights a shade darker, like velvet deepening.

Hikari types, then lets the phone speak for her, voice clear and amused: “[TTS] a playlist that sounds like velvet. approved.”

Rebecka’s fingers are already moving. “On it.”

Niklas gathers the tissue, smoothing the wrinkles like he's erasing the day's hesitation. When he looks up, Hikari is watching him—steady, small smile. She taps.

"[TTS] moonman?"

"Yeah?"

"[TTS] you did good."

He laughs, low and a little breathless with relief. "Team effort."

"[TTS] still. you did good."

She lifts the bag again, holds it to her heart as if it's a book she can't wait to open properly later. Then she nudges him with her shoulder, points to the couch, and types one more line as the new song starts—warm bass, brushed drums, a voice like smoke.

"[TTS] sit. tea. we plan the reveal. candles. dark chocolate. runway is hallway."

Alice squeals into the nearest pillow. Rebecka grins, hitting "save" on the playlist titled ghost violet.

Niklas sinks into the cushion, the last of his nerves dissolving as Hikari tucks her toes under his thigh for warmth. The bag rests on the coffee table between them like a crescent moon. Nothing rushed. Nothing demanded. Just the promise of softness and something a little wicked—on Hikari's terms, in her time—with the three of them keeping watch, making the room safe for the reveal to come.

The hallway becomes a runway because Hikari says so.

Candles puddle light along the floorboards, a soft path from bedroom to living room. The speaker purrs low and slow; Rebecka's "velvet" playlist holds the room in warm hands. Alice has turned off every overhead lamp and dragged a chair to the best sightline, knees bouncing, pillow clutched to chest. Niklas sits straighter than he ever has, a hand around his tea like an anchor. Rebecka is composed, cane resting against her leg, fingers folded—listening, smiling.

From the bedroom: the faint click of a front clasp. A whisper of mesh. Hikari coughs once, theatrical. Her phone lights around the corner.

[TTS] runway open. do not perish.

Alice clamps a hand over her mouth to stifle a squeal. "We're alive. Barely."

Hikari steps into the candlelight.

Ghost violet isn't loud; it glows like a secret inside the black. The longline bralette smooths into a soft V, velvet catching light when she turns. The high-waist shorts hug with enough lace to be wicked and enough cotton to be kind. The mesh shrug kisses her elbows; the velvet cuffs frame her hands like parentheses around mischief. Thigh-highs hold their place on their own—no tugging, no fuss—tiny bat silhouettes drifting when she moves.

She's added exactly two things: a silk robe left open, more suggestion than cover, and the choker ribbon tied loose at the side, ring resting where a pendant might. Offered, not claimed.

Hikari walks. Not a model's prowl—hers. Small, precise steps that make the bats fly and the violet breathe. She stops at the end of the hallway, sets a foot on the first candlelit plank like she's testing thin ice, then looks up.

[TTS] verdict?

Alice can't hold it. "That's illegal."

Rebecka laughs, bright. "You are perfect."

Niklas swallows. His voice comes out steady anyway. "You look like yourself turned up to eleven."

Hikari's mouth tips. She makes a slow spin, fingers sliding along the longline seam as if she's reading braille. At the end she faces them and tugs the robe edges just a touch closer, not to hide—just to feel it. The phone hums.

[TTS] comfort: excellent. wicked: adequate. audience: very well behaved.

Alice raises a finger. “Counterpoint.” She hops up and pads over with her pillow like a peace offering. “May I?”

Hikari lifts her chin in permission. Alice’s hands are careful, fixing a twist in the mesh at Hikari’s shoulder, a whisper of fabric-on-fabric that’s pure goosebumps. She steps back, hands together, starstruck. “Runway look one: ghost violet.”

Rebecka stands and moves closer, stopping where Hikari would want. Hikari takes her hand and guides it, letting Rebecka feel the textures—the velvet edge, the mesh, the lace hem. Rebecka’s breath catches on the bat pattern. “That’s adorable,” she says, reverent. “And very you.”

Hikari’s phone: a chime, pleased.

[TTS] look two?

Alice gasps. “There’s a look two?”

Hikari disappears down the hallway, swish of silk, candlelight flicker. Niklas exhales for the first time in a minute. “I am extremely behaved,” he says to no one.

“You’re doing great,” Rebecka murmurs, amused.

When Hikari returns, it’s a small shift with big effect: the robe is gone; the choker is tied a touch tighter; the mesh shrug sleeves pushed to mid-forearm. The high-waist shorts now sit under a thin garter skirt—a wisp of shadow that sways when she breathes. Same coverage, new attitude.

She stops in front of Niklas and looks up. He stands automatically, taller shadow over small comet. She taps her screen.

[TTS] moonman. help with clasp next time?

He nods, heart in his throat. “If you want me to.”

She leans in just enough for the ring at her throat to tap softly against his sternum. Then she turns and walks to Rebecka, who reaches out; Hikari places the ring in Rebecka’s palm for a second, cool metal warming. A pass, not a transfer. Offered, not taken.

Lastly, she faces Alice. Alice does a tiny bow, then whispers, “Final pose?” Hikari mirrors her bow, then does a neat pivot, weight on one hip, chin tilted—a little cartoon villain, a lot of queen.

[TTS] scoring?

Alice pretends to think. “Eleven out of ten bats.”

“Eleven,” Rebecka agrees.

Niklas smiles. “Eleven.”

Hikari’s shoulders sink with relief and pride. She pads to the couch and climbs onto it sideways, tucking toes under Niklas’ thigh like a claim to warmth. Alice drapes the silk robe over her lap like a cape. Rebecka hands her a square of dark chocolate and taps the playlist louder by a breath.

[TTS] runway closed. cuddle hour open.

“Best event,” Alice says, melting in beside her.

Rebecka finds Hikari’s foot and squeezes, gentle. “For the record,” she murmurs, “ghost violet is now a holiday.”

Niklas looks at the choker ring catching candlelight, at the bats fluttering when Hikari giggles through the phone, at the soft, wicked, entirely-Hikari silhouette nestled between them.

“We’ll celebrate it every year,” he says.

Hikari taps one last time, and the phone’s voice is clear, sly, happy:

[TTS] or every week. let’s do every week.

Chapter 13
Twenty-Two Candles

The morning sun in Tokyo came in shy and gold, slanting across the tiny apartment like it knew it was intruding on something sacred. Hikari sat cross-legged on the couch in a black tulle skirt, a lace choker, and a tiny silver crown barrette clipped to her bangs. Her phone lay in her lap with the text-to-speech app open, the cursor blinking like a heartbeat.

On the coffee table: a strawberry shortcake with twenty-two tiny silver candles in a spiral, waiting.

"Don't light them yet! I need five minutes to make this perfect," Alice said, darting between counter and table with the precision of a stagehand and the energy of a confetti cannon. She'd dressed in mellow goth for Hikari—charcoal blouse, ribboned cuffs, a velvet bow clipped near her ear—subtle, sweet, and very Alice.

Niklas, already enormous in the kitchen's narrow light, set down a plate of dorayaki he'd griddled himself. "Backup dessert," he said. "In case the candles turn the cake into a war zone."

Rebecka's fingers hovered over the paper plates, counting through the embossed rims. "I like the sound the sugar makes when Alice moves the box," she said with a smile—the bakery air still clung to the cake's box, whispering with every shift. "It's like… a soft snow."

Hikari typed; the phone spoke in the warm contralto she'd tuned to match her streaming persona. "Today, the snow belongs to me."

They sang—off-key and full-hearted. Alice lit the candles in a fast circle, and Rebecka took Hikari's hands, guiding them to the cake so she could feel the tiny warmths before she blew. Hikari inhaled, cheeks puffing, and extinguished them in one breath. A curl of smoke rose and vanished.

"Make a wish," Niklas said.

Hikari typed, eyes lowered. "I wish to keep this. You three. Like a charm I never lose."

Alice pressed their foreheads together; Rebecka slid arms around both of them; Niklas leaned across and tapped the crown barrette so it chimed against her hairpin. The cake was cut—too generous slices—and coffee poured, and then it was coats and shoes and out into the city.

They spent the afternoon doing Hikari things.

At the arcade, Niklas braced the crane machine like he was prepping a server rack for a stress test. "Physics says impossible," he muttered, then coaxed a plush bat into the chute. He held it out. "For the birthday queen."

Hikari's phone said, "I accept this minion," and she tucked the bat under one arm like a tiny, winged scepter.

Purikura was chaos. Alice orchestrated poses—gothic, silly, claws up, hearts—and Rebecka read the rhythm of the shutter by the machine's cheerful countdown, catching each click with an easy tilt of her head. They decorated the prints with pixel stars and the words "Hikari 22" and a lopsided bat doodle that Niklas insisted was "art."

At a café, they took the booth by the window. Rebecka traced the raised pattern on the menu while Alice read aloud in a gentle rush. Niklas ordered a set of tiny parfaits "because tasting menu is just diplomacy," and Hikari listened to the way her friends argued over spoons and laughed. She didn't need to say much—she just typed:

"Today, I am full. Not of cake. Of you."

Evening softened to violet. They took the train two stops to the river; lanterns bobbed and the water carried a ribbon of city light. Alice slipped a pendant across Hikari's neck—a little onyx moon in a filigree setting that matched her choker.

"It's from a local maker," Alice said. "I thought… night suits you."

Hikari typed, then lifted the phone so the voice would be heard over the water. "Night keeps secrets. I keep promises."

Rebecka's gift came in a palm-sized box tied with linen string. Inside: a set of touch-coded dice carved from smooth wood, each pip replaced by a tiny symbol Hikari could feel—stars for one, hearts for two, little bats for three. "For game nights," Rebecka said, cheeks pink with pride. "So the table is always fair."

Hikari slid the bat die into her pocket like a talisman. She typed: "I love clever."

Niklas waited, then produced his own offering with a sheepish shrug: a black hooded cardigan with subtle embroidered constellations along the inside hem—hidden unless you swirled it. "For when the AC in your streaming room has no mercy," he said. "Also… secret stars."

Hikari laughed without sound and typed, "Dragon boy understands theatrics," and pulled it on immediately, the inner stars brushing her thighs when she turned.

They ate ramen at a place that knew them by nods alone. Hikari's bowl came extra garlicky; Alice declared she would never kiss anyone again for twenty minutes; Rebecka timed it. Niklas added an egg to each bowl without asking, the way he always did, like quietly tucking comfort into a day.

By the time they reached karaoke, Hikari's crown had tilted. They rented a private booth. The setlist was chaos again—goth rock into glitter pop into a sweeping ballad that made Rebecka close her eyes and hum the harmony. Hikari didn't sing; she let her phone speak her "lyrics," scrolling lines with a showman's timing so her persona's voice rode the melody in a strange, beautiful duet. Alice filmed ten seconds and then put the phone away, choosing tonight for memory, not metrics.

At the end, they didn't need to discuss where they were going. The city knew too, in that way a city does when nights tighten to a point. They walked beneath neon that bled roses and ice onto the pavement, Hikari's tiny bat tucked in the crook of her arm, Rebecka's hand easy on Hikari's shoulder, Alice swinging their joined fingers between them, Niklas a steady warmth at their side.

The love hotel rose like a whimsical castle—curtains in every window, soft light, a tastefully ridiculous sign. Alice stifled a giggle; Rebecka squeezed Hikari's fingers twice; Niklas glanced down. "Happy birthday," he said, simple as a lock clicking open.

Hikari typed, and this time she didn't press play. She showed them the screen instead:

"Thank you for choosing me."

They stepped into the lobby together. The door hushed closed behind them, the city's noise dimming to a velvet hush. A rack of room themes gleamed—moons and libraries and starfields—Rebecka's fingertips skimmed the engraved braille labels and she smiled, choosing without hesitation.

When the lift arrived, they filed in, all four. Hikari leaned back into them, her crown finally straight, the onyx moon warm against her throat. The doors slid shut on laughter and a shared breath, and the night—obedient to wishes—kept their secrets.

Chapter 14
After the Deathmarch

The elevator dinged and Niklas spilled out like a felled tree—bag half open, hoodie damp with cold sweat, eyes glassy. He got the door to the apartment three quarters of the way open before his knees went soft.

Alice caught the bag, Hikari caught him.

Well—Hikari stepped into him and took the weight with both arms, small body braced, and the rest of it was momentum and stubbornness. She nudged him inside with her hip while her phone on a lanyard chirped, [Lock the door please.]

Rebecka found the keys by sound—the little brass jingle against the threshold—and slid the deadbolt home. “Nik?” Her hand found his wrist. His pulse hammered.

He tried to joke. “I swear I was just…resting my eyes.”

“Uh-huh,” Alice said, breathless, guiding them toward the sofa. “And I’m the Queen of Sweden.” She lowered him with practiced grace. “Shoes off.”

Hikari pressed her forehead to his shoulder for one steadying second, then lifted it and typed: [Dehydrated. Overheated. Probably ran on caffeine fumes and spite. I love both but not for you.] The phone’s synth voice was crisp and bossy in the quiet.

“Got it,” Rebecka said. She was already in the kitchen by memory, fingers laying out glasses by touch, the soft notes of cupboard doors like a metronome. “Electrolytes?”

“In the blue tin behind the ramen,” Alice called.

Niklas tried to sit up. Hikari’s palm landed on his sternum: light, decisive. [Down. Dragon slayer privileges revoked.]

He snorted, tried to protest, and then the fight went out of him all at once. He lay back, enormous in their little living room, the veins at his temples easing.

Alice knelt and tugged at his laces. “These feel like they’re welded on. Babe, how many hours?”

He stared at the ceiling. “I… lost count after thirty-six? Release train. Pager. Jenkins hated me personally.”

“Jenkins can get in line,” Alice said, voice softening as she freed one foot, then the other. “Okay. Feet up.” She slid a folded blanket under his calves. “Hikari, cool cloth?”

Hikari was already there, a bowl of water and a towel conjured from nowhere. [Yes, dear maid.] The phone added a tiny wink sound effect. She wrung the towel and laid it over his forehead, fingers lingering in his hair. He closed his eyes and blew out a shaky breath.

Rebecka arrived with a glass, then another. She held one to his lips; her other hand cupped his jaw, thumb learning the rasp of stubble. “Small sips, Nik.” The lemon-salt mix hit his tongue and his throat worked, greedy despite himself.

“Thank you,” he murmured.

Hikari typed, [Ten minutes of sips. Then carbs and protein. Ramen or rice porridge?]

“Ramen,” Niklas whispered, automatically, and they all smiled because of course.

Alice straightened. “Chef rotation: Hikari, you do broth magic; I’ll soft-boil eggs and slice the pork; Becks, can you do spring onions and nori?”

Rebecka’s grin was feline. “I will also not attempt pancakes.”

“Mercy,” Niklas croaked.

They moved like a tiny kitchen brigade. The sounds were home: water coming to a hush, the whisper of a knife on a board, Hikari's phone occasionally voicing a timed alert—[Eggs out. Ice bath. Noodles in thirty seconds.]—and Alice's gentle patter as she cleaned as she went. Rebecka narrated her station like a radio host for Niklas' benefit, blades tapping, scallions scattering under her fingertips.

On the coffee table, Hikari set out a small bowl of rice crackers. [Rule: one cracker per five sips. No cheating.]

"Bossy," he said, but his mouth obeyed, and color crawled back into his face.

While the broth simmered, Alice slipped a hand under the hem of his hoodie. "Permission to do the mom check?"

"Granted."

Her palm was cool against his belly. "You're warm but not scary. Breathing's even." She leaned close, voice lower. "If the dragon scratches, we'll ground you. Promise."

His eyes flicked to hers with something like apology. "It won't," he said, quiet. "Not with you here."

Rebecka re-tucked the towel. "We believe you. And we're here if you're wrong."

Ten minutes later, Hikari presented the bowl like a priestess at an altar. The broth was dark and glossy; the egg revealed a perfect, trembling heart. She set it on a cork mat and typed, [Careful hot. Eat slowly. If you faint into it I will be cross and also post the picture.]

"Threats and incentives," Alice approved.

He ate. The first mouthful was almost obscene in how it rewired him: salt and fat and warmth sinking into hollow places. He went glassy-eyed again, but this time with relief. "Oh," he said, and then, earnest, "I don't deserve you."

Rebecka leaned on the arm of the sofa and kissed his temple. "We disagree."

They rotated care with the same unspoken choreography. Alice massaged his forearms, finding each knot and working it apart; Hikari braided his damp hair to keep it off his neck, her phone saying, [You look like a Viking prince on sick leave.] Rebecka perched on the floor by his knee and read him the silliest blurbs from the noodle package in a solemn librarian voice until he laughed for real.

After the bowl was empty and the world had steadied, Alice tugged his hoodie up and replaced it with a soft tee. "Bed. Now."

He made a fuzzy protest about bothering them, work emails, duty. Hikari typed, [Your duty is to sleep.] Then added, [We filed a ticket: P1—Critical—Boyfriend down. ETA to resolution: 10 hours horizontal.]

They shepherded him to the bedroom. Rebecka clicked the blackout curtains closed; Alice set his phone on Do Not Disturb and slid it across the room; Hikari placed a glass of water within reach and knelt, eyes level with his.

[If you wake disoriented, look at me. Then breathe with me. In four. Out six.]

He nodded, throat tight.

They layered in around him like a constellation, careful with heat and weight. Alice tucked herself at his back, one arm around his ribs so he could feel the measured rise and fall of her breathing. Rebecka found his hand and twined their fingers, thumb spelling slow circles into his palm. Hikari lay on his chest, light as a cat, her phone face-down; she didn't need the voice for this. Her pulse ticked steady against his sternum.

"Älskling," he mumbled, Swedish snagged on sleep. "Förlåt… jag pressade för långt."

"Forgiven," Alice murmured. "Also, next time you tell us before the deathmarch, ok? We'll plan."

Rebecka squeezed his hand. "We'll pack snack boxes with little labels. 'Spite' is not a snack."

Hikari lifted the phone one last time. [We're your cooldown. That's the pact.]

He closed his eyes. The dragon, if it stirred, found a thumb on its nose, a hand on its jaw, a melody of three heartbeats around it. The apartment settled, the kind of quiet with edges rounded off. His breath evened—and held there, soft and sure.

In the morning, they'd field his emails in triage, put a lock on his calendar, stage an intervention with coffee and boundaries. They'd tease him about the braid, feed him fruit, draft a sane sprint plan on sticky notes.

For now, the only sprint that mattered was the one his body was running back to himself. And his team—his little, stubborn, ridiculous team—kept pace beside him in sleep.

Chapter 15
The Truth About Tomorrow

Scene 1 — "I should have said this sooner"

Niklas had just set two mugs on the kotatsu—one jasmine, one black tea with too much honey—when Hikari tapped her phone. The familiar little chime, then her voice from the speaker: soft, bell-glass clear, and not quite hers.

"I need to tell you something serious."

He sat, the floor cushion sighing under his weight. "Okay."

Her thumbs paused over the screen, then fluttered. The phone spoke: "I am infertile."

He didn't reach for the mug. He didn't reach for her either, not yet. He just nodded once, the kind of nod you give a truth that has already been living in the room for a while.

"Thank you for telling me," he said, voice low. "Are you… how are you with that?"

She typed again, slower. "I grieved it. A long time ago. But it is still part of me."

He finally slid his palm across the table, stopping with his fingertips resting against the edge of her sleeve—a question mark made of skin. She turned her wrist so their fingers could meet.

"I should have talked to you about this before," he said. "To all of you. I… under no circumstances do I want children." The words came out clean and heavy, like stones he'd been carrying. "Even though I doubt I can have them anyway, I should have said it. I'm sorry I didn't. If that's a dealbreaker… I understand."

Her phone spoke after a long breath. "Thank you for saying it clearly."

He exhaled like he'd been holding air since his teens. "I'm not saying it to shut doors on you. I'm saying it so you don't build futures around something I can't give. I want a life with you—quiet mornings, loud karaoke nights, too much takeout, growing old in black clothes like two stubborn crows. But not parenting."

Her thumbs moved. "I don't want to parent either. Not humans." A tiny pause, then a new line: "Maybe cats."

He huffed a laugh, shoulders loosening. "Cats are negotiable. Highly."

She squeezed his fingers, then typed again. "We should tell the others together. Not because I'm ashamed. Because we are a 'we.'"

"Yeah," he said. "Tonight?"

She nodded.

He finally lifted his mug. The tea had gone lukewarm. Somehow, it tasted perfect.

Scene 2 — "What we mean by family"

They gathered in the living room like they always did for big talks: lights soft, phones face-down, comfort within reach. Rebecka traced the rim of her cup to orient herself, a white cane resting against the sofa arm. Alice folded her legs underneath her on the rug, apron from the café still tied at her waist, eyeliner a little smudged from the late shift. Hikari sat between them, one knee bouncing in a tight rhythm that only slowed when Alice tucked a hand over her shin.

Niklas didn't pace. He wanted to. Instead he sat opposite, back straight, both hands around his mug as if it could anchor him.

Hikari tapped the first sentence, then turned the screen so everyone could see before she played it. “I told Niklas earlier: I am infertile.”

Alice’s eyes went wide, then soft. “Oh, honey.” She leaned in and Hikari leaned back, cheek bumping Alice’s forehead in their practiced almost-hug.

Rebecka inhaled, gentle but audible. “Thank you for trusting us,” she said. “Do you want to talk about it?”

Hikari typed. “I am okay. It’s old grief for me. But it matters for us.”

Niklas cleared his throat. “And I need to add something. I should’ve said it sooner. I don’t want children. Under any circumstances.” He kept his gaze steady, moving from Alice to Rebecka and back. “That’s not about any of you. It’s just true about me. I’m sorry I didn’t put it on the table from the start. If that changes things for you… I’ll respect that.”

Silence settled, respectful rather than heavy.

Alice was first. She fiddled with the ribbon at her apron, then let it go. “I… used to picture being a mom because I thought that’s what you do.” She smiled, a little crooked. “Then I met you three, and the picture changed. I want late-night costume crunches and cons and naps tangled up and… us. I don’t need a baby to feel like my life is full. I’d rather be the cool aunt to everyone else’s kids and the embarrassing cat mom to too many cats.”

“Too many?” Niklas said, deadpan.

“Statistically irresponsible,” Alice said, solemn, which made Hikari snort through her nose, a small whistle.

Rebecka turned her head toward Niklas’ voice. “I appreciate the honesty. I won’t lie—when I was little, I imagined a big noisy family because I grew up with a quiet house and I thought noise meant love.” She folded her hands on her knees. “But I also know I want to be a librarian more than anything. I want to build a home that is safe and kind. I don’t need children for that. I do want to keep space in my life to mentor—interns, kids who need reading buddies, people who think books are closed doors. That’s important to me.”

“That sounds… wonderful,” Niklas said. “I can show up for that.”

Hikari typed: “Chosen family. Not smaller. Just different.”

Alice nodded. “Different like… Sunday pancake tradition, but without burning the kitchen, Niklas.”

“I apologized. Repeatedly.”

Rebecka smiled. “You did. The smoke alarm forgave you eventually.”

Hikari’s next line arrived with a delicate mechanical lilt: “Boundaries. We should set them now. So we don’t hurt each other later.”

Alice lifted her hand. “Okay, proposal:

We’re a child-free household.

If anyone’s feelings change—ever—we bring it up right away, no simmering.

We still get to pour love into little humans if we want, just not as parents: nieces, nephews, library kids, café regulars, neighbor gremlins.

We adopt cats when the landlord finally blinks.”

“Seconded,” Rebecka said, amused. “Also, can we add: we allow grief to exist if it pops up unexpectedly. For any of us.”

Hikari typed: “Yes. Grief allowed.” Then a second line: “And celebrations allowed. For what we choose.”

All eyes drifted to Niklas. He hadn't realized he'd been bracing until his shoulders dropped. "I agree to all of that," he said. "And I promise to keep saying this out loud so it never becomes one of those unspoken landmines."

Alice scooted around the table and pressed her temple to his shoulder. "Thank you for trusting us to still choose you."

He let out a breath that almost became a laugh. "You're the ones choosing me? Have you met me?"

"Yes," Rebecka said, warm. "We are very familiar with your dramatics around burnt pancakes."

Hikari typed, and the phone played the last line with that soft, precise cadence: "We choose each other. That's the point."

No one clapped or made a toast. They didn't need to. Alice reached to lace her fingers with Hikari's. Rebecka found Niklas' free hand and held it, light but certain. In the center of the table, four mugs steamed, and for a long, quiet minute, the only sound in the room was the small click of Hikari's keyboard as she added one more note to their shared chat: "Cat names brainstorm starts tomorrow."

Chapter 16
A Swedish Knock at the Door

The door buzzer chirped and then came the rhythmic knock-knock—pause—knock that Niklas had grown up with. He'd barely turned the handle before his mother wedged a tote into the gap and his father's arms were already around him, laughing in that quiet, chesty way that always made everything feel lighter.

"Min pojke," his mother said, pressing his cheeks between her palms. "You look tired. Eat first, argue later."

"Hi, mamma. Hej, pappa." He half-laughed, half-groaned as the tote's weight dropped into his hands. It smelled like cardamom and home.

They tumbled in on a gust of November air—coats, scarves, a bouquet that had clearly been arranged on the airplane tray table, and another tote that clinked with coffee packets and something wrapped in crinkly paper.

"Shoes off!" Niklas remembered too late that he didn't need to say it; his father already had one socked foot in the air.

The girls were waiting in the living room. Hikari sat cross-legged on the rug with a little speaker beside her phone, glossy black hair pinned back with a bat-shaped clip. Alice hovered near the kitchen, apron still on from a last-minute cookie rescue, her curls bouncing with nerves. Rebecka had her hands folded over her white cane, chin lifted toward the sound of the door.

Niklas' mother stopped. Her eyes softened as though someone had turned down the world and turned up only what mattered. She didn't ask who was who. She simply stepped in, hands open and visible, and offered a smile large enough to sit on.

"Hello. I'm Karin," she said, in careful English that warmed the room. "May I hug you? If not, I have … cookies."

Alice let out a little squeak and nodded, almost tripping over her own feet as she leaned in. "Hi! I'm Alice. Yes, please. Also—cookies is a yes."

Karin's hug was the kind that fit around a person's worry and held it together. When she drew back she reached into the tote and pressed a tin into Alice's hands. "Kanelbullar. They survived twelve hours and one nosy security dog. Do not tell customs."

Alice fanned the lid, inhaled, and made a sound that was half-gasp, half-prayer. "Oh my—these are illegal."

"Only in Britain," Niklas' father said, reaching for a handshake and accidentally offering both hands at once. "I'm Anders. I do bad jokes and useful shelves. If you have a shelf that is not behaving, I will have words with it."

Alice's laugh bubbled out. "We have a rebellious spice rack."

"Ha! An upstart," Anders said, deeply serious. "We will negotiate."

Karin turned to Rebecka next, slowing her steps. "Hej, Rebecka. May I stand here?" She tapped her knuckles gently against the tin so the soft ring gave a sense of distance and space. When Rebecka nodded, Karin took her hand and squeezed.

"Hi, Karin," Rebecka said, a little breathless. "It's so nice to meet you."

"I brought something for you," Karin said. She guided Rebecka's fingers to a folded knit, a plum-colored shawl with a raised braid pattern. "I like making textures that tell their own story. If you don't like it, pretend for ten minutes and then give it to a dog."

Rebecka stroked the braid and smiled so bright it was audible. “It’s perfect. I can read it. Thank you.”

“Good,” Karin murmured, eyes shining. “I also brought cinnamon buns, which are not textured but are very persuasive.”

Anders had already bowed far too deep to Hikari, realized, and added a second bow, equally deep, as if to average them out. He straightened, embarrassed and grinning.

“Sorry—eh—hello. Hikari?” he asked, glancing to Niklas.

Hikari lifted her phone. The little speaker chimed and then her voice, soft and bell-like, filled the space: “Hello, Anders. Hello, Karin. It’s very nice to meet you.”

Karin’s gaze flicked to the phone, then back to Hikari’s eyes. She didn’t flinch at the text-to-speech. She nodded as if someone had simply chosen a different instrument to play the same melody. “Your voice is lovely,” she said. “May I hug you, too? Or would you prefer a hand hold? Or just buns?”

Hikari’s mouth curved. She extended both hands. Karin squeezed them, then surprised Hikari by producing a small velvet box. Inside lay two tiny silver moon studs and a matching charm shaped like a bat.

“I saw your little bat,” Karin said. “Thought he might like a friend.”

Hikari typed; the speaker purred: “He will be delighted.” She clipped the charm to her collar and tilted her head toward Niklas, eyes laughing.

Anders clapped once, decisive. “Right. Fika. Where is your coffee machine, son? It must work hard today.”

“It’s on the counter,” Niklas said, his voice taking on a depth that meant relief. He caught Alice’s eye, then Rebecka’s, then Hikari’s, and each of them breathed a little easier—like the room had learned to expand.

The kitchen became a choreography of inherited kindness. Karin washed her hands with a nurse’s efficiency and began plating buns, slicing apples, producing a small jar of cloudberry jam as if it were rare medicine. Anders assembled the traveling pour-over contraption he swore was superior to all machines and quizzed Alice about sugar ratios like a scientist plotting a delicate experiment.

“You cosplay, yes?” he asked between pours. “I saw the photos Niklas sent. The armor with the wings—fantastic.”

Alice blinked. “He… he sent you those?”

“Of course,” Anders said. “We brag. It’s the parental way. Do you make the costumes?”

“All of them.” Her shoulders straightened almost imperceptibly. “Sewing, foam, resin—the works.”

“Then you must help me with a secret,” he said, leaning in like a conspirator. “I have a Dala horse that needs a tiny saddle for a joke present. No one tell Karin.”

“I heard that,” Karin said, passing a plate to Rebecka.

Rebecka giggled and accepted the cup Anders guided to her hand. “This smells amazing.”

“Fresh ground,” Anders said, and then, gentler, “Cup is at two o’clock, handle toward you.”

“Thank you,” she said. “You’re… very good at this.”

“My wife is a nurse,” he said with pride. “I am trained to not be in the way.”

Karin rolled her eyes fondly and turned to Hikari with a small bag. “May I?” At Hikari’s nod, she set the bag by the phone. “Throat lozenges. Honey-ginger. I don’t know if they help your… set-up, but they help me when I talk too much.” She winked.

Hikari’s speaker chimed: “I like honey. Thank you.”

They gathered around the low table. The first bite of bun made everyone go quiet—cinnamon, cardamom, butter. November sighed against the window while warmth pooled in the corners of the room.

"So," Karin said, lifting her coffee, "tell me your stories. Not all of them—we will be here all week—but the parts you want us to know today."

What followed came out in threads. Alice talked about the maid café and how she deflected weird customers with weaponized politeness. Rebecka shared her dream of working in a library, her fingers unconsciously tracing the raised braid of the shawl as she spoke. Hikari typed sentences like stepping stones: streaming at night, a persona that gave her room to be large, and the odd safety of speaking through a small machine.

Karin asked the kind of questions that had no edge. Anders threw in jokes like pebbles skipped across a lake—never deep enough to sink, always enough to make ripples of laughter.

Eventually, Niklas cleared his throat. "I should have told you both sooner," he said, glancing at each of the girls, "about… us. I'm sorry. I was scared you'd—"

Karin reached across the table and put a hand on his wrist. "We raised you to love well," she said simply. "Look at these faces. You chose very well."

Anders nodded. "Also, I have built things in wilder circumstances. We can build a shelf for love, too."

"Pappa," Niklas groaned, but his eyes were wet.

Karin tapped her glass with her spoon. "One practical thing," she said, nurse-voice returning. "If anyone ever gets sick, I am remote triage at any hour. And if anyone ever needs to talk, I am nosy at any hour."

Alice sniffed. "We might kidnap you."

"Only if you feed us," Anders said. "This jam is not infinite."

They ate; they talked; time softened. The rebellious spice rack confessed its crimes and Anders, true to his word, fixed it with a lecture and two screws. Karin taught Alice a trick for pinning slippery fabric. She and Rebecka swapped soup recipes that were more loyalty than liquid. Hikari showed Karin how to add custom words to the TTS dictionary, and soon "Karin" no longer came out like "carrion," which caused everyone about three minutes of undignified laughter.

Before the light fully failed, Anders set up his phone on a stack of cookbooks for a group photo. "Close, close," he said, waving them in. "I want to see all your faces. Yes, even yours, Niklas, stop hiding behind the tall."

Hikari nestled under Karin's arm; Alice tucked under Niklas' other side; Rebecka stood between Anders and Niklas, her hand touching everyone's sleeve like a constellation drawn by contact.

The timer chirped.

For one ridiculous second nobody was ready. Anders was still laughing, Alice had cinnamon sugar at the corner of her mouth, Hikari had turned toward Karin at the last moment, and Rebecka's hand rested across three different sleeves as though making certain everyone was still there.

The camera caught them anyway.

Niklas stared at the photograph.

He remembered a rainy hallway. A white cane lying across the carpet. A woman shivering against a door. "Just a neighbor," he'd told Alice that night.

Somewhere between then and now, there had been ramen and terrible pancakes. First dates and frightened conversations. Karaoke and graveyard lights. Love hotels and ordinary Tuesdays. Three

women had learned him well enough to know when he needed holding, and he had learned that being needed was not the same thing as being alone.

His mother leaned over his shoulder.

"Good," Karin said. "Now we have proof."

"Proof of what?" Alice asked.

Karin slid the phone across the table so they all could feel the moment captured there, each in their own way.

"Family," she said. "Obviously."

Four people. Four ways of loving. One home they build together.

In Tokyo, Niklas thinks being a good neighbour simply means helping when help is needed. Then a rainy hallway brings Rebecka into his life, and one act of kindness begins changing all of theirs.

Rebecka is blind, quietly stubborn, and determined to become a librarian. Hikari is mute, sharp-minded, and powerful behind the gothic voice she built for herself. Alice turns cosplay, humour, and fierce loyalty into an art form. Niklas, a Swedish systems developer far from home, is drawn into their orbit one careful yes at a time.

Ramen becomes a first date. Quiet nights become shared rituals. The four of them learn to make room for desire, boundaries, fear, family, and the ordinary tenderness of choosing each other again and again.

Romance in the Land of the Setting Sun — Book One is a warm, intimate story about polyamory, accessibility, found family, and love built through care rather than assumption.

Care first. Words first. Then everything else.